

Route diversions announced ahead of PM’s visit to Noida airport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

The Gautam Buddh Nagar Traffic Police has issued a detailed advisory ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visit to Noida International Airport on March 28. Noida Police officials have advised commuters to follow designated routes and avoid unnecessary travel near the venue to ensure the smooth conduct of the high-profile event.

According to Noida Police officials, the entry routes and parking zones have been marked. Vehicles from Meerut and Ghaziabad will be

routed via the Eastern Peripheral Expressway, while those from Mathura and Aligarh will take the Yamuna Expressway. Separate parking zones have been earmarked, including P-07 for Meerut and P-06 for Ghaziabad.

Commercial vehicles will be diverted, and goods vehicles will be restricted on the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway and surrounding roads from 7 am to 11 pm.

Emergency vehicles such as ambulances and fire services will have uninterrupted passage. Parking Arrangements: 15 parking facilities have been arranged for 14,700 heavy and medium

vehicles and 5,000 two-wheelers.

Traffic coming from Mathura and Aligarh via the Yamuna Expressway will exit at Jewar Cut and enter through Sabauta Underpass and Kishorpur Gate, with parking allocated in zones P-05, P-09 and P-11.

Vehicles from Hapur, Bulandshahr and nearby areas will be diverted along the Jewar-Khurja road and enter through Parohi Gate, with parking arranged in zones P-13 and P-14.

Dignitaries will access the venue through the dedicated Yamuna Expressway interchange and park in zones P-

01, P-02 and P-03, while media personnel will enter via Kishorpur Gate and park in P-08. Police, administrative staff and government employees on duty will also use the Kishorpur Gate, with parking designated at P-10, while official buses will be routed via Dayanantpur and parked in P-15.

Commuters from Noida and Greater Noida using the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway will be diverted through specified roundabouts and service roads before entering via a temporary gate near Ranehra Police Post, with parking mainly at P-07.

Vehicles from Greater Noida West and surrounding areas will be routed through Pari Chowk, while those from Dankaur and nearby regions will follow service roads and canal routes to designated entry points. Two-wheelers and light motor vehicles will be allowed entry through Kishorpur Gate with parking at P-04, while vehicles from Jewar town will use the same gate and park in P-12.

Commercial vehicles on the Jewar-Tappal route will be diverted towards Tappal, while those from Khurja heading to Jewar will be stopped at Khurja itself and redirected.

Government working to improve drinking water supply, sewer connectivity: Verma

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Friday said the State Government is working on a war footing to improve drinking water supply, sewer connectivity and cleaning the Yamuna River.

Giving a detailed presentation about steps taken in the Delhi assembly, he also highlighted the findings of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) report, exposing years of systemic failures in water management, sewer infrastructure, and Yamuna cleaning.

He also noted that during the assembly session, several MLAs raised concerns about water supply, sewer issues, and local infrastructure challenges in their constituencies, directly reflecting the grievances of citizens. However, the minister strongly criticised the absence of the opposition during such a critical discussion.

Delhi currently requires approximately 1200 MGD of water, while the supply stands at around 1000 MGD, creating a persistent gap. The Minister pointed out that, beyond supply constraints,



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“In most parts of the world, NRW losses are around 15 per cent. In Delhi, they crossed 50 per cent. This is not just leakage...it is a reflection of systemic failure,” he said.

He further highlighted that nearly 30 lakh households still lack formal water connections, leading to illegal usage, inefficiency, and revenue loss.

To improve water availability, an additional 36 MGD capacity is being added, major projects like Chandrawal and Wazirabad revived, and long-pending interstate water coordination strengthened.

As regards Yamuna cleaning, he said key steps include construction and upgradation of 35 STPs with global standards, expansion of treatment capacity to 1500 MGD for future needs, in-situ treatment of major drains including Najafgarh drain, and strict monitoring of sewage discharge and quality. He also announced that within 2 to 2.5 years, Delhi will have more treatment capacity than sewage generation, ensuring long-term sustainability.

Phansi-ghar row: Assembly issues warning to AAP leaders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Assembly on Friday issued a warning to AAP leaders, including former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, regarding the ‘Phansi-ghar’ issue, based on a report from its Privileges Committee.

Speaker Vijender Gupta spoke about the “manufactured narrative” of a ‘Phansi-ghar’ within the assembly premises, stating that associating the famed building with an execution chamber is a disservice to its true history.

“The House is deliberating on this matter with absolute justice. The contempt has been proven. While no court in India can grant relief in matters of legislative privilege, we are proceeding based on the dignity of this institution,” a statement said.

A Privileges Committee report, which was tabled in the assembly on March 23, was discussed in the House. Following the discussion, the House addressed a motion proposed by BJP MLA Jintendra Mahajan.

Mahajan recommended issuing a warning to Kejriwal and other AAP leaders for showing contempt by failing to appear before the committee. The motion was second-



ed by ruling party MLA Raj Kumar Bhatia, and the House ultimately passed it via a voice vote.

The Phansi-ghar was inaugurated in the assembly by Kejriwal, in the presence of

then deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia, speaker Ram Niwas Goel and deputy speaker Rakhi Birla, on August 9, 2022.

The Speaker criticised the neglect of Delhi’s rural

martyrs while “fake stories” of execution rooms were being circulated. After the BJP took power in Delhi in February of the previous year, the issue was raised in the assembly, with Speaker Gupta labelling it a “tiffin room” rather than a gallows where freedom fighters were hanged.

“A third report from the committee will specifically address the lies spread regarding the Phansi-ghar. The assembly secretariat and the Committee of Privileges would ensure that the sanctity of the House is never compromised by misinformation or the defiance of officials,” the statement added.

Concerns raised by MLAs to be resolved by officers: Speaker

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta assured members on Friday that the issues they raised through special mentions in the House would be properly addressed and resolved by the concerned officers.

During the budget session, several MLAs from the ruling BJP expressed frustration that matters they raised through special mentions were either unanswered or

only partially addressed, often without offering any solutions.

Jangpura MLA Tarvinder Singh Marwah pointed out the absence of officers in the gallery, lamenting that it indicated a lack of seriousness towards the issues raised in the House.

Raj Kumar Bhatia, MLA from Adarsh Nagar, highlighted that replies from various departments often failed to provide solutions to the issues raised by legislators.



“Sometimes the response states that the matter is not related to our department, much like RTI replies. If that is the case, who will address these issues?” he questioned.

Speaker Gupta responded that clear instructions had been given to the officers. He encouraged members who were dissatisfied with the replies they received to inform him.

“The procedure is that such replies are sent to the Committee on Questions and References, which summons officers and the MLA concerned for resolution of the issue,” he said.

Timarpur MLA Surya Prakash Khatri claimed that replies were frequently not provided,

often due to trivial technical reasons.

The speaker suggested that MLAs directly present the issues from their constituencies, rather than framing them in question form, to facilitate timely resolutions.

He mentioned that the assembly would engage in discussions with officers regarding the legislators’ objections before handing over the matters to the Questions and References Committee.



SOUTH EASTERN COALFIELDS LIMITED
“A MINI RATNA COMPANY”

SECL/BSP/GM/EE/2026/763
Date: 26.03.2026

Notification for engagement of Full time Advisor (Finance), in SECL on fixed tenure basis.

South Eastern Coalfields Limited (Subsidiary of Coal India Limited) invites application for engagement of one Advisor (Finance) in SECL from retired executives of CIL & its subsidiaries, PSUs/autonomous organizations of Central/State governments Officers of class-C and above of Central & state Govt. (Non-clerical) & members of National level professional institutions on fixed tenure basis for an initial period of two year which may be extended further, as per CIL policy for engagement of Advisor's depending upon the requirement and satisfactory performance.

The Application Form and detailed notification can be seen and downloaded from SECL website www.secl-cil.in under the caption Career. Interested candidates fulfilling the criteria may submit their application in prescribed format with supporting documents to the “Office of GM(HR), Executive Establishment Department, South Eastern Coalfields Limited, Seepat Road, Bilaspur, Chhatisgarh, Pin 495006, latest by (15 days before the date of notification) by 09.04.2026, 5.00 pm by Registered Post/Speede-mail in mail id - gmhr.ee.secl@coalindia.in. Applications received after stipulated time will not be considered and the company will not be responsible for any postal delay/loss in transit in submission of application within specified time.

PUBLIC NOTICE

M/s. ALC Arora Industrial Park Pvt. Ltd. registered office 106, First Floor, Plot no 76-77, Vinayak Complex, Vijay Block, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi – 110092, India
Corporate office SCO no 38-39, District One, Sector – 68, Adjoining MC Office, SAS Nagar (Mohali), Punjab – 160062
www.aroraindcorp.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

M/s. ALC Arora Industrial Park Pvt. Ltd. is registered the following accounts in Kotak Mahindra Bank Ltd., Sector 70, Mohali Branch, for the project namely “Arora Industrial Park” for an area measuring 29.525 acres situated at village Kundli, Tehsil Rai, Sector 47, District Sonapat.

NAME	ALC ARORA INDUSTRIAL PARK PVT. LTD. -ARORA INDUSTRIAL PARK- COLLECTION A/C	Master Collection Account - 100%
A/C NO	7349492817	
IFSC	KKKB0004089	

NAME	ALC ARORA INDUSTRIAL PARK PVT. LTD. -ARORA INDUSTRIAL PARK-RERA A/C	Escrow Account - 70%
A/C NO	7349492794	
IFSC	KKKB0004089	

NAME	ALC ARORA INDUSTRIAL PARK PVT. LTD. -ARORA INDUSTRIAL PARK-TRANSACTION A/C	Free Account - 30%
A/C NO	7349492664	
IFSC	KKKB0004089	

PUBLIC NOTICE

M/s. Chandni Jain, Mr. Navin Jain & Mrs. Sakshi Jain have approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Sector-50, Noida, U.P. (Bank) to avail a Loan against mortgage of Property No. 004, (481 sq. mtrs.), Block-C, Sector-14, Noida, District, Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. after release of the same from Axis Finance Ltd where it is already mortgaged and have also represented that they are the absolute owners of the said property by virtue of Transfer Deed cum Sale Deed dated 09.05.2024 (Document No. 5032) executed by Mr. Rahul Bishnoi who was the mutatee in the record of Noida. If anybody, person, body corporate other than Axis Finance Ltd, has any right, lien, claim or objections whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 7 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate
GNA & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.



Office of the Superintending Engineer
3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh
Email: sepwdph@rediffmail.com

Letter No. : 1084/208C(Yata D)-03/2026
Dated : 24/03/2026

National Competitive E-Tender Notice

The Superintending Engineer 3rd Circle, Public Works Department, Pithoragarh invites tender through E-Tendering (Two Bid System) on behalf of Hon'ble Governor of Uttarakhand for following works. All other information will be available online from date 31-03-2026 at 5.00 PM onward on website <http://www.uktenders.gov.in>

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Earnest Money (in Lac)	Cost of Tender (₹)	Validity of Tender (day)	Period of Completion (months)	Contractor's Category of Registration
1	Hot -mix work on Kimtoli-Raushal motor road in Lohaghat Assembly of Champawat District under Hon'ble Chief Ministers announcement No. 143/2024, (Length: 20.00 km).	22.84	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	18	Category “A” for Road works in any State Govt./Govt. of India/Govt. undertaking.

SUPERIOR FINLEASE LIMITED
CIN: L74899DL1994PLC061995
Regd. Off: NS- 92, Khasra No-33/21, Ranaji Enclave, Najafgarh, Near Arjun Park Bus Stand New Delhi -110043; Email : superiorfinlease@gmail.com;
Website: <http://www.superiorfinlease.com> Phone No. : +91-9953798335

CORRIGENDUM CUM CLARIFICATION

This Corrigendum cum Clarification is being issued as a continuation of the Notice of Extra-Ordinary General Meeting (“EGM”) dated February 21, 2026, for the EGM held on Wednesday, 18th March, 2026, at 03:30 P.M. (IST) through Video-Conferencing (VC) / Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM), and in furtherance of the corrigendum submitted prior to the EGM on March 12, 2026. Except as specifically stated herein, all other contents of the Notice of EGM and the accompanying Explanatory Statement remain unchanged.

1. Background:

The Company had filed applications with the stock exchanges, namely BSE Limited (“BSE”) and Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India Limited (“MSE”), for seeking in-principle approval in relation to the proposed preferential issue of equity shares. A corrigendum was submitted to BSE prior to the EGM. The EGM was held on 18th March, 2026, and the Company has subsequently received observations from MSE after the conclusion of the EGM, pursuant to which the following changes have been executed in the EGM Notice.

2. Clarification:

- The details provided in the Explanatory Statement and the table of proposed allottees forming part of the Notice of EGM and the resolution, including the number of equity shares and total consideration, are correct.
- The typographical error pertains only to the issue size and corresponding amount were incorrectly stated as 11,64,159 (Eleven Lakh Sixty Four Thousand One Hundred Fifty Nine) equity shares, aggregating to ₹ 58,20,795/-. The correct issue size is 15,64,159 (Fifteen Lakh Sixty Four Thousand One Hundred Fifty Nine) equity shares, aggregating to ₹ 78,20,795/-.

3. Corrected Resolution No. 02:

Resolution NO. 02 shall be read as follows:

“RESOLVED THAT pursuant to the provisions of Sections 23, 42 and 62(1)(c) and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the Companies (Prospectus and Allotment of Securities) Rules, 2014, the Companies (Share Capital and Debentures) Rules, 2014 and other applicable rules made thereunder (including any statutory amendment/s), modification(s) or reenactment(s) thereof for the time being in force) (“Act”), the enabling provisions of the Memorandum of Association and Articles of Association of the Company and the applicable provisions of the SEBI (Issue of Capital and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2018, as amended (“SEBI ICDR Regulations”), SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (“SEBI LODR Regulations”) and subject to approvals, permissions and sanctions as may be necessary from regulatory authorities including Securities and Exchange Board of India, BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited and subject to such conditions as may be prescribed while granting such approvals, consent of the members of the Company be and is hereby accorded to create, offer, issue and allot on a preferential basis through private placement up to 15,64,159 (Fifteen Lakh Sixty Four Thousand One Hundred Fifty Nine) equity shares of face value of ₹ 1/- each at an issue price of ₹ 5/- per equity share (including premium of ₹ 4/- per share), aggregating up to ₹ 78,20,795/-, to the following persons belonging to non-promoter category, on such terms and conditions as may be determined by the Board.”

Sr. No.	Name of Allottees	Maximum number of Equity Shares	Maximum Amount (Rs)
1	RAM BHAGAT SHARMA	6,39,600	31,98,000
2	MANJU SHARMA	2,11,174	10,55,870
3	SURENDER KUMAR	2,00,000	10,00,000
4	AJAY KUMAR SINGH	1,00,000	5,00,000
5	RAVI KANT SHARMA	3,13,385	15,66,925
6	PUSPA KUMARI	1,00,000	5,00,000

RESOLVED FURTHER THAT the ‘Relevant Date’ for the purpose of determination of the floor price for issue of the Equity Shares under the Preferential Issue, as above, as per provisions of Chapter V of the SEBI ICDR Regulations and other applicable laws is Tuesday, February 17, 2026 (‘Relevant Date’), being the date 30 (Thirty) days prior to the date on which the meeting viz. an Extra-Ordinary General Meeting of members of the Company is proposed to be held to consider and approve the preferential issue.

RESOLVED FURTHER THAT subject to the receipt of requisite approvals as may be required under applicable law, consent of the members of the Company is hereby accorded to record the name and details of the identified investors/ allottees in Form PAS-5 and the Company be and is hereby authorized to make an offer to the identified investors/ allottees through Letter of Offer/ Private Placement Offer Letter cum application letter in Form PAS-4 or such other form as prescribed under the Act and SEBI ICDR Regulations containing the terms and conditions of the preferential issue (“Offer Document”) after passing of this resolution and upon receiving the applicable regulatory approvals and within the timelines prescribed under the applicable laws.

RESOLVED FURTHER THAT any director of the Company be and is hereby authorized to issue notice to call extraordinary general meeting and to submit necessary papers, documents, deeds if any and to comply with all mandatory compliances related to Registrar of Companies, Stock Exchange, wherever shares of the Company are listed and to take necessary approval from various authorities and to give effect to the foregoing resolution

For Superior Finlease Limited
Sd/
Rajneesh Kumar
(Director)
DIN: 02463693

Date: 27.03.2026
Place: New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

I Randhir Singh, Senior Manager, Punjab & Sind Bank Branch: Azadpur, hereby inform that Original Power of Attorney No. 6462 dated 25.06.2001 issued by Head Office of the Bank has been lost/misplaced. Finders may contact the nearest Police Station or the Bank and further this POA be treated as cancelled.

PUBLIC NOTICE

I Manish Kumar, Senior Manager, Punjab & Sind Bank Branch: Roshanpura, hereby inform that Original Power of Attorney No. 8226 dated 18.03.2019 issued by Head Office of the Bank has been lost/misplaced. Finders may contact the nearest Police Station or the Bank and further this POA be treated as cancelled.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER: PWD BUILDING:: ASSAM:: CHANDMARI : GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/05

CANCELLATION NOTICE

It is hereby informed to all concerned that the tenders invited vide Press Notice No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/04 dated 13th March, 2026 and Press Notice No. CE/TB-III(B)/10/2026/07 dated 13th March, 2026 stand cancelled due to unavoidable circumstances.

Chief Engineer, P.W.D.(Bldg.) Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DPR/C/PIO/1014/28-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (BLDG.): PW (B&NH) DEPTT.: CHANDMARI: GUWAHATI-3.

No. T/TB-1/14/2025/40

CANCELLATION NOTICE OF PRESS NOTICE (RE-TENDER)

This is for general information to all concerned that Press Notice (Re-tender) issued vide No.T/TB-1/14/2025/36 dated 13/03/2026 is hereby cancelled due to enforcement of Model Code of Conduct for Assam Legislative Assembly Election, 2026.

sd/-
Chief Engineer (Bldg.), P.W.(B&NH) Deptt., Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DPR/C/PIO/1013/28-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (BLDG.): PW (B&NH) DEPTT.: CHANDMARI: GUWAHATI-3.

No. T/TB-1/14/2025/40

CANCELLATION NOTICE OF PRESS NOTICE (RE-TENDER)

This is for general information to all concerned that Press Notice (Re-tender) issued vide No.T/TB-1/14/2025/36 dated 13/03/2026 is hereby cancelled due to enforcement of Model Code of Conduct for Assam Legislative Assembly Election, 2026.

sd/-
Chief Engineer (Bldg.), P.W.(B&NH) Deptt., Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DPR/C/PIO/1013/28-Mar-26

NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS

(SPECIAL WINDOW FOR RE-LODGEEMENT OF TRANSFER REQUESTS OF PHYSICAL SHARES)

Pursuant to SEBI circular no. HO/38/13(12)2026-MIRSD-POD/1/3750/2026MIRSD/MIRSD-PoD/P CIR/2025/97 dated January 30, 2026, the Company is pleased to offer one time special window for physical shareholders to submit re-lodgement requests for the transfer of shares. The special window will be open for a period of one year from February 05, 2026 till February 04, 2027 and is applicable to cases where original share transfer requests were lodged prior to April 01, 2019 and were rejected/returned due to deficiency in the documents, process or any other reason. The shares re-lodged for transfer will be processed only in dematerialization mode during this window. Eligible shareholders may submit their transfer requests along with the requisite documents to the company’s registrar and share transfer agent (RTA) at M/S Skyline Financial Services Private Limited within stipulated period.

By order of the Board of Directors
Prakash Woollen & Synthetic Mills Limited
Sd/-
(Vijay Kumar Gupta)
(Whole-Time Director)
Place: Vill. Amhera (Amroha) (Haryana)
Date: 26.03.2026
DIN: 00335325

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Sh. Umesh Kumar Maheshwari, owner of Plot No. 32, Area 0.50 Sq. Yds. Khasra No. 104/4/1, Rajia Puri, in Block-B, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Shriyankumar Srivastava vide notarized G.P.A., ATS and Will dated 18.03.2013 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any dispute with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760, Dwarika Court Sector-10, Dwarika, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Mrs. Sufiya Rahman is the owner of House Old No. 154B, New No. 136, area measuring 229 sq. yards, Ia., 191.46 sq. Mtrs situated at Patil Nagar Tehsil & Dist Meerut purchased by Mr. Sanjay Ramani in favour of Mrs. Sufiya Rahman in respect of said property and Mrs. Shajuar Rahman is the owner of House 3 rd Story, Government Quarter old no 14 CB, New no 136, area measuring 229 Sq. Yards, i.e. 191.47 Sq. Mtrs, situated at Mohalla Patil Nagar Colony South, Tehsil and District Meerut purchased by Mr. Sanjay Ramani in respect of said property and Mrs. Shajuar Rahman is the owner of House 3 rd Story, Government Quarter old no 14 CB, New no 136, area measuring 229 Sq. Yards, i.e. 191.47 Sq. Mtrs, situated at Mohalla Patil Nagar Colony South, Tehsil and District Meerut purchased by Mr. Sanjay Ramani in respect of said property and Mrs. Shajuar Rahman is the owner of House 3 rd Story, Government Quarter old no 14 CB, New no 136, area measuring 229 Sq. 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Commercial LPG shortages disrupt restaurant operations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Restaurants in the national Capital are “grappling” with an “inadequate supply of commercial LPG cylinders”, with many operators claiming that receiving one or two cylinders a day is insufficient to meet their requirements despite the Government increasing allocations.

The alleged shortage has disrupted the day-to-day functioning of eateries, with operators saying that inconsistent supply and inadequate allocation are affecting business viability.

A representative of the Greater Kailash-based Tadka Rani restaurant, which also has chains, claimed that the situation has worsened over the past few days with supply falling far short of demand.

“In the past 10 days, we have received just one cylinder, whereas we require around 13 cylinders per day across our three branches. We have been in touch with Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL). Initially, they said domestic consumers were their priority, but now they are at least engaging with us,” the representative said.

He added that the “shortage” has led to operational losses and forced businesses to make adjustments to survive.

“We are facing significant losses. We have modified recipes and reduced our menu to manage operations. Many restaurants have already shut down. We are still in survival mode and hoping for some relief in April,” he said.

Mohit, a staff member at



My Yellow Cafe in Shaikh Sarai, said the outlet has not received any LPG cylinders despite placing a request two weeks ago.

“We are currently relying on electric appliances, as we

have not received any cylinders yet. We are serving items that require minimal cooking. This has affected our services, and some regular customers, mostly students from nearby colleges, have

stopped coming due to limited menu options,” he said. Amit Gupta, general secretary of the New Delhi Traders’ Association, Connaught Place, claimed that restaurants are receiving

only a fraction of their requirement.

“Restaurants that require around 10 cylinders are getting just one, that too at a higher cost. Many are operating on electric appliances, which is not sustainable in the long run,” he said.

Similarly, a staff member at QBA in Connaught Place, Ravindra, said, “We are receiving LPG cylinders, but the supply remains inconsistent and far below our daily requirement. As a result, we are managing operations partly on gas and partly using electric cooking appliances. This has somehow affected the service.”

On the other hand, the Delhi Government, following the central government’s directive, has issued a modified allocation order, raising that restaurants by an

additional 20 per cent over the existing 50 per cent, restoring availability to 70 per cent of previous levels (6,300 cylinders of 19 kg daily from the normal consumption of 9,000), Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said on Friday.

He said after securing major allocations for hotels, restaurants, dhabas, food processing, dairies, 5 kg cylinders for migrant workers and students, supply to labour-intensive industries, including steel, automobile, textile (with dry cleaning), chemicals, plastics, sports facilities, glass, and pharma units, has been massively enhanced to 28.5 per cent (1,800 cylinders), especially where specialised heating cannot be substituted by PNG. Earlier conditions on OMC registration and PNG applications remain applicable,

except for these irreplaceable industrial uses.

The revised allocation order, building on Thursday’s 50 per cent update, strategically weights sectors: hospitality, restaurants, dhabas, food processing, and dairies secure (3,375 cylinders); industries (1,800); essential services like education, health, railways, airports, and buses (225); caterers/banquets (225); government institutions, trusts/PSUs/industrial canteens/subsidised community kitchen (225); sports facilities/stadiums (270); and migrant workers via 5kg refills (180), Sirsa said.

“Delhi’s industries and eateries can now operate without disruption, this 70 per cent allocation is a direct result of coordinated efforts at the Centre and state level,” he stated.

Major areas in north, central Delhi to face water shortage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chanakyapuri, Kashmere Gate, Mori Gate, Chandni Chowk, Karol Bagh and Paharganj are among the several locations in North and Central Delhi which will receive reduced water supply due to problems at Chandrawal WTP, a Delhi Jal Board (DJB) order said on Friday.

Though the DJB order didn’t specify the number of days the supply will remain affected, a senior official of the board said, “The supply time has been reduced for the next couple of days.”

The supply, which was twice a day, will now either be in the morning or evening, as per the water roster issued by DJB for the several underground reservoirs and booster pumping stations connected to Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant (WTP).

Areas like Hindurao Hospital, Naya Bazaar, Kashmere Gate, Motia Khan, Pusa Road, Rajender Nagar, and Paharganj will receive water supply only in the



morning. Other locations like Vinay Marg, Chanakyapuri, Nehru Park, Ashoka Hotel, Akbar Road, and Sarojini Nagar will receive water only during evening hours. Since March 22, several areas in central Delhi and under the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) have been affected due to damage to a 600-mm diameter water pipeline at the Chandrawal plant.

“Apologies for the inconvenience. Teams from the Delhi Jal Board are working at war footing to restore water supply,” the order further read. Tankers have been deployed in Karol Bagh, Old

and New Rajender Nagar, West and East Patel Nagar and adjoining areas.

The supply, which was twice a day, will now either be in the morning or evening, as per the water roster issued by DJB for the several underground reservoirs and booster pumping stations connected to Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant (WTP).

Chandrawal WTP-II came to a complete halt after a major 600 mm diameter backwash pipeline near the pump house was damaged, leading to severe waterlogging within the premises. As a result, all electrical and

THE SUPPLY, WHICH WAS TWICE A DAY, WILL NOW EITHER BE IN THE MORNING OR EVENING

mechanical (E&M) equipment became non-operational, bringing pumping activities to a standstill. Chandrawal WTP is a critical installation supplying potable water to central Delhi, including NDMC areas. According to Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, repair and restoration work was initiated on a war footing on the same day to restore operations at the pump house.

“After continuous efforts, the plant was made operational in a phased manner on March 25, 2026. However, due to residual moisture, faults have been repeatedly occurring in the repaired motors during operational hours, affecting normal water supply. At present, about 47 MGD is functional against the installed capacity of 58 MGD,” the minister said in a statement.

According to DJB, the

motors installed at Chandrawal Phase-II WTP are customised old units with a 6.6 kV rating, and their spare parts are not readily available.

These heavy-duty motors require considerable time for repair and restoration. To safeguard the repaired motors and prevent flashing or short-circuiting, extra precautions are being taken, and the motors are being operated intermittently. Efforts are ongoing to stabilise the system and restore full supply at the earliest.

To ensure equitable distribution of available water across all areas under the command of Chandrawal WTP, a revised supply roster has been implemented with effect from March 27, 2026. Under this arrangement, water supply will be provided once daily (instead of twice) in most areas, either in the morning or evening depending on the zone.

To provide interim relief and ensure continued water availability, around 100 additional water tankers have been deployed in the affected areas.

PWD approves Mehrauli-Badarpur elevated road project in South Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Soon after the Delhi government allocated a budget for several integrated corridors to reduce traffic congestion, the Public Works Department (PWD) approved the Mehrauli-Badarpur (MB) elevated road project in South Delhi.

In the first phase, a double-decker integrated structure will be built between Saket G-Block and Sangam Vihar, which will have a six-lane elevated flyover, a six-lane underpass at Saket G-Block, an elevated ramp connecting the BRT corridor to the flyover, and a two-lane underpass linking MB Road with the BRT corridor.

In the second phase, a nearly 2.48-kilometre-long six-lane elevated flyover will be constructed from Maa Anandmayee Marg to Pul Prahladpur.

Notably, this will improve traffic flow in the areas like Saket, Ambedkar Nagar, Khanpur, Sangam Vihar and Pul Prahladpur.

According to PWD officials,



the department has engaged the Delhi Metro for the construction of a six-lane elevated corridor and underpass on Mehrauli-Badarpur (MB) road for ₹1,471 crore, to be ready in two years.

“The present road capacity is inadequate to cater to the traffic demand,” a PWD official said, adding that the project aims to provide free flow of traffic, save commuters’ time, avert traffic jams and save fuel.

This major arterial road is connected to several residential colonies and mixed land-use areas such as Pul Prahladpur, Lalkuan, Sangam Vihar, Khanpur village and

Saket in South Delhi, he said.

There is also heavy on-road parking, leading to traffic congestion in the area, officials added.

As the project is coming into alignment with the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC). It will be executed by them at the estimated cost of ₹1,471.14 crore, including ₹3.69 crore on tree transplantation, according to the plan.

The proposal includes an elevated road at two locations, an elevated portion corridor from Saket-G block to Sangam Vihar and a second corridor from Maa Anandmayee Marg to Pul-Prahaladpur, it said.

DDA sells over 700 flats in Narela

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has sold over 700 flats in its Karmayogi Awaas Yojana and Nagrik Awaas Yojana in Narela, indicating strong demand in the sub-city.

Giving details on Friday, the DDA said under the ongoing DDA Karmayogi Awaas Yojana 2025, a dedicated scheme for serving as well as retired Government employees, it recently offered an additional 936 flats in Pocket 6, Sector A1-A4, Narela.

The booking commenced on March 26, 2026 on the auspicious occasion of Ram Navami and witnessed an enthusiastic response, with over 400 flats booked within just 2 days.

Earlier, 1,168 flats launched in Pocket 9 under the same scheme have already seen around 75 per cent booking, indicating sustained demand



among Government personnel. Similarly, under the DDA Nagrik Awaas Yojana 2026, a total of 1,944 LIG flats were offered in Sector G7/G8, Narela, out of which over 300 flats have already been sold on Day 1, reflecting steady demand from the general public.

The success of these schemes highlights the increasing attractiveness of Narela as a preferred residential destination. This growth is being supported by DDA’s continuous infrastructure

development efforts, including key projects such as the Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) and the upcoming Rithala-Narela-Kundli Metro corridor, which are significantly improving connectivity.

In addition to these schemes, DDA has launched multiple housing initiatives in Narela aimed at making homeownership more accessible to the aspirational sections of society. To enhance affordability, a flat 25 per cent discount is being offered on all flats in Narela.

CM slams previous AAP Govt for huge loans, pending dues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday said a loan amount of ₹47,000 crore borrowed by the previous AAP regime was passed on to her Government, which is trying to repay it.

Speaking on a motion of thanks over the budget presented by her in the Assembly on Tuesday last, Gupta slammed the Opposition AAP while highlighting various initiatives and programmes of her Government.

The annual budget 2026-27, worth ₹1.03 lakh crore, was tabled in the Assembly on Tuesday and was passed by the House with a voice vote. Opposition AAP MLAs were absent from the House due to the boycott of the budget session by the party.

Reacting to AAP leaders’ criticism of her Government for market borrowing, the

Chief Minister asserted that her Government has taken the cheapest available loan at an interest rate of 7.4 per cent.

She said that the Delhi Government started taking loans in 1999 with Rs 1,164 crore borrowed at an interest rate of 10.5 per cent. Not a single year passed that the previous AAP government did not take loans at high rates, which have now been passed on to her government, she claimed.

“In 2019-20, they took a loan of ₹450 crore at around a 9 per cent interest rate. In 2020-21, they took a loan of ₹9,500 crore; in 2021-22, the loan was ₹5,000 crore; and ₹3,200 crore in 2022-23. During their tenure, the loan increased to more than ₹47,000 crore,” she told the House.

She also listed a long list of pending financial liabilities of her government, left behind by the previous government.



The pending liabilities include ₹3,700 crore for a contribution from Delhi for the development of expressways. The previous government did not contribute even ₹1 crore for this, she said.

The pending financial liabilities that have fallen on her government include the contribution of Delhi for the Metro rail. The BJP government has paid ₹2,700 crore of the pending ₹9,082 crore, she said.

She also listed the dues of contractors and other agen-

cies related to the construction of hospitals and schools, which her government is now paying. The pending dues related to health infrastructure stood at ₹2000 crore, while those related to education were more than ₹1000 crore, she said.

“I feel ashamed thinking about what kind of government it was. Money meant for children’s sports activities and awards were not paid, while ₹18 crore for the welfare of the economically weaker section was also not

released,” the chief minister cited. The Delhi Government has paid ₹1,750 crore in scholarships and ₹14.5 crore of pending award money. Pending dues of the Kishori scheme totalling ₹12 crore have also been paid by us, she said. “They were like TB (tuberculosis) for Delhi, clinging to the lungs of the city. Despite hard work and efforts, the stain does not go away. Every day, a new file opens, showing new scams and corruption,” she charged.

She also said that due to years of mismanagement, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and Delhi Jal Board (DJB) were in losses of ₹99,000 crore and ₹91,000 crore, respectively.

She asserted her government is committed to clearing the mess and ensuring that every single rupee of public money is accounted for and every project is completed within the given time period.

Police team up with C-DOT to boost tech-driven policing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has teamed up with the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT) to boost tech-driven policing. This partnership will bring in advanced solutions like the Facial Recognition System (FRS) to identify suspects and missing persons and SAMVAD, a unified communication platform for secure messaging and data sharing.

The Delhi Police-C-DOT partnership is bringing in some cool tech upgrades. The Intelligent Attendance System uses facial recognition to stop proxy attendance, boosting admin efficiency. Plus, the Cell Broadcast Solution will send geo-targeted alerts for traffic updates, emergencies, and public advisories, keeping citizens informed on the go.

The collaboration aims to



Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha, Special CP Crime Devesh Srivastava and RK Upadhyay, Chairman C-DOT, pose for a photograph after signing the MoU

leverage indigenous and secure telecom solutions developed by C-DOT to improve communication systems, surveillance, cybersecurity and emergency response mechanisms within the force.

According to a statement, the partnership will facilitate

the deployment of advanced applications tailored for modern policing needs. Among the key technologies is a Facial Recognition System (FRS), which will assist in identifying suspects, missing persons, and repeat offenders by matching images with

existing databases.

“A unified communication platform, SAMVAD, will enable secure messaging, audio and video calls, and data sharing among various police units, while SAMVAD Prime — a handset-based secure messaging system — will be used for sensitive

communications among senior officers and operational teams,” read the statement.

C-DOT Meet and MCX are game-changers for Delhi Police. It will ensure secure video conferencing for briefings and training, plus low-latency communication for emergencies — they’re stepping up their response game!

The Trinetra Security Operations Centre, an AI-powered cybersecurity platform, will further strengthen the protection of Delhi Police’s IT infrastructure, including critical systems. Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha and C-DOT CEO Raj Kumar Upadhyay, along with senior officials, highlighted that the collaboration would enhance operational efficiency and help build a robust, technology-driven policing ecosystem in the national Capital.

Government to boost film tourism, employment, says Kapil Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is taking concrete steps to develop the national Capital as a leading hub in media, entertainment, and emerging technologies. In this direction, special emphasis is being placed on promoting Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming and Comics (AVGC), Artificial Intelligence, and modern studio infrastructure.

In line with the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi for an Atmanirbhar Bharat, film tourism and employment generation will be given a significant boost. This was stated by Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra while presenting the Delhi Government’s vision on the theme “Delhi as India’s Creative Capital: Film Tourism for Economic Growth” at the



IFFD Industry Conclave 2026.

The Tourism Minister stated that the Government aims to develop an integrated centre in Delhi where creativity, technology, and innovation can flourish under one roof.

He emphasised that Delhi possesses a vast talent pool, strong technical capabilities, and a dynamic youth population, which will be empowered through the right platforms to achieve new heights.

Platforms like IFFD will play a crucial role in realising the vision of a developed Delhi under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

Mishra further informed that a new film policy is being formulated to position Delhi as a preferred film destination. Under this policy, the Government will provide a subsidy of up to ₹3 crore for film shootings conducted in Delhi.

IN FOCUS



Indian Air Force's Surya Kiran Aerobatic Team performs manoeuvres during an air show, near Sukhna Lake in Chandigarh on Friday

PTI

Panel seeks revamp of UNESCO sites' upkeep

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has recommended to the culture ministry to undertake a "comprehensive review" of maintenance standards and visitor facilities at all UNESCO World Heritage Sites in India in coordination with the ASI and prepare a time-bound revamp plan to ensure that the management of these sites is aligned with their global recognition.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture has also recommended to the ministry that it should prepare a "five-year UNESCO nomination strategy", including a pipeline of "at least 10 potential nominations", a structured engagement plan with partner countries for multinational nominations and a "dedicated staff and budgetary provision" for preparing nomination dossiers.

Trump extends deadline, as Israeli missiles...

Israel's Friday strikes "in the heart of Tehran" targeted sites used by Iran to produce ballistic missiles and other weapons, the Israel military said, adding that it also hit missile launchers and storage sites in western Iran.

Smoke was also seen rising over Beirut, although Israel did not immediately report hitting the Lebanon capital. Air raid sirens were heard in Israel as the military said it was working to intercept Iran's missiles. Tehran kept firing missiles and drones at its Gulf neighbours, with sirens warning of attacks in Bahrain, Qatar and the UAE. Saudi Arabia's Defence Ministry on Friday said it has shot down missiles and drones targeting its capital, Riyadh.

Kuwait said both its Shuwaikh Port in Kuwait City and the Mubarak Al Kabeer Port to the north, which is under construction as part of China's "Belt and Road" initiative, sustained "material damage" in strikes.

It appears to be the first instance when a China-affiliated project in the Gulf has come under assault in the ongoing war. Throughout the conflict, China has continued to purchase Iranian crude. With stock markets reeling and economic fallout from the war extending far beyond the Middle East, Trump is under growing pressure to end Iran's chokehold on the strait, a strategic waterway through which a fifth of the world's oil is usually shipped.

The US has offered Iran a 15-point proposal for a ceasefire, which includes its relinquishing control of the Strait of Hormuz, but has simultaneously ordered deployment of thousands of additional troops to the region, possibly in preparation for a military attempt to wrest the key maritime passage from Iran's grasp.

Trump, who had earlier threatened to destroy Iran's energy plants if the strait was not opened within 48 hours — only to extend the deadline to five days after Tehran cautioned of severe retaliation — pushed his self-imposed timeline to April 6 on Thursday, saying that talks on ending the conflict were going "very well".

Iran, however, maintains it is not engaged in any negotiations. After Wall Street's worst day since the war began, Asian shares mostly fell Friday over growing doubts about the chances of de-escalation. Oil prices rose again, the Brent crude, the international standard, at USD 107 a barrel in morning trading, up more than 45 per cent since Israel and the US attacked Iran on February 28 to start the war. Iran's stranglehold on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, has caused growing concerns of a global energy crisis, and appears part of a strategy to get the US to back down by roiling the world economy. The Gulf Arab bloc said on Thursday that Iran is now exacting tolls from ships to ensure their safe passage through the waterway.

Trump envoy Steve Witkoff said Washington has delivered a 15-point "action list" to Iran for a possible ceasefire, using Pakistan as an intermediary. The list includes restrictions on Iran's nuclear programme and re-opening the Strait of Hormuz. Iran has rejected the US offer and put forth its own five-point proposal, which includes reparations and recognition of its sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz.

Diplomats from several countries have been trying to organise a direct meeting between envoys from the US and Iran, possibly in Pakistan. Egypt's Foreign Ministry said in a statement Friday that Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty held phone calls the day before with his Turkish and Pakistan counterparts as part of their "intensive efforts" to organise the talks. Abdelatty said he hoped the tri-country effort would result in "gradual de-escalation efforts that would ultimately lead to the end of the war".

As the diplomatic efforts went on, a group of

India signed white shipping info sharing pacts with 5 nations: Govt

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

New Delhi

India has signed White Shipping Information Sharing (WSIE) agreements with five countries in the last five years to enhance maritime domain awareness, the Government informed Parliament on Friday. White shipping information refers to the exchange of information on merchant shipping traffic.

Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh, in a written response to a query in Lok Sabha, said India has fostered strong bilateral and multilateral partnerships with key partners and like-minded countries in the Indo-Pacific and beyond to ensure Security and Growth for all in the Region (SAGAR).

Expanding on this strategic vision, Prime Minister Narendra Modi outlined the MAHASAGAR doctrine — Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions — in March 2025 in Mauritius, he said. "While SAGAR focuses on security and growth within the Indian Ocean Region (IOR), MAHASAGAR expands this vision to cover the broader Global South. MAHASAGAR encompasses the ideas of trade for development, capacity building for sustainable growth, and mutual security for a shared future," Singh said. In line with the MAHASAGAR initiative, India "continues its commitment"



to the well-being and progress of nations in the region as a first responder and net security provider in the region. The Government is committed to strengthening maritime cooperation in the IOR and beyond, to ensure a favourable and positive maritime environment. India also participates in regional frameworks to promote maritime cooperation and exchanges in the region, Singh said.

"In line with this vision, India has been focusing on development assistance, capacity building initiatives, economic cooperation, connectivity, HADR (humanitarian assistance and disaster relief) support and defence and maritime security cooperation, to assist countries in the region on sustainable socio-economic development," he said.

The Ministry of External Affairs was asked about the steps taken by the

Government to ensure a rules-based order in the Indo-Pacific in strict adherence to the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

"India consistently maintains that the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, 1982 (UNCLOS) is the legal basis for maritime rights, freedoms and dispute settlement, including in the Indo-Pacific," Singh said. India signed the agreement under the UNCLOS on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ Agreement) on September 25, 2024.

"This reflects India's commitment to a comprehensive, UNCLOS-consistent ocean governance that extends beyond national jurisdiction to the high seas, which is a concrete step towards a rules-based maritime order, including in the Indo-Pacific region," he added. The MEA was also

asked about the details of the recent WSIE agreements signed to enhance maritime domain awareness (MDA) and combat non-traditional threats like piracy and 'dark shipping'. "India has signed White Shipping Information Sharing agreements with five countries in the last five years," he said. Singh also said the Government has not made any formal proposal in respect of a BIMSTEC Blue Economy Partnership Framework.

Asked about the diplomatic measures taken to address the challenges posed by "dual-use" maritime infrastructure being developed by extra-regional powers in India's extended neighbourhood, he said, "The Government continues to carefully monitor any developments having a bearing on India's security and economic interests, and takes all necessary measures to safeguard them."

FROM PAGE - 1

advised remote work, while Sri Lanka has declared a weekly public holiday to conserve fuel.

PM chairs meet with CMs on West Asia

Those chief ministers who attended the meeting included N Chandra Babu Naidu (Andhra Pradesh), Yogi Adityanath (Uttar Pradesh), Revanth Reddy (Telangana), Bhagwant Mann (Punjab), Bhupendra Patel (Gujarat), Omar Abdullah (Jammu and Kashmir), Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu (Himachal Pradesh), Pema Khandu (Arunachal Pradesh) among others. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit Shah were also present in the meeting.

PM highlighted the importance of activating control rooms at State and District levels and maintaining administrative alertness to prevent disruptions. He also stressed the need for advance planning in the agriculture sector, particularly in monitoring fertiliser storage and distribution, so that farmers do not face difficulties during the upcoming Kharif season.

Modi cautioned against the spread of misinformation and rumours, stating that timely dissemination of accurate and credible information is essential to prevent panic. He expressed his appreciation for the valuable suggestions shared by all Chief Ministers, noting that these inputs would be instrumental in effectively managing the evolving situation. He emphasised the need for vigilance, preparedness, and coordinated action to address the challenges ahead.

Referring to the ongoing situation in West Asia, PM Modi said India has prior experience in dealing with similar global disruption. He recalled the collective response during the Covid-19 pandemic, when the Centre and States worked together as 'Team India' to mitigate the impact on supply chains, trade, and daily life.

He underscored that the same spirit of cooperation and coordination remains India's greatest strength in navigating the present circumstances. He informed that an Inter-Ministerial Group has been operational since March 3, 2026 reviewing the situation on a daily basis and taking timely decisions.

During the day government also set up an 'informal group of ministers' led by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh to look into the issues arising due to the West Asia conflict. Union ministers Amit Shah, Nirmala Sitharaman and Hardeep Singh Puri are among the members of the informal group of ministers (IGOM), they said.

In his meeting with the CMs, Modi also advised vigilance against online frauds and fake agents. PM called for special attention in border and coastal States to address any emerging challenges related to shipping, essential supplies, and maritime operations.

He also emphasised the need for robust coordination mechanisms at all levels, including regular reviews at the level of Chief Secretaries and continuous monitoring at the district level, to enable quick response to evolving situations. He urged States to accelerate efforts in promoting alternative energy sources such as biofuels, solar energy, GOBARdhan initiative, electric mobility, as well as expanding piped natural gas connections. He also highlighted the importance of enhancing domestic exploration of oil and natural gas, with active cooperation from States. Prime Minister reiterated that addressing the challenge is a shared responsibility and expressed confidence that, working together as 'Team India,' the nation will successfully overcome the situation.

During the meeting, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh highlighted that the government has been working actively under the leadership of Prime Minister to tackle this crisis and taking positive steps such as ensuring timely availability of LPG and reducing the excise duties on petrol

Indian fuel shipment to aid Sri Lanka amid regional volatility

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

In a timely move aimed at easing mounting energy pressures, India is dispatching a major fuel shipment to Sri Lanka, underscoring its role as a key regional partner during times of crisis. The assistance comes as the island nation grapples with supply disruptions triggered by escalating tensions in West Asia.

According to official sources, a combined consignment of 38,000 metric tonnes of fuel—comprising 20,000 MT of diesel and 18,000 MT of petrol—is scheduled to arrive at Colombo Harbour. The shipment is being facilitated through Indian Oil Corporation's local subsidiary, Lanka IOC, ensuring swift distribution across the country. The emergency support follows a high-level conversation on March 24 between Sri Lankan President

Anura Kumara Dissanayake and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, reflecting close bilateral coordination amid evolving regional challenges. Sri Lanka had earlier reached out to India for assistance after energy supply chains were severely affected by instability in West Asia.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar also held discussions with Sri Lankan authorities on ensuring energy sustainability during the crisis.

The disruptions stem from ongoing conflict in the Gulf region, which has significantly impacted global oil transit routes, particularly through the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz. The narrow passage, a key artery connecting the Persian Gulf to the Indian Ocean, has seen shipping activity drastically curtailed, affecting the movement of fuel supplies worldwide.



Government said it chose to absorb the fiscal burden rather than pass costs to consumers, while continuing to monitor volatile global energy markets.

DGCA tightens VVIP flight rules

The order covers various aspects including aircraft airworthiness requirements, crew qualifications, airfield conditions and other operational and safety issues.

"Analysis of earlier accidents/incidents associated with aircraft operations to/from airstrips/temporary helipads and during election flying has often revealed violations of instructions, and safety was jeopardised. It is essential that adequate measures are taken by all concerned to ensure the highest standards of safety for the operation of such flights," it said.

The order which was issued on Friday also asks charter operators and state governments to keep a pamphlet in the aircraft indicating capability and limitations of that aircraft. It must also mention planning and conduct of the flight are professional responsibilities that must remain under the sound judgment of flights crew and engineers.

The pamphlet should also state VIP passengers respect decisions taken by the crew regarding diversions and that they be free from any external pressure or undue influence.

The guidelines mandated that the aircraft operator shall ensure that flight operations are in accordance with the Aircraft Rules and instruction/order/circular issued from time to time, and flight crew are not subjected to undue pressure for undertaking a flight which may impact safety of operations. Any fast minutes changes to the planned flight due to VIP requirements should be coordinated through the Organization's management only, and not directly with the crew.

The DGCA has mandated the use of twin-engine aircraft with a minimum of two crew members, stressing "good operational capability, reliability and easy maintainability" as non-negotiable requirements.

It has also made it compulsory for operators and state aviation departments to brief VVIP passengers about aircraft limitations and operational constraints before take-off. "The planning and conduct of the flight are professional responsibilities that must remain under the sound judgment of the flight crew and AMEs. They should be free from any external pressure or undue influence," the DGCA said.

"The flight crew shall ensure strict compliance of weather minima and proper weather briefing before commencement of flights as per existing regulations. Before Commencement of flight, the Pilot in Command shall familiarize himself with necessary meteorological information required for the intended flight. For every flight under Instrument Flight Rules, the pilot shall study the current weather reports and forecast and plan alternative course of action to provide for the eventuality that the flight may not be completed as planned because of weather conditions," it said.

Noida airport to boost connectivity: PM Modi

The airport is connected to the six-lane Yamuna Expressway, offering swift access to Noida, Greater Noida, Delhi, Gurugram, and major cities of western Uttar Pradesh. On Thursday, the Uttar Pradesh Government said NIA is set to become a "game changer" for the State's economy with a wide-ranging impact across agriculture, industry, logistics and employment generation.

Ladakh avalanche: 7 killed, 5 injured near zero point



MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

At least seven people were killed, and five were injured after passenger vehicles they were travelling in were hit by a massive avalanche near zero point on the route from Zojila to Sonamarg on Friday.

According to preliminary reports, a large volume of snow suddenly came crashing down, engulfing several vehicles passing through the high-altitude stretch near zero point, Zojila.

Soon after the incident, rescue teams rushed to the site and launched an operation to retrieve the bodies and clear the debris.

Chief Executive Councillor, Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council Kargil, Dr Jaffar Akhoun, who is present at the spot along with Kargil administration officers, said five bodies had been recovered so far. Five dead bodies have been retrieved from the snow and shifted to Sub District Hospital Drass,” he told a

local news agency.

Lieutenant Governor, UT of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, said on X that he heard the unfortunate news of an avalanche at Zojila.

“I have directed the DC and SSP of Kargil to visit the spot immediately and mobilise relief and rescue operations,” he said, adding that all Government agencies, including disaster relief forces and BRO have been put on high alert. “I am personally monitoring the situation,” the LG said.

Defence Ministry signs ₹858 crore deals for missile, aircraft

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Ministry of Defence on Friday here signed two contracts, worth a total of ₹858 crore, for the procurement of Tunguska Air Defence Missile System and Inspection (Depot Level) of P81 Long-Range Maritime Reconnaissance Aircraft.

The contract for the procurement of Tunguska Air Defence Missile Systems, valued at ₹445 crore, for the Indian Army, was signed with JSC Rosoboronexport, Russia in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh.

These cutting-edge missiles will enhance India's multilayered air defence capabilities against aerial threats including aircraft drones and cruise missiles.

The agreement will further strengthen the Indo-Russian strategic defence partnership, the ministry said.

The contract for the Inspection (Depot Level) of P81 Long-Range Maritime Reconnaissance Aircraft for Indian Navy under Buy Indian category with 100 per cent Indigenous Content, valued at ₹413 crore, was signed with Boeing India Defense Private Ltd, a wholly owned Indian subsidiary of Boeing, in the presence of senior officials of the Ministry of Defence.

This contract will ensure Depot level maintenance of P81 fleet at in-country MRO (Maintenance, Repair, and Overhaul) facility, which is in line with Government of India's commitment to Aatmanirbhar Bharat and Make-in-India.



PM virtually witnesses Surya Tilak ceremony at Ayodhya Ram temple

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday virtually witnessed the 'Surya Tilak' ceremony held at the Ram temple in Ayodhya on the occasion of Ram Navami, which was marked by religious fervour and drew lakhs of devotees to the holy town.



birth of Lord Ram, falls on the ninth day of Chaitra Navratri. The 'Surya Tilak'

illuminated Ram Lalla's idol at the grand temple. “Earlier today, witnessed

the Surya Tilak that took place at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Mandir, Ayodhya. May the blessings of Prabhu Shri Ram always remain upon us,” Modi said in a social media post.

At around noon, during the auspicious 'Abhijit Muhurat', the Surya Tilak ritual was carried out, with precisely channelled sun rays illuminating the deity's fore-

head for about nine minutes through a specially aligned system of lenses, a temple trust member said.

Fourteen priests conducted the rituals inside the sanctum sanctorum in accordance with Vedic traditions. Following the ceremony, the temple doors were briefly closed and 'bhog' comprising 56 dishes was offered to the deity.

ECI seeks report on Mamata's remarks on CRPF personnel



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India on Friday sought a factual report from the West Bengal chief electoral officer on a video featuring Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee purportedly threatening personnel of the Central Reserve Police Force.

EC officials alleged that at the Nandaprasad Girls' High School ground in Darjeeling, Banerjee “openly threatened” the CRPF personnel by asking all women and girls to be at the polling booths and if necessary use household kitchen equipment to “deal with necessary situations”.

The EC has asked the West Bengal CEO to submit a report on the video.

The CEO will ask the district election officer to verify the video, the officials said.

Nation Focus



Army Chief arrives in Odisha on three-day visit

Army Chief General Upendra Dwivedi arrived here on Friday afternoon on a three-day official visit to Odisha. Soon after landing at the airport, General Dwivedi left for 120 Infantry Battalion (TA) in the city, where he was scheduled to interact with army officers and spend the night. According to the itinerary, the Army Chief will visit Puri on Saturday, where he will go to the Sainik Sadan and offer prayers at the Jagannath Temple before leaving for Gopalpur in Ganjam district. He will then travel to Gopalpur to visit the military station and the Army Air Defence College. During the visit, General Dwivedi will review training infrastructure, modern equipment and operational preparedness of the forces, officials said.



Modi congratulates Balendra Shah on becoming Nepal's PM

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday congratulated Balendra Shah 'Balen' on being sworn in as Nepal's new prime minister, saying that he looks forward to working closely with him to deepen India-Nepal ties for the mutual benefit of both nations. Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah 'Balen', took oath as Nepal's democratically elected prime minister on Friday, around six months after the KP Sharma Oli-led Government was ousted in a Gen-Z protest that shook the nation.

₹9,200 crore invested under food processing PLI scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

More than ₹9,200 crore investments have been made by 168 approved applicants under the Production-Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme in the food processing sector, the Government said on Friday in the Rajya Sabha.

In a written reply, Minister of State for Food Processing Industries Ravneet Singh said, “Under the Production-Linked Incentive Scheme for Food Processing Industries (PLISFPI), 168 applications have been approved as of December 31, 2025.”

A cumulative investment of about ₹9,207 crore has been made by the approved applicants till December 31, 2025.

“Around 35 lakh metric tonnes per annum of processing and preservation capac-

ity has been created under the scheme. Total incentive amount of ₹2,714.79 crore has been disbursed till date,” he added.

Out of 168 applicants approved under the PLISFPI Scheme, 69 applicants are under the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) category. Two applicants are cooperatives, two applicants are under the sector for innovative food products, and 13 applicants are under the organic sector.

Singh said the scheme aims to support the creation of global food manufacturing champions, promote Indian brands of food products abroad, increase employment opportunities for off-farm jobs, ensure remunerative prices of farm produce and higher income to the farmers.



“The incentives under the PLISFPI are admissible where the entire chain of manufacturing processes, including primary processing, of the food products applied for coverage under the scheme takes place in India,” the minister said.

To a separate query, Singh said that as of January 31, 2026, a total of 41 Mega Food

Park projects and 401 Cold Chain projects have been sanctioned, under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Sampada Yojana.

Out of these, 25 mega food park projects and 302 cold chain projects have become operational, and the remaining are at various stages of implementation, the minister said.

India's clean energy push aims to cut imports: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India's clean energy transition is part of a larger national strategy aimed at reducing import dependence and enabling the country to play a leading role in the global shift towards a greener future, Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Friday.

Speaking at the Planet C3 Summit on Climate, Circularity and Community, the minister stated that the clean energy agenda spans a wide spectrum, from securing critical resources such as lithium and rare earth-based permanent magnets to scaling up domestic manufactur-



ing, accelerating innovation, and introducing new policy interventions.

“India has emerged as an important global voice in the transition towards sustainable development, and maintaining this position requires both accelerated scaling of existing initiatives and the launch of new ones in a time-bound manner,” Singh said.

He also highlighted that

sectors such as electric mobility, renewable energy, electronics manufacturing, space, and defence are increasingly dependent on resources like lithium and permanent magnets.

“India currently meets a large share of its requirement through imports, making it necessary to rapidly build domestic capacity,” the minister added.

Singh noted that energy security remained central to India's technological growth, particularly in the context of emerging sectors such as artificial intelligence, which require a reliable and continuous power supply.

Adequate fertiliser reserves available, no need to panic, says Nadda

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Chemicals and Fertilisers Minister JP Nadda on Friday said India has adequate reserves to provide fertilisers to farmers and there is no need to panic.

Replying to a supplementary question in the Lok Sabha on what steps the Government is taking to ensure availability amid the ongoing West Asia war, Nadda said he has spoken to state agriculture ministers on Thursday and informed them about availability of fertilisers.



“I want to assure the citizens of the country the Government has taken steps to ensure that fertiliser is available to farmers whenever required. We have sufficient reserves in place. There is not need to panic,” the minister said.

To a supplementary question from Congress member Manish Tewari on whether the Government is looking at newer markets for fertiliser imports, Nadda said there is sufficient reserves for kharif season.

Flight timings curtailed at Srinagar airport till July 31

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

During the peak tourist season, Srinagar Airport will restrict flight operations from 8 am to 5 pm every day starting April 6 for an Indian Air Force runway upgrade, which is slated to last until July 31, 2026.

At present, around 60 flights, including arrivals and departures, operate daily between 8 am and 10 pm at the airport. However, as per a Notice to Airmen (NOTAM) issued by the Indian Air Force, operational hours for scheduled flights will be temporarily restricted until 5 pm starting from April 6 due to ongoing runway works.

“While the watch hours will be reduced, flight movements are expected to increase in line with the DGCA (Directorate General of Civil Aviation)-approved

summer schedule. Airlines will plan and operate flights accordingly within the revised timings,” Srinagar airport said on X.

“Airports Authority of India remains committed to ensuring safe, efficient, and seamless travel. Passengers are advised to stay updated through official channels and avoid unverified information.”

The development at the beginning of the tourism season has triggered concern among stakeholders, who fear the reduced operating window will impact tourist arrivals.

Travel industry representatives said fewer flights could also lead to higher airfares, discouraging tourists.

Various stakeholders have urged authorities to increase flight frequency within the restricted hours to minimise the impact on Kashmir's tourism industry.



AIADMK announces second list of party candidates for April 23 Tamil Nadu polls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

The Opposition AIADMK in Tamil Nadu on Friday announced the second list of its party candidates for the April 23 Assembly election, retaining some of its MLAs.

The list also contains a number of former ministers and other senior party functionaries.

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami announced the candidates' names for 127 seats, including Tirunelveli assembly constituency from where

BJP state chief Nainar Nagenthiran won in the 2021 polls. The party has fielded Thachai N Ganesaraja, a senior member, from the southern constituency.

Nagenthiran had earlier in the day said that he would contest from Sattur seat (Virudhunagar dt) in the coming polls.

Former state minister B V Ramana has been nominated to contest from Tiruvallur, while another ex-minister and sitting MLA, Pollachi V Jayaraman have been fielded again from Pollachi.

Party legislator from



Kovind lauds expansion of Dang Prayag Hanuman Temple initiative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Calling it a powerful reflection of collective devotion and community participation, former President Ram Nath Kovind praised the expansion of the Dang Prayag Hanuman Temple initiative from 311 to 1111 temples across India's tribal regions.

He noted that the journey signifies not just numerical growth, but a deepening of faith-driven social transformation.

The initiative, led by Govind Dholakia, Founder-Chairman Emeritus of



Shree Ramkrishna Exports (SRK), along with the SRK Knowledge Foundation (SRKKF), traces its origins to

a humble yet profound moment in Dang.

In collaboration with spiritual leaders and vil-

lagers, the Dang Prayag Hanuman Yagya was initiated to nurture spiritual awareness alongside social cohesion among forest communities.

The decision to scale from 311 to 1111 temples reflects growing participation and belief in the model's impact.

In Sanatan tradition, 1111 symbolizes alignment and divine guidance, underscoring the initiative's deeper spiritual intent.

Gujarat Governor Acharya Devvrat highlighted how the effort recognises and institutionalises devotion in its simplest form.

ECI orders transfer of IPS officials in Tamil Nadu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

The Tamil Nadu Government on Friday announced that four IPS officials serving in Chennai have been transferred to the districts following a direction from the Election Commission of India (ECI).

Superintendent of Police CB-CID, Chennai, G Jawahar has been transferred to Kancheepuram district to serve as its SP, while Enforcement SP K Prabakar has been shifted to Perambalur, Q Branch CID



SP E Sundaravathanam has been transferred to Thanjavur, and Vigilance and Anti-Corruption southern range SP A Myilvaganan has been posted to Tenkasi district to serve as SP, a release said.

■ States Focus ■



NAGALAND ASSEMBLY REFERS FNTA BILL BACK TO GOVT

The Nagaland assembly on Friday referred the Frontier Nagaland Territorial Authority (FNTA) Bill back to the state Government for further examination following fresh concerns raised by MLAs and pending inputs from the Centre. The Bill, introduced on Thursday by Deputy CM Yanthungo Patton, was listed for discussion and passage on Friday. However, before it could be taken up, Speaker Sharingain Longkumer informed the House of a communication received from Parliamentary Affairs Minister KG Kenye. Kenye told the House that a letter from the Eastern Nagaland Legislators Union (ENLU) highlighted certain provisions missing in the Bill when compared to the Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) signed on February 5, in New Delhi.



KCR'S DAUGHTER KAVITHA TO LAUNCH POLITICAL PARTY IN APRIL

Telangana Jagruthi president K Kavitha on Friday said she would launch her new political party on April 25 with "Telangana-centric" issues as its main focus. Speaking to reporters in Nizamabad, she said the name and flag of the party would be announced at 10 AM on April 25 at an event to be held at Muneerabad on the outskirts of Hyderabad. Alleging negligence of people's issues, including farmers, by major parties, Kavitha, daughter of BRS chief K Chandrababhan Rao, said a new political force is needed in the state to achieve 'Sarvodaya Telangana' (progress of all).

Shah to unveil BJP charges vs TMC ahead of polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will on Saturday unveil a compilation of the BJP's allegations against the TMC Government in West Bengal ahead of the assembly elections in the state, a senior party leader said.

The document, titled 'Abhiyognama' or 'charge sheet', compiles alleged instances of corruption and misgovernance during the 15-year tenure of Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. Shah is scheduled to arrive in Kolkata late on Friday evening and release the 'charge sheet' at a hotel in New Town on Saturday after-



noon. The 'charge sheet' will highlight the alleged "failures" of the TMC Government across 14 sectors, the leader said. Allegations related to corruption in the administration, collapse of law and order, safety concerns for women, prevalence of syndicate raj, and crises in health and education are expected to figure prominently in the 'charge sheet', he said. The BJP plans to use the

BJP, Opposition clash over fuel excise duty cuts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP and the Opposition on Friday traded charges over the Centre's decision to cut excise duty on petrol and diesel. While the ruling party said the move will provide major relief to the citizens, the Opposition termed the reduction in duty a "late move" taken with the upcoming elections in West Bengal, Assam, and other states in mind.

Defending the decision, the BJP launched a sharp attack on the Opposition over its "misleading campaign." The ruling party MP Anurag Thakur targeted the Congress, alleging that while the Narendra Modi Government has reduced the burden on citizens, the Congress-ruled states have taken steps to increase it.

"First of all, we express our gratitude to the prime minister for the historic decision to reduce excise duty on petrol and diesel. At a time when fuel prices have risen sharply across the world, India is perhaps the only country that has reduced

excise duty and directly benefited 140 crore citizens," Thakur told reporters in the Parliament House complex. He claimed that the Congress has a history of increasing taxes on fuel in states ruled by it.

Drawing a comparison, Thakur said the BJP-led Centre reduced excise duty by ₹10 per litre on petrol and diesel, while Congress governments in states were moving in the opposite direction.

He also charged West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee with spreading misleading narratives on fuel prices and said such statements were aimed at creating confusion among the public.

BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi cited the global energy situation to defend the Centre's decision, saying the Government has acted with sensitivity in a difficult environment. Referring to Ram Navami, he said the decision reflected the principle of making essential items affordable.

Meanwhile, BJP's ally Shiv Sena also supported the Centre's decision to cut excise duty on petroleum



products, describing it as a "citizen-centric move" that will provide relief to people amid rising global fuel prices.

In a social media post, Shiv Sena MP Shrikant Shinde said at a time when fuel prices are increasing worldwide due to tensions in West Asia, the Centre has prioritised the interests of citizens.

The Opposition in its criticism termed the Centre's excise cuts on fuel a "late move" taken with the

upcoming elections in West Bengal, Assam, and other states in mind.

The Opposition also termed the Centre's initiative to hold a meeting with chief ministers on the West Asia conflict a delayed act, and stressed that wider consultations should have taken place earlier in the crisis.

The Congress claimed that the government's excise cuts on petrol and diesel were due to assembly elections and pointed out that con-

sumer prices in India were not reduced even when global crude oil prices fell on seven different occasions in the past 12 years.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said, "When global crude oil prices fell as they did on seven different occasions in the past 12 years consumer prices in India were not reduced."

"Today's announcement was because of assembly elections. Wait till April 30th," he said.

Assembly elections in Assam, Kerala and Puducherry will be held on a single day on April 9, in Tamil Nadu on April 23, and in two phases in West Bengal on April 23 and 29, while votes will be counted for all polls on May 4.

TMC MP Sagarika Ghose criticised the Government for "reactive" policymaking and questioned the timing of the decision. Congress MP Tariq Anwar said the Government should have acted earlier. Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Priyanka Chaturvedi also claimed that the timing of the excise duty cut was linked to elections.

1,068 hectares Railway land under encroachment: Vaishnaw

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Around 1,068 hectares of land owned by the Indian Railways is under encroachment across the country, which is only 0.21 per cent of the total 4.99 lakh hectares of land, Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw informed the Rajya Sabha on Friday.

Replying to supplementary queries during Question Hour, the minister said that if one sees the utilisation of all railway land, nearly 80 per cent of the land is near



Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw speaking in the Rajya Sabha during the second part of the Budget session of Parliament in New Delhi PTI

the tracks, 5 per cent around it, while the remaining 15 per cent of land is used for development of stations,

colonies, hospitals and other things.

"Around 0.21 per cent of Railway land is under illegal

encroachment in the country," he told members in the House.

"It is correct that this illegal encroachment on land is a serious problem. Action has also been taken, but timely action has also been taken from time to time. But every time such an action is taken, a humanitarian approach is adopted, as the poorest people have set up jhuggis on railway land. Wherever possible, a practical solution has been taken together with state Governments," he said. He also informed the

Upper House that several good initiatives have been taken to protect railway land. Among the technological steps taken, he said, complete digitisation of railway land has been done, and electronic land records have been put on a portal.

"Each and every plot of land has been properly mapped and electronically preserved. Surveys have also been done through drones and satellite images of the land of all railway land. Overall, further encroachment has been stopped significantly.

LPG cylinders made in Bengal should stay in state: Mamata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Friday reiterated her demand that cooking gas produced in the state should not be diverted elsewhere in the country, citing concerns over a perceived LPG shortage amidst the ongoing West Asia conflict.

Responding to a query on the Centre's decision to cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by '10 to help oil marketing companies cope with rising global crude prices, Banerjee questioned whether the benefit would be passed on to consumers.



"They increased fuel prices to alarming levels first and are now reducing duties in minuscule amounts. I want people to get that benefit," she said, while addressing reporters

MODI GOVERNMENT MAY HIKE FUEL PRICES AFTER ASSEMBLY POLLS: ABHISHEK

Kolkata: Senior Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee on Friday said there is a strong possibility that the BJP-led central Government will increase the prices of cooking gas and transport fuel after the assembly elections are over on April 29. Addressing an election campaign for the TMC candidate in Binpur assembly constituency in Jhargram district, Birbaha Hansda, Banerjee also accused the Narendra Modi Government of not taking the necessary steps to address the aggravating fuel crisis in West Bengal. The TMC general secretary dared Modi and his ministers to make a promise at their election meetings that there would be no hike in the prices of LPG, petrol, and diesel over the next five years.

at the Kolkata airport before boarding her flight to Andal in Burdwan district, where she is scheduled to address election rallies.

The chief minister said

the Centre must ensure that ordinary citizens do not suffer due to LPG allocations for Government personnel and paramilitary forces being deployed in the state for poll duty.

Will break backbone of Bangladeshi Miyas if BJP-led coalition returns to power: Assam CM

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Friday said his Government will "break the backbone" of Bangladeshi Miyas in the state if the BJP-led coalition returns to power in next month's election. He asserted that the Government will work to build a "strong Assamese society" and the illegal migrants will no longer be able to dare the indigenous community.

Addressing an election campaign meeting at Dhakuakhana in Lakhimpur district, Sarma said, "We



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma campaigning in Dhakuakhana PIONEER PHOTO

have worked very hard for the indigenous people of the state, and those who came from Bangladesh and encroached on Assam's land and homes, we broke their hands and legs, politically."

"This time, we will break the very backbone of the Bangladeshi Miyas, so that they cannot dare the Assamese people," he added. 'Miya' is originally a pejorative term used for

Bengali-speaking Muslims in Assam, and the non-Bengali-speaking people generally identify them as Bangladeshi immigrants. In recent years, activists from the community have started adopting this term as a gesture of defiance.

Sarma said the Government cleared 1.5 lakh bighas of encroached land from Bangladeshi Miyas in the last five years, and the target is to clear 5 lakh bighas in the next term. "It is our land, our right; our 'jati' (community), our 'swabhiman' (dignity). We will work to build a strong Assamese society," the CM added.

J-K Assembly adjourned as chaos erupts over Khamenei death

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

More than three weeks after life returned to normalcy in different parts of the Kashmir valley in the aftermath of the killing of the Supreme Leader of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in coordinated US-Israeli airstrikes on Tehran, the floor of the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly Friday witnessed acrimonious scenes as the legislators belonging to the ruling National Conference, Congress, CPI(M), Independents and the Opposition PDP raised slogans against Israel and condemned the assassination of a religious leader. However, the BJP legislators were seen displaying placards to press for a National



Jammu & Kashmir National Conference MLAs stage a protest during the Budget session of the Legislative Assembly in Jammu on Friday PTI

Law University in Jammu. The second leg of the Budget session was resumed on Friday after a five-week long recess.

As the chaos prevailed on the floor of the assembly, the speaker of the house, Abdul Rahim Rather, adjourned the house for about half an hour. As the House assembled after

the adjournment, National Conference MLA Tanvir Sadiq sought a statement from the Leader of the House against the war on Iran.

In response, BJP legislators maintained that the Iran crisis is an international issue and does not fall within the domain of the House. To

restore order in the house, the speaker requested the Chief Minister to make a statement after hearing the opinions of several members from both benches.

In his crisp statement, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah condemned the "unjust and illegal war imposed on Iran" and requested Prime Minister Narendra Modi to use his influence to end the war in the interest of humanity.

"On behalf of myself and my colleagues, I strongly condemn this unjust and illegal war imposed on Iran. I express my deepest condolences over the loss of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and his associates and all those who have lost their lives in this conflict," the chief minister said.

Biogas plant provides clean cooking, lighting in Arunachal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

A 30 Cubic Meter biogas plant has been commissioned at the Central Cattle Breeding Farm (CCBF) in Nirjuli, Arunachal Pradesh, converting cow dung into clean biogas for cooking and lighting. The plant serves over 12 families, reducing their dependence on LPG, and produces nutrient-rich slurry for soil fertility.

Gabriel D Wangsu, the minister in-charge in the Government of Arunachal Pradesh directed the department to replicate this model across state farms, promoting clean energy, organic farming, and reducing pollution. The initiative is a step towards sus-



tainable living, turning waste into valuable resources.

Accordingly, Arunachal Pradesh Energy Development agency in collaboration with AHV and DD department have fast tracked its commissioning that was commissioned on 27th March 2026.

The event was graced by RK

Sharma, IAS, Commissioner (Planning, Power and NCER), YVJ Rajasekhar, IAS, Secretary (AHV and DD along with officers from APEDA and the Department of AHV and DD.

The Minister further directed the department to prepare proposal for increasing the capacity and replicating such Bio Gas plants

across various state farms of Arunachal Pradesh, Mr Wangsu emphasized that effective utilisation of cattle waste not only helps in generation of clean energy but also reduces environmental pollution and promotes organic farming besides reducing dependency on LPG at this juncture.

He further encouraged farmers and field officers to replicate such models at the grassroots level for long-term benefits.

According to Dr Taba Heli (Project In charge), this initiative marks a meaningful step towards a greener future, turning waste into valuable resources while promoting sustainable living and reducing dependence on LPG.

Economy policy impact matters beyond numbers: President Murmu



President Droupadi Murmu addressing a gathering of officers of the CPES and IES at Rashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Asserting that behind every statistic lies a human story, President Droupadi Murmu on Friday said that the true measure of economic policy is not merely in numbers, but in its outcome.

Addressing a group of Indian Economic Service (IES) officers, who had called on her at the Rashtrapati Bhavan, she said the role of economic planning and implementation in public service has become more critical than ever.

Murmu said their role will be significant in ensuring sustainable growth, managing inflation, enhancing employment opportunities, reducing inequalities, and steering the economy through a complex environment.

"At the same time, you should always remember that behind every statistic lies a human story. The true measure of economic policy is not merely in numbers, but in its outcome. It should improve the lives of people, especially the most vulnerable," she said.

The president said that officers' actions should be guided by a deep sense of empathy and a commitment to inclusive and equitable development.

Murmu asked the IES officers to uphold the highest standards of integrity and professionalism.

"In public service, trust is your most valuable asset, and it must be earned and preserved through your decisions and actions," she said.

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Order Order

Delhi HC stays eviction of Race Club, Polo ground; directs Centre to follow due process



The Delhi High Court has stayed the eviction of the Delhi Race Club and the Indian Polo Association from their historic premises. Justice Mini Pushkarna, in two separate orders passed on March 25, restrained the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs from taking "forcible possession" of the Delhi Race Club at Kamal Ataturk Marg and the Jaipur Polo Ground in the Race Course area. Both entities had been served with eviction notices dated March 12, 2026.

"Based on the aforesaid narration of facts and submissions made before this Court, a prima facie case has been made out in favour of the plaintiff. Further balance of convenience also lies in favour of the plaintiff and irreparable injury shall be caused to the plaintiff, if interim relief is not granted to the plaintiff," the court said while restraining the Centre from dispossessing the club until the next hearing on April 9.

The court noted that the race club has been operating on the 53.242-acre premises since a lease was first granted in 1926. "This court has made a pointed query to the defendant, whether the defendant would make a statement before this Court similar to the other connected matter, that the defendant shall not dispossess the plaintiff without resorting to due process of law," Justice Pushkarna said.

Retired HC judge to move tribunal after name removed from Bengal voter list

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Calcutta High Court's retired judge and West Bengal Waqf Board chairperson Shahidullah Munshi claimed that his name has been deleted after judicial scrutiny of the electoral rolls, and has decided to move an appellate tribunal. The exclusion came to light after the publication of the first supplementary list of 'under-adjudication' voters on Monday.

Justice Munshi said the names of his wife and elder son continue to remain under adjudication.

The chairperson of the State Waqf Board also said he had appeared for the SIR hearing, submitted his passport and offered to provide his Aadhaar and PAN cards.

The retired judge said his family found their names marked as under adjudication in the post-SIR electoral roll published on February 28.

"My name was deleted in the first supplementary list. I have submitted all required documents, including my passport, but I received no acknowledgement," he said on Thursday.

According to official data released on February 28, 63.66 lakh names, around 8.3 per cent of the electorate, have been deleted since the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process began in November last year, reducing the voter base from about 7.66 crore to just over 7.04 crore. In addition, over 60.06 lakh electors have been placed in the



Justice Shahidullah Munshi

"under adjudication" category, and the eligibility of these people as voters is being determined through scrutiny by judicial officers.

Describing the situation as distressing, he said, "So far, only my name has been deleted, while the names of my wife and son are still under consideration. This is extremely humiliating and amounts to harassment. I do not understand how the decision was taken or on what basis my name was removed."

Munshi said he would soon move the appellate tribunal seeking restoration of his name in the electoral rolls.

The retired judge said he and his wife were earlier voters of the Bowbazar assembly constituency and had later

shifted to Entally. The issue has triggered a political row, with the ruling Trinamool Congress criticising the Election Commission over the exclusion.

"When a former High Court judge's name is deleted from the voters' list, one can imagine the plight of ordinary citizens, including the poor and marginalised," a TMC leader said.

The Election Commission has not issued any official statement on the matter so far. Meanwhile, a senior BJP leader said there were legal remedies available in case of discrepancies.

"If there has been any error, the person concerned can approach the tribunal as permitted by the court. The legal route is open," he said.



CJI: Fill vacant posts, prioritise elevation of women judges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has written to chief justices of High Courts for expeditious filling up of judicial vacancies with special focus on elevation of women judges for ensuring diversity in the benches.

According to sources, the CJI wrote to chief justices of 25 High Courts last week and highlighted the vacancies of judges in higher judiciary and increase the representation of women in the benches.

The CJI, who has earlier flagged poor representation of women judges, also asked the chief justices not to delay the recommendation of collegiums and endeavour for taking steps for filling of the vacancies even before actual vacancy arises.

On March 8, while speaking at a function, CJI Kant batted for greater institutional reforms in the judiciary to



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

bring more women into the legal field and said that High Court collegiums should consider meritorious women members of the bar for judgeship as a norm and not as an exception.

The CJI requested the High Court collegiums to widen the zone of their consideration and include women advocates from their states who are practising in the Supreme Court for elevation.

He had highlighted that multiple women are current-

ly serving as chief justices of different High Courts, and the Punjab and Haryana High Court has as many as 18 sitting women judges.

Similarly, the Madras and Bombay High Courts also have about a dozen female judges each, he had said.

CJI Kant had also pointed out that women comprise approximately 36.3 per cent of the working strength of judicial officers at the district level. "Friends, this is not a simple statistic; I would

argue it reflects a generational shift. If we speak of a pipeline, it is here that it is visibly widening. And when the base of the system reflects greater inclusion, it is only a matter of time before that strength finds expression in the higher judiciary," he had said.

According to data tabled in Lok Sabha by Union minister Arjun Ram Meghwal in February, 170 women judges have been appointed in the High Courts since 2014, including 96 in the last five years, and six in the Supreme Court.

The data said 116 women judges were serving in the High Courts as on February 6. It said that 308 posts of High Court judges were vacant as against the sanctioned strength of 1122 judges.

As on February 6, the High Courts have a working strength of 814 judges and the Supreme Court as on date has 33 judges including one woman judge.

NGT notice over illegal water boring in Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has issued notice to the Assam Government and various State agencies over alleged illegal groundwater boring in parts of Guwahati.

The NGT's Eastern Zone Bench admitted an application, which highlighted serious concerns over alleged illegal groundwater extraction in the Barshapara area of the capital city of Assam, filed by Milan Kanti Das and others. The Bench comprising Justice Dinesh Kumar Singh and Expert Member Ishwar Singh on Monday issued notices to all respondents, directing them to respond within four weeks. The

Tribunal fixed May 8 as the next date of hearing.

The case has made the Assam Government as respondent, represented by the Special Chief Secretary (PHED), along with the Executive Engineer (PHED), District Commissioner of Kamrup Metropolitan, Central Ground Water Board and the Water Supply Management Committee of Barshapara no 1. During the hearing, the applicants submitted that as per information obtained under the Right to Information Act from the Central Ground Water Board (CGWB), no NOC has been issued for groundwater extraction in the Barshapara area. It has been alleged that



the Barshapara no 1 Water Supply Scheme Management Committee is operating multiple borewells without authorisation and extracting groundwater for extended hours daily.

The area has been cate-

gorised as a semi-critical groundwater zone, and such excessive extraction has reportedly led to a sharp decline in groundwater levels, causing water scarcity for local residents, the petition claimed.

Security breach: NIA custody of 7 foreign nationals extended

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Friday extended by 10 days the NIA custody of seven foreign nationals, including six Ukrainians, accused of breaching national security.

NIA special judge Prashant Sharma, who conducted the proceedings in the agency's headquarters here, directed the production of the accused persons after completion of their custodial interrogation on April 6.

Earlier in the day, the judge allowed the agency's plea seeking holding the judicial proceedings at its headquarters against six Ukrainians and a US national, noting that the case pertained to breach of national security and the investigation is highly sensitive with global ramifications.

On March 16, the court had allowed 11-day NIA custody of the accused, identified as US national Matthew Aaron Van Dyke and Ukrainian nationals Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim, and Kaminskyl Viktor.

Court sources said the



NIA produces accused foreigners before court

FILE PHOTO

foreign nationals on Friday moved a plea seeking an independent translator for fair judicial proceedings.

In the remand application on March 16, the investigation officer, citing the FIR, said that some Ukrainians had entered India on tourist visas on separate dates and flew to Guwahati, from where they travelled to Mizoram without obtaining the requisite documents, such as the Restricted Area Permit or Protected Area Permit.

Thereafter, these individuals illegally entered Myanmar to impart pre-scheduled training for Ethnic Armed Organisations (EAO) in that country, the officer

Bank loan fraud: ED files chargesheet against ex-RCOM executive Punit Garg

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate on Friday filed a chargesheet against former Reliance Communications president Punit Garg and another person as part of its money laundering probe into an alleged ₹40,000 crore bank loan fraud case. The company's promoter Anil Ambani's is not figured in the chargesheet. The chargesheet was filed before a special court at Rouse Avenue under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The more than 170-page chargesheet names Garg and Vaishali Jairam Mane, a former director at US-based Bonn Investment Inc, as accused in the case, said officials. The ED arrested Garg, 61, in January this year.

The former Reliance Communications (RCOM) president, while holding senior managerial and directorial positions in the company from 2001 to 2025, was actively involved in the acquisition, possession, concealment, layering and dissipation of proceeds of crime generated from the said bank fraud, the ED claimed earlier. The alleged laundered funds were "diverted" through multiple foreign subsidiaries and offshore entities of RCOM, it alleged.

As the president of RCOM, the agency said, Garg was handling the global enterprise business of the company between 2006 and 2013. He also served as president (regulatory affairs) from 2014 to 2017. In October 2017, Garg was appointed executive director at RCOM, and from April 2019 till April 2025, he served as a non-executive director of the company, according to the ED.

It was found that the pro-



ceeds of crime generated from the alleged fraud were "diverted" to purchase a luxury condominium apartment in Manhattan, New York.

Mane was allegedly linked to the purchase of this Manhattan apartment and has therefore been named in the chargesheet, the ED said.

The property was "fraudulently" sold in 2023 during a corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) of RCOM by Garg, the ED said.

It is understood that RCOM informed the stock exchange about this "fraudulent" sale in 2025.

"The sale proceeds of \$8.3 million (about ₹69.55 crore in 2023) were remitted from the US under the guise of a sham investment arrangement with a Dubai-based entity controlled by a Pakistan-linked individual, without the knowledge or consent of the resolution professional (RP)," the agency said.

A part of the proceeds of crime — public money taken by RCOM as bank loans — was "diverted" for Garg's personal expenses, including overseas education-related payments for his children, the agency claimed.

In December 2025, the ED had filed a chargesheet against Anil Ambani's group company, Reliance Power Ltd, and 10 others in a money laundering case linked to the issuance of an alleged fake bank guarantee of ₹68 crore for securing a tender.

Live-in between married man, consenting adult woman not a crime: Alld HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has said that a married man living in a consensual live-in relationship with an adult woman does not amount to a criminal offence under law. A division bench of Justice JJ Munir and Justice Tarun Saxena made the observation while granting interim protection from arrest to two petitioners in the case.



Staying their arrest, the court said, "There is no offence where a married man is staying with an adult woman in a live-in relationship with her consent. Morality and law have to be kept separate. If there is no offence under the law, social opinions and morality will not guide the court."

Coal scam : Delhi court acquits ex-MP Vijay Darda, former coal secretary HC Gupta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Holding that the allocation of coal blocks was part of a "policy decision" of a high-powered panel and the PMO, a special CBI court on Friday acquitted former MP and media baron Vijay Darda, his son Devendra Darda, and former coal secretary HC Gupta in a case related to alleged irregularities in allocation of the Bander coal block in Maharashtra. Bringing down the curtains on the oldest pending coal block allocation case registered on March 27, 2014, Special Judge Sunena Sharma also acquitted M/s AMR Iron and Steel Private Limited, Manoj Kumar Jayaswal, Santosh Bagrodia and LS Janoti.

The judge cleared all accused of charges including criminal conspiracy (Section 120-B IPC), cheating (Section 420 IPC), and various sections of the Prevention of Corruption (PC) Act. The verdict said the evidence adduced by the CBI was "highly insufficient to conclusively establish any of the essential ingredients like deception, inducement, dishonest intention or wrongful gain for the alleged offence of cheating punishable under Section 420 (cheating) of the IPC".

Trashing the charge of criminal conspiracy against all the accused, the judge, in the 287-page verdict, said, "Even for the offence of criminal conspiracy, the prosecution case is based only on conjunctures and surmises

without there being any direct or indirect evidence sufficient to draw anything reasonable, rational or conclusive."

"Moreover, the decision to carry out the exercise of allocating coal blocks was a policy decision, which was taken in accordance with the specific instructions of the 7th Election Coordination Committee (ECC) and the PMO. "In accordance with the extant guidelines, the Screening Committee recommended the allocation of Bander Coal Block to AMR (for its 0.3 MTPA capacity) jointly with M/s Century Textiles & Industries Ltd and M/s JK Cement Ltd and the said decision was unanimously taken after due deliberations on the information furnished by the applicants and the feedback



Vijay Darda

received from the State Governments and the Ministry of Steel," the verdict said. "The decision to allocate the coal block, by no stretch of the imagination, can be said to be a decision taken 'without any public interest' especially, when there is no allegation of quid pro quo," it said. The CBI alleged that M/s

AMR Iron & Steel Pvt Ltd, represented by Manoj Jayaswal, had fraudulently obtained the Bander coal block by misrepresenting its financial strength and concealing previous coal block allocations.

The case rested heavily on the claim that Vijay Darda used his position as a Member of Parliament to

influence the PMO through recommendation letters. In exchange for this alleged influence, the CBI claimed that ₹24.60 crore was routed from Jayaswal's Abhijeet Group to a company owned by the Dardas (Asera Banka Power Ltd) under the guise of high-premium share purchases.

The verdict found a special mention of former coal secretary HC Gupta, a co-accused, and said, "However, before parting with this judgment, this court owes a duty to mention that HC Gupta..., who had been summoned by the court on a closure report filed by CBI qua him, has been honourably acquitted for lack of any evidence for the alleged charges framed against him." Dealing with the role of former Congress

MP Vijay Darda, it said he routinely wrote letters to the PMO in his capacity as an MP for the development of his constituency in Maharashtra and, moreover, it was conclusively established that such letters were never considered for the allocation. Vijay Darda is promoter of media company Lokmat Group. "Once, it is held that Vijay Darda had no role to play in the allocation of the coal block, the very foundation of the prosecution case regarding payment of illegal gratification of ₹24.60 crore collapses," it held.

In the absence of any role attributable to the MP in grant of the coal block, it said there was neither any occasion nor any plausible motive for AMR to pay any illegal gratification to him. "There is no evidence,

either oral or documentary, to demonstrate that the said transactions were undertaken pursuant to any prior demand, agreement or purpose of influencing the allocation of the coal block," it said.

Over 25 corruption cases filed by the CBI are currently pending before two special courts set up to try cases arising out of the alleged coal scam whereas 27 have been disposed of so far. On January 16, 2025, the ED informed the top court that 45 complaints, including supplementary ones, were pending under the PMLA. Supreme Court in 2014 quashed 214 coal blocks allocated by the Centre between 1993 and 2010 after taking note of two PILs and ordered a trial by a special CBI judge.



Editor's
TAKE

When work feminises but power masculinises

As more women enter the workforce across professions, a stark reality persists: leadership remains overwhelmingly male

When it comes to gender issues, mostly crimes against women take centre stage – dowry deaths, domestic violence, infanticide, rape and molestation are often talked about loudly and in unequivocal terms. Crimes against women need to stop and raising voices against them is very important. However, another gender issue that needs equal, if not more, attention is discrimination against women in the workplace. Women are often paid less than their male counterparts, have equal skills and give an equal number of hours to their profession, yet they sooner or later hit the glass ceiling. India slipped from 129th position to 131st out of 148 countries in the 2025 Global Gender Gap Report. Studies show that women in leadership positions are far fewer in number than men. Often, to make a point, a few examples of women in top positions are thrown in.

Indeed, women like Indra Nooyi, Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw and Falguni Nayar have demonstrated that women can not only participate in but also lead and transform industries at the highest level. Yet, their success stories, while inspiring, remain exceptions rather than the norm. The reality is that their participation in the workforce has not translated into proportional power. Men tend to dominate positions of leadership, prestige and decision-making, even in professions generally associated with women like cooking, teaching and nursing, and while the work remains the same, what changes is who controls it.

This pattern is structural. Labour markets are shaped by deep-rooted gender norms that assign women to roles seen as extensions of domestic responsibilities. These roles are often undervalued, poorly paid, and offer limited upward mobility. When sectors professionalise and profits rise, barriers – both visible and invisible - emerge that restrict women's ascent. One major factor is the persistence of the "glass ceiling". Women are often clustered in entry-level or mid-level roles but face systemic hurdles in climbing to senior management. This is not merely a question of merit but of networks, mentorship and institutional bias. Leadership processes are often reinforced by stereotypes that associate authority with masculinity. Equally significant is the "double burden" women carry. Changing this reality requires a reconfiguration of how work and leadership are structured. First, organisations must actively dismantle biases in hiring, promotion and evaluation. Transparent criteria and accountability mechanisms can help ensure that leadership opportunities are not skewed. The Government, on its part, must make policies that support work-life balance – such as flexible work arrangements, parental leave for both genders, and accessible childcare – essential. When women lead, it reshapes aspirations and normalises their presence in positions of authority. The way forward lies not just in opening doors, but in ensuring that women can walk through them – and lead.

When wars burn more than oil

This is a moment to argue, with renewed urgency, for accelerating the domestic renewable energy transition, not merely as a climate commitment, but as a national security imperative



DISHA SHARMA

Never before have climate science and geopolitics converged so sharply, or so consequentially. The ongoing conflict involving Iran is not merely a crisis of regional security; it is a slow-motion assault on the planet's atmospheric dynamics and on the energy futures of nations thousands of kilometres away. India, sitting at the intersection of both vulnerabilities, has reason to pay particular attention.

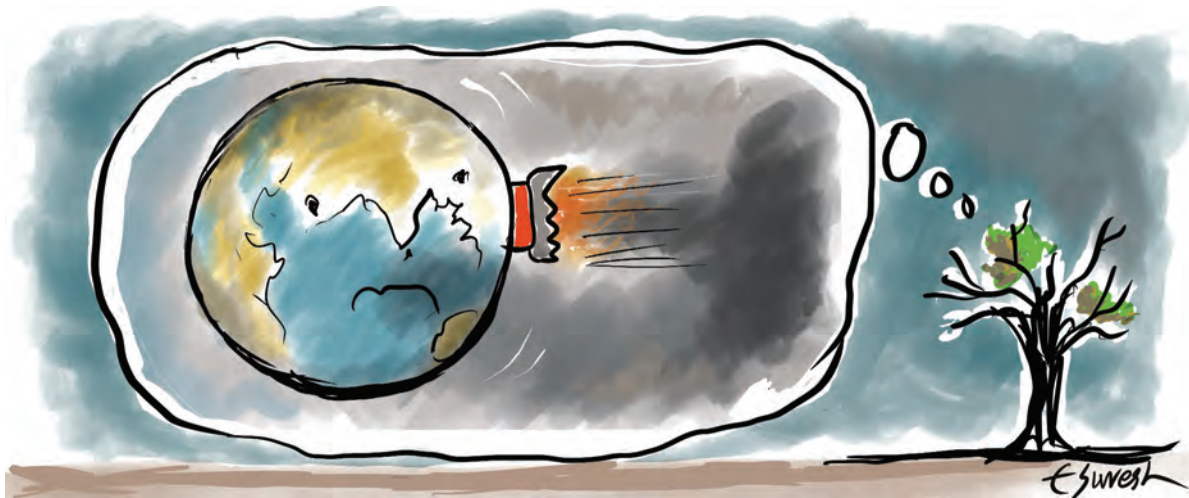
The recently released World Meteorological Organisation's State of Global Climate Report offers a sobering baseline. Greenhouse gas concentrations have reached an all-time high. Global temperatures have breached the 1.2°C threshold consecutively since 2025. The past decade has been the hottest period recorded so far. The Earth, as scientists are no longer reluctant to say plainly, is already boiling. Yet what is often treated as a futuristic problem has an urgent, present dimension, one that active warfare is now making dramatically worse.

The conflict has introduced a carbon shock that few anticipated. The Climate and Community Institute estimates that the bombing of fossil fuel infrastructure alone released approximately 5 million tonnes of carbon dioxide in just the first two weeks of the war. To place that in proportion: India's carbon dioxide sink stood at 2 billion tonnes in 2025, a hard-won achievement of years of afforestation and renewable energy push. A single fortnight of distant conflict has carved a visible dent into that ledger. Geopolitics, it turns out, does not respect national carbon budgets.

The dangers compound in two distinct directions, and understanding both is essential to grasp why this conflict demands the attention of climate diplomats and energy policymakers simultaneously.

The energy security fault line

The first danger is one of supply. India imports approximately 88 per cent of its crude oil and nearly half of its liquefied petroleum gas and liquefied natural gas through the Strait of Hormuz. While oil and gas together account for nearly 6 per cent of India's total power generation, their role is far more critical in the sectors that keep the economy moving: transport, fertiliser and chemical manufacturing, and household energy. Any sustained disruption to this chokepoint is not an abstract geopolitical inconvenience; it is a direct threat to the fuel that runs India's transport networks, powers its industries, and keeps household energy affordable for hundreds of millions.



INDIA'S POSITION IS UNCOMFORTABLE BUT CLARIFYING. IT IS A COUNTRY WITH A CREDIBLE DECARBONISATION TRAJECTORY, GENUINE ENERGY POVERTY CHALLENGES, AND ACUTE EXPOSURE TO HORMUZ-DEPENDENT SUPPLY CHAINS, ALL AT ONCE. THE CONFLICT THROWS EACH OF THESE INTO SHARPER RELIEF

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Energy security has always carried two faces: the availability of supply, and the prudence with which available resources are used. Both are now under stress. When supply tightens, the instinct, individually and institutionally, is to reach for whatever is cheapest and most accessible. In practice, that means a reversion to more polluting sources. Some Indian households, facing LPG shortages or price spikes, are already turning back to open-fire chulhas, echoing methods that a decade of public health campaigns worked hard to displace. The health consequences are well documented: indoor combustion of solid fuels produces soot, carbon monoxide, and particulate matter at concentrations that cause chronic respiratory and cardiovascular disease. An entire research and policy campaign was built to wean households off exactly this practice by promoting smokeless chulhas. Conflict-driven energy scarcity risks undoing it.

The atmospheric feedback loop

The second danger operates through the atmosphere itself, and its timeline is shorter than most people assume. There is now substantial evidence that changes in greenhouse gas concentrations and the accompanying rise in particulate matter alter weather patterns on timescales of days and weeks, not decades. The world had an inadvertent demonstration of this during the COVID-19 pandemic, when industrial and vehicular activity shut down almost simultaneously. Within days, air quality in major cities transformed visibly. Skies cleared. Rivers ran cleaner. Climate impacts, the pandemic revealed, are not solely the province of a distant future.

Additional carbon dioxide in the atmosphere drives global temperatures upward. Hotter temperatures in turn drive up energy demand, particularly for cooling. And in countries like India, where grid capacity remains stretched

and the energy mix still leans heavily on fossil fuels, peak demand spikes are met predominantly through thermal power. The loop is self-reinforcing: more emissions produce more heat, more heat produces more demand, more demand produces more emissions.

For the hundreds of millions living in India's heat-stressed geographies - the Indo-Gangetic Plain, coastal Odisha, interior Maharashtra - this is not an abstraction. Extreme heat events, intensifying monsoons, urban flooding, and erratic weather are already realities that require energy access to manage. Cooling, clean water pumping, flood response: all

depend on reliable, affordable power. The cruelest irony of the present moment is that the geopolitical disruptions contributing to a hotter atmosphere are simultaneously threatening the energy access that people need to survive that heat.

What India must insist upon

India's position is uncomfortable but clarifying. It is a country with a credible decarbonisation trajectory, genuine energy poverty challenges, and acute exposure to Hormuz-dependent supply chains, all at once. The conflict throws each of these into sharper relief.

This is a moment to argue, with renewed urgency, for accelerating the domestic renewable energy transition, not merely as a climate commitment, but as a national security imperative. Every gigawatt of solar or wind capacity built domestically is a unit of energy that cannot be held hostage by a strait or a war. It is also a moment to insist, in multilateral forums, that the climate costs of warfare be accounted for, and that the carbon emissions of conflict become part of the reckoning when peace settlements and reconstruction agreements are negotiated. Climate science and geopolitics have never been better connected. The tragedy is that the connection is being forged not by cooperation, but by crisis.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIC TALK



Young girls sit during the 'Kanya Pujan' ritual on the last day of the 'Navratri' festival at the Dakshineswar Ramkrishna Sangha Adyapeath temple in Kolkata. PHOTO: PTI

Happy mind: Lessons from India's 100-year-olds



RAJESH K PILLANIA

2ND OPINION

In this pioneering research work in India, interviews with happy Indians aged 100 and above reveal one finding: happiness is chosen, cultivated, and sustained through a calm mind, optimism, mental engagement, tranquillity, and continuous learning.

The wish to live long and live well is as old as the search for happiness itself. A pioneering Indian study asks a direct question: what makes people live happy, long lives in India? Based on interviews conducted during 2023-2025 with men and women aged 100 and above from various backgrounds and different parts of the country, the answer is organised into seven secrets. These are cultivating strong and supportive relationships, embracing oneness or spirituality, choosing, developing and maintaining a happy mind, achieving success in life, saying yes to enjoying life, maintaining good physical health, and nurturing others by giving. Together, they form the HARMONY of happiness formula, an Indian formula for happiness.

This article focuses on one of those seven secrets: choosing, developing and maintaining a happy mind. It presents a happy mind not as a passing mood, but as an ongoing practice shaped by how people think, respond, learn, and remain engaged with life. Among happy Indian centenarians, the findings show that a happy mind is built on a stress-free outlook, a choice to live happily, optimism, mental activity, peace of mind, openness to learning, good mental health, and a sense of humour.

To explore this further, the study states plainly that choosing, developing and maintaining a happy mind is important for happiness. For the centenarians in this research, a happy mind begins with a decision. It begins with choosing to be happy, living happily, maintaining a happy nature, focusing on wellness, believing there is no dearth of happiness, and talking happily to people. The study treats this as a lived practice, part of how happy centenarians move through daily life and relate to others.

When these approaches are ranked by the number of mentions from happy participants, the order is telling. Maintaining a stress-free mind leads to choosing happiness, optimism, mental engagement, peace of mind, openness to learning, mental health, and a strong sense of humour.

The Pioneer
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SLEEPER BUS TRAGEDY EXPOSES GAPS IN TRANSPORT SAFETY

After witnessing the heartbreaking scenes at the morgue following the Rayavaram-Markapur sleeper-bus tragedy, where families stood in uncertainty and grief awaiting identification of their loved ones, I feel compelled to draw attention to serious gaps in our transport safety and disaster-response systems.

The accident is yet another reminder of recurring failures in preventing predictable transport disasters. While the immediate response of the state machinery is commendable, the larger question remains: why are we still unable to prevent catastrophic post-crash bus fires?

The issue goes beyond vehicle failure, human error or road conditions alone. Sleeper buses becoming engulfed in flames within minutes raises serious

concerns about crashworthiness standards, flammable interior materials, limited emergency exit accessibility and the absence of automatic fire-suppression mechanisms.

Driver fatigue, weak enforcement of speed regulations and inconsistent safety compliance monitoring also require closer scrutiny. Strengthening inspection mechanisms and real-time monitoring of private long-distance buses is essential.

This tragedy must become a turning point. Strengthening sleeper-bus design standards, enforcing fire-safety compliance and improving disaster identification systems are essential steps if we are serious about preventing such disasters in the future.

K ANANTH RUPESH | ONGOLE

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Act mindfully during fuel crisis

Amid West Asia's conflict, tension is brewing among Indians regarding oil and gas supplies. The panic situation is intensifying each day, with people reaching gas agencies and standing in long queues to refill LPG cylinders. Vehicle owners are worried about fuel reserves amid misleading news of a lockdown-like situation in the country.

Though the government has clarified that reserve stocks are available for the next 60 days, it is the duty of the public to use oil and LPG judiciously.

Vehicle pooling and the use of bicycles can be adopted to save fuel. The government ought to advise companies to switch to work from home where possible to reduce fuel consumption.

Induction plates and solar cookers can also be used during this time. People should understand the gravity of the situation and help the government in difficult times.

Amid escalating tension, some people are stocking gas cylinders and black marketing them to earn money, which is very disappointing. People should refrain from believing rumours, act patiently and mindfully, and adopt alternative methods to save fuel and gas.

ABHILASHA GUPTA | MOHALI

War from distant screens

From the blood-soaked plains of antiquity to the anti-septic glow of digital war rooms, the soldier's journey has curiously shrunk even as the battlefield has expanded.

Once, war was led from the front by figures who wore their courage like armour and their scars like scripture. Alexander rode into battle with his men, Caesar crossed rivers with them, and Ashoka carried the weight of Kalinga. Admiral Nelson lost an eye and an arm in combat, and Rana Sanga lost an eye and an arm and was lamed in separate battles.

Today, war is fought on screens and through sanitised briefings. The theatre is global, but the touch is remote. Generals no longer read the tremor in a soldier's hand; they read coordinates. The finger that once steadied a comrade now rests on a console key – efficient, detached and unburdened.

There is something tragically ironic in this evolution: power exercised from comfortable rooms while devastation unfolds in distant lands. War, once a test of endurance and judgement, risks becoming distant and detached from its human cost. War may now be fought from screens and command rooms. But its cost is still paid in blood on the battlefield.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

Parenting needs both parents

The Supreme Court has recently urged the Union Government to create a formal law for paternity leave, highlighting that the current system neglects fathers' roles and places all caregiving burdens on mothers. There is little doubt that paternal care is equally important compared with maternal care. Though the approaches of a mother and father differ in parenting, both are vital for a child's healthy and cognitive development.

While mothers tend to prioritise nurturing, direct care and emotional security, fathers often focus on structural play and fostering independence. Paternity leave also helps reduce stress on new mothers and assists in sharing household responsibilities. As long as paternity leave remains optional or absent in India, the idea that parenting is mainly a mother's responsibility will continue to persist.

A law on paternity leave would not just give fathers time off, but would reset expectations, where involvement from both parents becomes normal from the start.

That shift can gradually move society away from rigid gender roles towards a more balanced understanding of family and responsibility.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Justice for CAPFs, stability for the nation

To understand why this Bill matters, one must look beyond promotions, postings, and cadre sensitivities. The issue is larger than administrative preference. It goes to the heart of how India has remained governable, secure, and united despite its diversity, regional complexity, and federal structure

FIRST
Column



ASHOK KUMAR

At a time when India faces increasingly complex internal and border security challenges, the country cannot afford a debate that confuses genuine service grievances with structural injustice, or institutional reform with institutional weakening. The discussion around the CAPF (General Administration) Bill, 2026 has, in some quarters, been framed as if India must choose between the dignity of CAPF officers and the relevance of IPS leadership. That is a false and dangerous binary.

Having served for over 34 years in uniform, including tenures in the CRPF and BSF, in Naxal-affected areas and along the Pakistan and Bangladesh borders, I say with full responsibility that this Bill is not an attack on anyone. It is a balanced reform. It addresses the legitimate concerns of CAPF officers while preserving the institutional structure that has served India's national security interests for decades. In my view, it deserves clear support.

To understand why this Bill matters, one must look beyond promotions, postings, and cadre sensitivities. The issue is larger than administrative preference. It goes to the heart of how India has remained governable, secure, and united despite its diversity, regional complexity, and federal structure.

Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel did not create the All India Services as a bureaucratic convenience. He envisioned them as the steel frame of a unified India. He understood that a country as vast and varied as ours could not be held together through fragmented loyalties, isolated administrative cultures, or region-bound thinking. Without a disciplined and nationally oriented service structure, India risked administrative fragmentation and weak central coordination. In the security domain, such a danger can be disastrous.

It is because of this vision that the IPS has, for decades, functioned not merely as a cadre service but as an institutional bridge between the Union and the states, between intelligence and enforcement, and between state police and CAPFs. This steel frame has helped hold India together.

Those who reduce this debate to a simple question of cadre advancement overlook a



THE CAPFS DO NOT FUNCTION IN ISOLATION. IN MANY SITUATIONS, THEY ASSIST STATE POLICE AND OPERATE WITHIN LOCAL AND DISTRICT-LEVEL COMMAND ENVIRONMENTS DEEPLY ROOTED IN THE STATE POLICING FRAMEWORK

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basic operational truth: internal security in India cannot be managed as a patchwork of disconnected forces. A threat in one district can affect another state. An intelligence input from one agency may require immediate action from another. In such a system, speed, trust, and coordination are essential.

An Intelligence Bureau assessment may need to be translated into field action by a CRPF company in Chhattisgarh, a BSF formation in Jammu, or a state police unit in a sensitive district. Such coordination cannot depend on ad hoc communication or institutional ego. It requires a command ecosystem where officers understand the operational cultures of multiple agencies and can work across them seamlessly.

That is where IPS officers play a vital role. Their professional journey often takes them through state police, CAPFs, and central police organisations such as the CRPF, BSF, IB, and CBI. Coordination between IPS officers of equivalent batches commanding state police and CAPFs is often quicker and more natural because they are institutionally connected. This wider exposure gives them a broader operational perspective and strengthens inter-agency synergy. In a federal democracy like India, that is not an administrative luxury. It is a national security neces-

sity.

I write this not from theory, but from personal experience. I have served in both the CRPF and BSF. I have seen the harsh realities of Naxal-affected terrain, the sensitivity of the Pakistan border, and the complexity of the Bangladesh border. In each of these theatres, one lesson became repeatedly clear: operations succeed when institutions work together, and falter when services function in compartments.

This is why extreme positions on either side are unhelpful. Neither are 100 per cent IPS officers best suited for every role, nor are 100 per cent CAPF officers. Like every institution, every service has highly capable officers and a few black sheep. The mature way forward is not to indulge in absolutist claims, but to build a structure that uses the strengths of both while reducing friction. That is exactly what this Bill seeks to do.

The strongest argument in favour of the CAPF (General Administration) Bill, 2026 is that it does not force the country to choose between fairness and functionality. It seeks to provide both. It codifies essential service rules, creates greater transparency in promotions, provides for fixed tenures, institutionalises grievance redressal, and creates additional senior posts to address long-standing career stagnation.

This is not a token gesture. Career progression has been a real concern for many officers within the CAPFs, and any honest observer must acknowledge that. The Bill responds meaningfully. It creates hundreds of new senior posts at the levels of DIG, IG, and Additional DG. It also implements the Supreme Court's OGAS ruling on orderly gradation and seniority. This is structural reform.

In my own career, I have seen a significant evolution in the service conditions of CAPF personnel. There was a time when many of their institutional concerns remained inadequately addressed. Over the years, however, the system has improved. Facilities, recognition, promotional avenues, and welfare measures have all progressed. This Bill carries that process forward in a codified and transparent manner. It addresses long-standing concerns not through slogans, but through law.

At the same time, the Bill wisely preserves IPS leadership at the top level within the larger internal security architecture. This has become the most politically and emotionally charged aspect of the debate, but it should not be. Preserving IPS leadership in key senior roles is not a slight to CAPF officers. It is a recognition of how

India's federal security system actually works.

The CAPFs do not function in isolation. In many situations, they assist state police and operate within local and district-level command environments deeply rooted in the state policing framework. Officers who have experience in both state police and central forces are naturally better positioned to sustain that bridge.

This is exactly what the Bill protects. By preserving IPS leadership in senior roles while simultaneously expanding opportunities and correcting stagnation for CAPF cadre officers, it balances service justice with national institutional coherence. That is statesmanship, not discrimination.

Unfortunately, some of the public discourse around this issue has been shaped less by institutional seriousness and more by grievance-driven rhetoric. Reform is legitimate and necessary, but reform cannot become a pretext for attacking institutions that have long been central to national security and federal coordination.

India today faces a far more complicated threat environment than it did even a decade ago. Border infiltration, radicalisation, terrorism, left-wing extremism, organised crime, cyber-enabled networks, and communal volatility all demand a high degree of institutional integration. At such a time, weakening inter-service coordination would be a strategic mistake.

To dismantle 75 years of institutional memory in order to solve a promotional bottleneck would be deeply unwise. One cannot repair a staircase by demolishing the building. Administrative reform must improve the structure, not fracture it. The strength of this Bill lies precisely in the fact that it offers reform without rupture.

It recognises the bravery and sacrifice of CAPF personnel. It addresses their legitimate service concerns. It opens pathways for growth and fairness. But it also understands that national security is too serious a matter to be held hostage to narrow institutional rivalry. India needs both genuine welfare and a strong command architecture. This Bill provides both. For all these reasons, I strongly support the CAPF (General Administration) Bill, 2026. It gives promotional relief and administrative clarity to CAPF personnel while preserving the continuity, coordination, and institutional synergy essential to India's internal security system.

That is the right balance. It is fair to CAPF officers, faithful to Sardar Patel's vision, and above all, in the national interest.

Charged, but unchanged: The EV delusion



ACHARYA PRASHANT

Every civilisation in crisis reaches first for the solution that requires it to change the least. This is not cowardice; it is the structural behaviour of the human ego, which will accept any modification to its tools before it will accept an examination of its wants. The current response to the climate emergency follows this pattern with remarkable fidelity: we will change the engine, we will change the fuel, we will change the grid that charges the fuel; but what we will not change, what we are constitutionally unwilling to even place on the table, is the question of why we must travel this far, this fast, this privately, this incessantly, and what exactly we believe we are moving towards.

In the domain of transport, this pattern has found its most consequential expression in the electric vehicle, and the case for it is built on a mathematical error so fundamental that correcting it changes everything. The error is in treating per-vehicle emissions as the relevant unit of measurement, when the actual problem is the product of two variables: how much each vehicle emits, and how many vehicles there are. The EV addresses the first, but leaves the second not only unaddressed but actively growing, because the desire to own a private vehicle is rooted in something no battery has ever touched: the ego's assertion of separateness, its claim to status, its demand to feel that it has arrived. Improve the rate all you want; if the volume grows faster, total emissions rise. This is not a philosophical observation but arithmetic, and the entire EV consensus has been built on leaving it incomplete. The electric vehicle is, by the metrics that matter, a better machine than its petrol counterpart; that fact is not being contested here, and it should be stated plainly before what follows.

The equation nobody completes

A serious climate thinker would say: the EV is one lever among many in a systems-level transition that includes grid decarbonisation, urban redesign, and behavioural change. This is precisely wrong. Behavioural change is not happening at all; it is what the EV was purchased to make unnecessary. The EV does not function as one lever among many; it functions as the lever that releases the hand from the others. The global fleet stood at 1.31 billion in 2020 and is projected to reach 2.21 billion by 2050, with growth concentrated almost entirely in Asia, Africa, Latin America, and the Middle East. The number of vehicles is driven by the ego's claim on mobility, its

insistence on closing the gap between current life and the imagined life of arrival, and, as Jevons observed in 1865 (Jevons Paradox), efficiency gains expand consumption. The EV makes driving cheaper per mile. The ego will use more of it.

The numbers the optimists skip

Consider India, because India makes the calculation most visible. India today has thirty-four cars for every thousand people; the United States has eight hundred and thirty-two. That gap is not merely a statistic; it is an aspiration, and it is not alien to you. It is yours, or it was yours, or it belongs to someone you love, and the EV has made it easier to hold because now it comes with a green conscience attached. India's total vehicle stock is projected to more than double from 226 million to 494 million by 2050; given India's coal-heavy grid, battery EVs currently offer as little as 5 per cent greenhouse gas reduction compared to the existing fleet, and India's grid profile is shared by China, Indonesia, Vietnam, South Africa, and Poland, the majority of the world's fastest-growing vehicle markets. Around 90 per cent of all federal EV tax credits in the United States went to the top income quintile, and in many cases the EV joins rather than replaces the existing petrol car. The footprint grew. The conscience improved.

The driver has not changed

The second variable is driven by the ego, and no improvement to the vehicle reaches the ego, because the vehicle was never primarily a transportation device; it is an ego-object, and the EV is the same ego-object with a cleaner engine. The personal car is a metaphor for the ego itself: sealed, self-directed, insulated from the world it passes through; the driver need never adjust her pace to another's, never sit beside someone she did not choose; the car privatises existence. The electric car is the same assertion, now quieter and cleaner, with the sealed pod intact, the insulation from others intact, and the declaration that one has the right to move through the world on one's own terms, answerable to no shared constraint, entirely undisturbed. This is not incidental to the appeal; it is precisely the appeal, the thing the engineering cannot touch. For the ego that is educated, concerned, and unwilling to relinquish the life it has built, the EV is a salvation narrative: nothing needs to fundamentally change, everything can continue, merely repowered. It arrives in a lineage of such instruments—carbon offset certificates, biofuels, mass tree-planting campaigns—each offering action without transformation and leaving the root intact.

The crisis inside the conscience

The EV is only one expression of a more fundamental error: the belief that the climate crisis is external, amenable to external solutions, and that the inner condition of the person driving the machine is not a relevant variable. The climate crisis is not a product of bad engineering. It is the

ego's inner condition made legible at civilisational scale. The United States Department of Defense emits an estimated fifty to sixty million metric tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent annually, exceeding the total national emissions of Sweden, Norway, or Denmark, and none of it enters any EV lifecycle calculation; it is invisible not because it is unmeasurable but because the ego has arranged that its climate conscience and its geopolitical preferences occupy separate drawers, never to be opened at the same time. The average long-haul return flight produces more carbon dioxide per passenger than most people in lower-income countries produce in an entire year; you, if you are the EV-driving, climate-aware professional, this piece is addressing, likely fly, and each flight is filed in a different mental category from the car, because reconciling them would require examining what the life costs in full, and that examination is what the EV was purchased to make unnecessary. The climate crisis is not a problem the ego has. It is a problem the ego is.

The question that has never been asked

The question the entire EV conversation has avoided is not what we should drive, but why each human being needs to own a private vehicle at all, and what is the incompleteness in us that the private pod is being recruited to fill. That question cannot be answered by a lifecycle analysis, because it concerns not the machine but the one who cannot imagine living without it. And that one is you, the reader, not a generalised consumer, but you, with your own relationship to mobility, to independence, to the freedom from dependence that the private vehicle provides. What is that freedom, exactly? What does it protect you from? What would it cost you to find out?

The technology will improve. The grid will decarbonise. The per-vehicle figures will fall further, and those who have staked their environmental conscience on the battery will cite each improvement as confirmation. None of it changes what has not been asked; it only makes the not-asking more comfortable, more technically defensible, more elaborately self-justified. The engine changes. The fuel changes. The sticker on the number plate changes. The centre from which all of it is driven, the restless, acquisitive, self-enclosed centre that needed the car, needed the military, needed the house, needed the flight, does not change at all. And it is that centre, not the combustion chamber, that is the crisis. It will not be resolved by anything that leaves you untouched. And you know this. The question is only whether that knowledge is something you can afford to stay with.

Acharya Prashant is a teacher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

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From dream to reality: Noida airport takes off



VIVEK SHUKLA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to inaugurate the Noida International Airport at Jewar on March 28, marking a historic milestone for Uttar Pradesh, Delhi-NCR and the nation. Just days away from this grand launch, the airport—popularly known as Jewar Airport—will commence operations as India's newest and one of its most ambitious aviation hubs. Located in Gautam Buddha Nagar district, approximately 75 km from Delhi, this greenfield facility is poised to become the second major airport serving the National Capital Region (NCR). With its inauguration, India takes a significant leap towards addressing the growing demands of its booming aviation industry.

The Noida International Airport (IATA: DXN) has been developed in phases, with Phase I ready to handle 12 million passengers annually. It features a 3,900-metre runway capable of supporting up to 30 aircraft movements per hour, a state-of-the-art terminal spanning 100,000 square metres equipped with 48 check-in counters, 10 aerobridges, nine immigration lanes and advanced security systems. Cargo terminals are fully operational, and the airport will initially focus on both domestic and international flights. Low-cost carriers like IndiGo (the launch airline), Akasa Air and Air India Express are gearing up to operate from here, connecting key cities such as Mumbai, Hyderabad, Kolkata and more. In the long term, the airport aims to scale up to 70 million passengers per annum across multiple phases, eventually featuring multiple runways and positioning itself as one of Asia's largest aviation gateways.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath personally inspected the site multiple times, reviewing progress on the domestic terminal, security arrangements, traffic management and inauguration preparations. He has chaired high-level meetings, directing officials to ensure quality, timeliness and zero laxity in execution.

The airport embodies Yogi's "Triple S" model - Safety, Stability and Speed—that has redefined Uttar Pradesh's development narrative. By prioritising infrastructure like the Jewar project, Uttar Pradesh attracts global partners and investors. Plans for a "Singapore City" near the airport, complete with world-class logistics and investor-friendly ecosystems along the Yamuna Expressway, highlight his forward-thinking approach to turning aviation hubs into economic engines.

Land acquisition for the project, executed with sensitivity towards affected families (offering employment options alongside compensation),



reflects his people-centric policies.

This development is not merely an addition to infrastructure; it is a strategic response to the crippling congestion at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport, which has long exceeded its designed capacity. "I feel by providing a modern alternative, Noida International Airport will decongest NCR's skies, reduce delays and enhance passenger experience. India's aviation sector has been on a rapid growth trajectory, with domestic passenger traffic surging post-pandemic and international connectivity expanding," says Ajit Dubey, an aviation sector expert.

Amrit Mann, Managing Director, Mann Fleet Partners Limited, said, "Noida International Airport represents the future of Indian aviation, and I foresee it will be one of the leading airports in the world." It may be recalled that Noida International Airport strengthened its passenger mobility ecosystem with the appointment of Mann Fleet Partners Limited as its official ground transportation services partner. The collaboration is aimed at delivering seamless, efficient and integrated last-mile connectivity solutions for travellers, enhancing overall passenger convenience across the airport campus. Under the agreement, Mann Fleet Partners Limited will manage a comprehensive portfolio of ground mobility services designed to support smooth passenger movement.

The Noida International Airport's launch comes at a pivotal time for India's aviation ambitions. With air traffic projected to grow exponentially over the next three decades, this facility will play a crucial role in realising the nation's vision of becoming a global aviation leader. It will generate employment on a massive scale, stimulate regional economies and enhance connectivity for millions.

As flights take off from Jewar soon, the airport will not only ease the burden on Delhi but also ignite a new era of prosperity. It stands as a testament to collaborative governance—between the Centre and the state—and Yogi's unwavering focus on transformative infrastructure. India's skies are set to expand, and Noida International Airport will be at the forefront, soaring high as a beacon of progress.

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FREE FIERCE FALL

Yet again, in another free fall, the Sensex, or the Bombay Stock Exchange index, fell by nearly 1,700 points. It marked the end of a rough week, or five trading sessions, when hopes were rekindled as the index gained almost 3,000 points, before it shed 2,500 of those, and closed at nearly 75,600 points. However, over the week, the gain of more than 500 points provided some relief to the investors, who have seen the Sensex engaged in a free, fierce fall from highs touching 86,000 points in November 2025, to more than 10,000 points down.

Yesterday's fall was premised on the reactions in the US stock markets the previous night (Thursday), when the Iran war and global crude oil prices "rattled global markets, impacting not just stocks but safe havens like bonds, gold, and currencies. That is leaving investors with fewer places to hide." It was one of those rare days, when no asset class seemed safe, there was nowhere to go, and investors felt trapped in a dark, dingy cellar, with the only exit shut. People were reminded of the song with the lyrics, "Nowhere to run, baby, nowhere to hide."

On Thursday, the US Dow Jones was down by one per cent, S&P 500 by 1.75 per cent, and Nasdaq by more than two per cent. Gold futures fell by four per cent, and investors sold bonds as treasury yields widened. On a larger basis, the S&P 500 is seven per cent lower than its high in January 2026, and gold fell 17 per cent in March 2026. The former may be on its way, say experts, to record its worst month since October 2008, which was the height of the 'Great Recession.' As we said earlier, you have got nowhere to run, baby, nowhere to hide.

Obviously, the overreaction, or shall we say understatement, in the markets came from contradictory war signals. Iran rejected the 15-point peace plan initiated by the US, even as America maintained that talks were on, and president Donald Trump gave Iran another period of reprieve until early April. Not sure, whether the war was ending, or peace initiatives were in place, global crude oil went up. As an analyst remarked, "There is really no clarity on when this war will end, despite a lot of confusing commentary." Most of the latter comes from the 'top.'

Another analyst took a more straightforward, yet philosophical, approach. "The Strait of Hormuz remains essentially shut, the conflict is not over, and Truth Social (president Trump's) posts are not a replacement for concrete diplomatic discussions that can lead to a lasting end to the conflict across the region." In a sense, statements cannot replace actions, and wishes cannot substitute for strategies. America's strategy was that the war would end quickly. Now that it has not, there is no other blueprint in place, except for a possible demand of \$200 billion from the Congress to continue to fight the war.

In the recent past, Trump's statements about peace talks, peace points, peace pauses, and decimation of Iran moved the markets positively. But on Thursday (in the US) and Friday (in India), the possible pause in escalation raised hopes, which were dented by the lack of actual breakthroughs. Finally, on-ground actions trumped messages. In effect, according to analysts, the Indian markets were closed on Thursday, and were forced to play catch-up to the trends in the other markets. Thursday's volatility in Asia and the US impacted Indian equities.

When a war is on, and each side, including those which are not directly related to the war, resorts to half-truths, hopes, propaganda, and realities, investors react to the present. But the present itself is vitiated, with no clarity. Hence, the reactions are knee-jerk, immediate, with no predictions of what is likely to happen the next day. Over time, investors tend to disbelieve the news and headlines, or over-believe them, which creates more volatility. Finally, the fed-up investors resort to profit-booking at every change they get, and can grab. This enhances the fluctuations, as momentum resets every few hours.

Indeed, on Friday, profit-booking was in the forefront. After the Sensex gained in the previous two sessions, investors lined up to make whatever gains were available. This explains why the Friday fall was broad-based, as the 16 major sectors logged losses. Apart from the large caps, and renowned stocks like Reliance Industries, the small-cap index slid by 1.7 per cent, and midcap one by more than two per cent. Only a few state-owned firms, like ONGC, gained. The oil explorer gained more than four per cent on Friday, and enjoyed its best week in the past two months, as it is a major beneficiary of high crude oil prices.

According to an analyst, "The Indian economy is strong enough to absorb the shock if the war ends, crude cools down, and gas availability becomes normal." In essence, if things happened as if the war was never there, being played in the minds of the global leaders. However, he adds, "The market hope is that since a prolonged war is in nobody's interest, it may end soon. The US itself is now looking for an exit strategy." But exits are clouded by smoke, fire, and flames. Maybe some windows and ventilators will open, as the smoke clears up.

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BUSINESS10

Meta under the tube with Musk

Three last-week orders may propel anti-social media policies

Three American court orders indicate mounting social and business pressures on three social media sites, although one of them considers itself a streaming platform. In social terms, two of the orders, against Meta (Facebook, WhatsApp, and Instagram) and YouTube (Google), accept that social media influences the children, makes them addictive to online messaging, and hurts them. In business terms, the third one, against X (Twitter), agrees that advertisers can boycott a platform, and it does not logically lead to unfair competition. In some ways, the legal trio establishes a growing thinking among policy-makers.

On three consecutive days this week, the rulings pushed the social media sites on the back-foot, much like what the legal proceedings did with the global tobacco firms during the 1990s. Like in the case of the latter, when cigarettes were banned from the public arena, advertising was restricted, and medical warnings appeared on packets, the three weekly judgments against social media will mark the beginnings of how we will view social media apps in the future. "This is just the beginning," claimed a trial lawyer, and the orders indicate that the negative sentiments have "finally boiled over," according to a researcher.

First, on Tuesday (March 24), a jury in New Mexico stated that Meta needs to pay \$375 million because its products led to "child sexual exploitation, among other harms." The next day, another one in California imposed a much-smaller \$6 million fine on Meta and YouTube as they "deliberately designed addictive products to hook young users." This is reminiscent of the attacks on the tobacco firms, which knew that cigarettes were addictive but denied the claims, and aggressively pushed the products in the marketplaces. More cases are likely to follow in the US, and possibly other nations.

On Thursday (March 26), a lawsuit by Elon Musk, the owner of X, and other new-age and space-

age firms, which accused some advertisers of conspiring against X, and illegally boycotting the platform, was thrown out by a US district judge, Jane Boyle. The judge said that X could not prove that it suffered harm under the competition laws due to the advertising withdrawal by global marketing giants such as Unilever, Mars, and Orsted. There was no conspiracy or concerted efforts to deny revenues worth billions of dollars to Musk's X.

According to a media report, the Californian jury found that the social media platforms acted with "malice, oppression, and fraud." In a joint statement, the lead lawyers, who represented families, schools, and others, said, "This verdict is bigger than one case. For years, social media companies have profited from targeting children while concealing their addictive and dangerous design features. Today's verdict is a referendum, from a jury, to an entire industry, that accountability has arrived." The term referendum emerges from the fact that 10 out of the 12 jurors voted against the social media sites and, according to an expert, "heard six weeks of testimony, sat through 44 hours of deliberation, and reached a resounding conclusion."

Meta and YouTube disagreed with the orders, and stated that they would file appeals. According to YouTube, the Californian jury misunderstood its business operations, and designated it as a "social media site," while it is merely a video-streaming platform. Meta's reaction was detailed and categorical. "Teen mental health is profoundly complex, and cannot be linked to a single app. We will continue to defend ourselves vigorously, as every case is different, and we remain confident in our record of protecting teens online," said a spokesperson. It took relief from the fact that it was not a unanimous verdict.

What is crucial is that the legal backlash was partly established via the internal documents of Meta and YouTube. One of them from the latter asked a question if the firm measured "wellbeing," and answered that it did not. The ones from Meta accepted that the "young ones are best ones," and targeting them was a good "gateway" to entice other family members. Indeed, an email from an employee admitted that "targeting 11-year-olds feels like tobacco companies a couple of decades ago." What is worse, an internal Meta memo read, "Data shows that Instagram had become the leading two-sided marketplace for human trafficking."

For many observers, especially those in their 50s and above, this reminded them of the tactics of the tobacco firms. Internal memos, studies, and communications proved that they knew about the addictive and extreme medical effects of cigarettes. Yet, they refused to share them, junked them, and indeed used them to improve market shares, especially among the younger smokers. In public, they financed research that proved minimal or ambiguous links between smoking and cancer, and that smoking does not cause the disease.

Musk's challenges seem different, although they are connected to the overall operations and profitability of social media. When he took over X in a controversial manner, and a recent order agreed that he misled investors, and caused them losses, he made sweeping changes that were unacceptable to users, experts, and even advertisers. Within a year, ad revenues fell by more than half. His lawsuit claimed that the advertisers conspired against their self-interest to withdraw money, which violated the antitrust laws. The firms withheld advertising by following codes set by a global alliance, which stank of conspiracy.

However, the district judge disagreed. She maintained that the global alliance was not involved in the advertising process. The latter did not buy ad space from X, and sell it to advertisers. It did not tell X not to sell independently to the advertisers. "The very nature of the alleged conspiracy does not state an antitrust claim, and the court therefore has no qualm dismissing with prejudice," said the judge. The advertisers had argued that they acted independently, and were not dependent on the global alliance for such decisions.

But what is important in the three orders is that it will propel the policy-makers to impose restrictions on social media's access to children, as well as advertising that enables illegal and harmful content. In India, some of the states have introduced laws to ban such access to the youngsters. The Economic Survey advocated a national policy. At the same time, lawyers believe that "if they bring enough cases, and keep winning, eventually it will be simpler for the companies to change their platforms than to keep fighting in court." In the US, advocates focus on a multi-pronged strategy to urge the Congress to pass laws, create attention through public campaigns, and file more lawsuits.

A Left-Handed Economist

Urban centres cannot hold demand

Uneven demand across geographies, price-points, and products

"While the initial supply and pricing adjustments led to moderated consumption... organised channels responded faster to the structural changes. We expect the positive impact of GST 2.0 on consumption to become more visible from the January-February-March (2026) quarter onwards." In other words, while the earlier, possibly, repressed demand in the cases of passenger vehicles and two wheelers was unleashed after GST 2.0, the ongoing and regular demand in FMCG suffered because of the price disruptions, and changes. Different sectors, different dynamics, different strokes.

Several macro changes account for these subtle, but crucial, trends in private consumption, and urban-rural divide. Inflation matters. Even as headline inflation moderated, and food inflation became invisible, the Iran war has perked them up. Despite the low hikes now, the earlier ones impacted household budgets, which never fully reversed. This was more in the cases of lower- and middle-income consumers. Spending adjustments tend to show up first in discretionary categories, and frequency of purchases rather than in absolute withdrawals.

A second factor is the uneven nature of income recovery. Formal sector income growth is relatively stable, despite the disruptions due to the pandemic, Russia-Ukraine war, tech changes, and Iran war, for the high-income segments. Joblessness mostly affects the youngsters, and new entrants. These support higher-

income consumption. But wage growth in informal and semi-formal segments are inconsistent. This creates divergence within the urban markets. Rural markets have their own dynamics, largely due to farm incomes. Migration trends change, as rural women still opt out of the jobs market.

A third layer is linked to consumption behaviour. Urban buying is being redistributed rather than uniformly expanding. A larger share of discretionary spending is moving toward services such as travel, entertainment, and experiences. This shift affects categories that rely on repeat, high-frequency purchases, and adds another layer to the slowdown in mass consumption. The result is an environment where signals are mixed rather than uniformly positive or negative. Rural demand, which was the real engine of growth, has sputtered a bit. But the high-value urban consumption may make up for it.

For companies, the implication is that relying on a single narrative of consumption expansion is no longer sufficient. Growth strategies need to account for the divergences across income groups, geographies, and product categories. Pricing and product mix can support revenues in the short term, but sustained expansion requires recovery in volumes. If this imbalance persists, the risks are clear. Volume-led growth may remain weak, premium segments may become crowded as firms chase the same consumers, and pricing-led growth may begin to lose out.

Over time, this can affect the quality and durability of earnings.

Urban India has the income and credit capacity to support discretionary spending, but this is becoming selective. In effect, parts of urban India are spending, but not in the categories that once gave firms dependable volume growth. This is where the "plateau" risk comes in. The easiest urban gains are finished. High-base comparisons make year-on-year growth harder to sustain. Entry-level categories show strain. Firms lean on mix and pricing. The stronger sections of urban demand are in upper-middle-income and affluent consumers. FMCG giant, Marico, in the Q4-FY25 update, noted healthy sentiment among upper-middle and affluent urban segments, and described the broader picture as mixed.

The fragility becomes important in the current external environment. India's private-sector growth fell to a three-year low as the Middle East war weighs on demand, and elevated crude prices become a macro risk. SBI Research concluded that if global crude oil stays near \$100 a barrel, India's GDP growth could fall to 6.6 per cent, and inflation rise to 4.1 per cent. At \$130 a barrel, the impact on growth might be severe, down to six per cent. These estimates matter for consumption because broad-based demand is hardest to sustain when external shocks raise costs. The strengths at the top, and gradual recovery at the bottom of the consumption pyramid are not enough, not at present.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

GOVT CUTS EXCISE DUTY ON PETROL, DIESEL BY ₹10

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government has slashed excise duty on petrol and diesel by ₹10 per litre, averting a pump price hike that had become necessary because of soaring global oil prices.

The cut in special additional excise duty on petrol from ₹13 a litre to ₹3 and the same on diesel from ₹10 per litre to nil, will lead to an estimated revenue loss of ₹1.75 lakh crore.

Alongside, the Government brought back duties on export of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF), according to a notification issued late on Thursday.

The Government also imposed an export duty of ₹21.5 per litre on diesel and ₹29.5 per litre on aviation turbine fuel (ATF), reinstating a levy first introduced in July 2022 to curb windfall gains by refiners following Russia's invasion of Ukraine and later withdrawn in December 2024.

However, unlike last time, there is no windfall tax that has been levied on domestic crude oil producers like

ONGC. The war in the Middle East has pushed international oil prices up by 50 per cent to over \$100 per barrel. At current international crude prices, petrol prices should have been increased by ₹26 a litre and diesel by ₹81.90.

While state-owned oil marketing companies had so far been absorbing the impact of high oil prices, the current situation had become financially untenable, sources said, adding that to mitigate some of the losses, the Government cut excise duty which has been adjusted against the required increase in prices. Pump prices remain unchanged after the excise revision.

After reduction in duty, the incidence of excise on petrol will be ₹11.9 per litre (₹1.40 basic excise duty, ₹3 special additional excise duty, ₹2.50 agriculture infrastructure and development cess, and ₹5 road infrastructure cess).

On diesel, the incidence will be ₹7.80 per litre (₹1.80 basis excise duty, ₹4 agriculture infrastructure and development cess, and ₹2 road and infrastructure cess).

Considering 175 billion litres of auto fuel sales annu-



ally (115 billion litres of diesel and 60 billion litres of petrol), the impact of the duty cut will be ₹1.75 lakh crore annually. The excise duty cut follows record losses that oil companies suffered from the surge in international oil prices. Prices of crude oil, the raw material for making petrol and diesel, have surged almost 50 per cent this month as the US and Israel attack on Iran and Tehran's sweeping retaliation disrupts global supply. Despite oil prices rising above \$100 per barrel, retail pump rates had

remained on freeze. This had led to oil companies incurring record losses which had even started impacting their working capital.

To ease the pain, the Government cut excise duty. The reduction will be adjusted against the ₹24 a litre required increase in petrol and ₹30 per litre hike in diesel rates warranted due to the rise in international oil prices.

Rating agency ICRA, in a note on Thursday, said if the average crude oil price goes up to \$100-105 per barrel, fuel retailers will incur a

loss of ₹11 per litre on petrol and ₹14 per litre on diesel, respectively.

International oil prices touched \$119 per barrel earlier this month on the intensifying Iran war, before pulling back to around \$100 a barrel.

The first signs of stress came when Nayara Energy, the country's largest private fuel retailer, raised petrol price by ₹5 per litre and diesel by ₹3 a litre on Thursday. Petrol at Nayara pumps now costs ₹100.71 a litre and diesel costs ₹91.31 per litre. State-

owned fuel retailers, who control about 90 per cent of the market, continue to keep rates frozen. A litre of normal petrol in Delhi continues to cost ₹94.77 at their outlets, while the same grade diesel comes for ₹87.67 a litre.

"At current international crude prices, under-recoveries stand at approximately ₹26 per litre on petrol and ₹81.90 per litre on diesel. The combined daily under-recovery being absorbed by OMCs is approximately ₹2,400 crore," an oil ministry statement said.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in a post on X said the reduction in excise duty "will provide protection to consumers from rise in prices". The Government, she said, has always ensured that citizens are protected from vagaries of supply and costs of essential goods.

"Further, duties have been imposed on exports of diesel at ₹21.5 per litre and on ATF at ₹29.5 per litre. This will ensure adequate availability of these products for domestic consumption," she added.

Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said international crude prices have gone through

the roof in the last one month from around \$70 dollars per barrel to around \$122. "Consequently, petrol and diesel prices for consumers have gone up all over the world. Prices have increased by around 30-50 per cent in Southeast Asian countries, 30 per cent in North American countries, 20 per cent in Europe and 50 per cent in African countries," he said, adding that the Government had two choices — either increase prices drastically or bear the brunt on its finances.

In keeping with the commitment of the last four years since the conflict in Russia-Ukraine started, the Government decided to take a hit on its own finances again to safeguard the Indian citizens.

"The Government has taken a huge hit on its taxation revenues to ensure very high losses of oil companies (approximately ₹24 per litre for petrol and ₹30 a litre for diesel) at this time of sky high international prices are reduced," he said. "At the same time, export tax has been levied as international prices of petrol and diesel have skyrocketed and any

refinery exporting to foreign nations will have to pay export tax."

Puri said the global situation remains in flux, and the Government is closely monitoring developments across energy, supply chains, and essential commodities on a real-time basis.

"All necessary steps are being taken to ensure uninterrupted availability of fuel, energy, and other critical supplies for our citizens. We are fully prepared to handle emerging challenges," he said. India, he said, has consistently demonstrated resilience in the face of global uncertainties, and we will continue to act in a timely, proactive, and coordinated manner.

"Rumours of a lockdown in India are completely false. Let me state this clearly, there is no such proposal under consideration by the Government of India," he said.

"In such times, it is important that we remain calm, responsible, and united. Attempts to spread rumours and create panic in such a situation are irresponsible and harmful."

Stock markets dive over 2 per cent amid uncertainties, rising crude prices

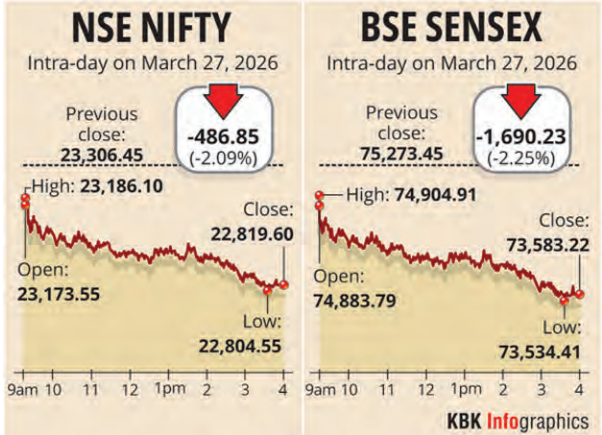
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Equity benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled over 2 per cent on Friday after a two-day rally, in tandem with a weak trend in global peers, as the US-Iran conflict continues to be the crucial overhang for markets, raising doubts about a de-escalation of the war.

Crude oil prices staying above the \$100 per barrel mark, the rupee's free fall and unabated foreign fund outflows also added to the gloom.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,690.23 points, or 2.25 per cent, to settle at 73,583.22. During the day, it plunged 1,739.04 points, or 2.31 per cent, to 73,534.41.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 486.85 points, or 2.09 per cent, to end at



22,819.60. From the 30-Sensex firms, Reliance Industries dropped the most by 4.55 per cent, followed by InterGlobe Aviation, Bajaj Finance, State Bank of India, Eternal and HDFC Bank. In contrast, Tata Consultancy Services, Bharti Airtel and Power Grid were the gainers.

Brent crude, the global oil

benchmark, jumped 1.72 per cent to \$109.9 per barrel.

The rupee tanked 86 paise to close at yet another all-time low of 94.82 (provisional) against the US dollar on Friday. In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi and Japan's Nikkei 225 index ended lower, while Shanghai's SSE Composite

index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index settled in positive territory. Markets in Europe were trading in the red.

The US market ended sharply lower on Thursday. "Profit booking set in after the recent two-session rally as the rupee fell to an all-time low amid sustained FI selling, while escalating tensions in the Middle East heightened caution among investors ahead of the weekend," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said. Stock markets were closed on Thursday on account of Ram Navami.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹1,805.37 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth ₹5,429.78 crore.

Wall Street logs worst day since start of Iran war

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Hong Kong

World shares mostly fell while oil gained again on Friday as Wall Street saw its worst day since the start of the Iran war, owing to growing doubts over de-escalation.

In early European trading, Britain's FTSE 100 fell 0.3 per cent to 9,939.96. France's CAC 40 dropped 0.7 per cent to 7,718.97, and Germany's DAX lost 1.3 per cent to 22,314.28.

In Asia, Tokyo's Nikkei 225 closed 0.4 per cent lower at 53,373.07. South Korea's Kospi also lost 0.4 per cent to 5,438.87, narrowing the sharp drop earlier in the day at trading close.

Hong Kong's Hang Seng was up 0.4 per cent to 24,951.88 after dipping



earlier in the day, while the Shanghai Composite index traded 0.6 per cent higher at 3,913.72. Australia's S&P/ASX 200 fell 0.1 per cent to 8,516.30.

Taiwan's Taiex was 0.7 per cent lower, while India's Sensex lost 2.1 per cent.

On Thursday, Wall Street fell to its worst drop since the Iran war began, with the S&P 500 sinking 1.7 per cent for its worst day since

January to 6,477.16. The Dow Jones Industrial Average fell 1 per cent to 45,960.11. The Nasdaq composite slumped 2.4 per cent to 21,408.08, and is off 10 per cent below its recent all-time high in what is considered a "correction".

Expectations this week of de-escalation negotiations between Washington and Tehran have sent markets into disarray.

Indian aviation industry outlook negative; weak near-term demand: ICRA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Ratings agency Investment Information and Credit Rating Agency of India Limited (ICRA) on Friday revised its outlook on the Indian aviation industry to negative from stable, citing disruptions in international airspace following escalation of geopolitical tensions in West Asia.

The revision in outlook is also on account of a sharp depreciation of the rupee against the US dollar and an expected increase in jet fuel (ATF) prices, ICRA said.

cent for FY27. However, these projections now carry a downward bias, it said. Flight cancellations due to airspace closures, coupled with higher airfares following the levy of fuel surcharges (estimated at 5-6 per cent of average ticket prices), are expected to weigh on passenger traffic growth, ICRA said.

Additionally, rerouting of flights is likely to increase fuel burn and operating costs, the ratings agency said.

Moreover, the removal of airfare caps by the DGCA, which were introduced in December last year following



These factors are likely to significantly increase cost pressures for airlines, even as demand growth faces downside risks, it said.

The ratings agency said it expects domestic air passenger traffic growth to be at 0-3 per cent for the ongoing fiscal year and international passenger traffic growth for Indian carriers at 7-9 per cent, indicating a relatively weak near-term demand environment.

Prior to the West Asian crisis, ICRA had estimated domestic air passenger traffic growth at 6-8 per cent and international traffic growth for Indian carriers at 8-10 per

operational disruptions at IndiGo poses further downside risks.

A sharp rise in ticket prices could dampen travel demand going forward, ICRA said. ICRA had earlier projected net losses for the aviation industry to narrow to ₹11,000-12,000 crore in FY27, supported by traffic growth.

However, the recent geopolitical developments, along with adverse currency movements and rising fuel costs, have introduced a downward bias to these estimates, it said, adding that for FY26, the industry is expected to report net losses of ₹17,000-18,000 crore.

Crude oil futures pare losses; rise nearly 2% on global cues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices pared early losses to trade nearly 2 per cent higher at ₹9,061 per barrel in futures trade on Friday, tracking gains in global energy benchmarks amid geopolitical uncertainty in West Asia.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude oil for the April delivery opened lower at ₹ 8,820 per barrel, but later reversed losses to trade higher by ₹ 143, or 1.59 per cent, to ₹9,142 per barrel.

Similarly, the May contract also recovered losses and climbed ₹42, or 1.63 per cent, to ₹8,866 per barrel on the MCX.

Crude oil prices have traded back and forth during the week, and are currently hovering around ₹8,900 levels in the domestic markets, Aamir Makda, Commodity & Currency Analyst at Choice Broking, said. In international markets, West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude for the May contract gained \$1.12, or 1.19 per cent, to \$95.60 per barrel, while Brent Crude for the June delivery edged up by 1.13 per cent to \$103.04 per barrel in New York.

Makda said crude oil prices remained volatile due to a lack of resolution in the Iran conflict and contradictory statements by US



President Donald Trump. Ongoing tensions have disrupted exports through the Strait of Hormuz, pushing storage tanks to critical levels and raising concerns over potential output cuts if shipping con-

straints persist. In addition, around 40 per cent of Russia's oil exports have reportedly been halted following Ukrainian drone attacks on major pipelines, adding to supply concerns, he said.

AI project: UP Govt scraps ₹25,000 cr MoU with Bengaluru-based startup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh Government has cancelled a proposed ₹25,000 crore Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed with Bengaluru-based startup Puch AI for developing artificial intelligence infrastructure in the state, citing lack of financial credibility on the part of the firm.

In a statement issued on the official handle of InvestUP on Thursday, the Government said the decision was taken after a review conducted as per standard operating procedures revealed that the company did not possess the requisite net worth or credible financial linkages to execute a project of such magnitude.

"As per standard protocols laid by the state

Government, the MoU signed with Puch AI on March 23, 2026, was reviewed. Necessary details were sought from the investor, but they were not provided in a timely manner.

Due-diligence showed lack of net worth and credible financial linkages for the project's scale," the statement said.

It added that the agreement stands cancelled with

immediate effect and no rights or obligations remain between the parties.

The Government emphasised that the move was taken in the interest of transparency and maintaining high standards of probity in governance.

The now-scrapped MoU, announced earlier this week, was projected as a major initiative to position Uttar Pradesh as a hub for emerging technologies.



WhatsApp rolls out dual account support for iPhone users

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Meta-owned messaging platform WhatsApp on Friday announced a slew of new features, allowing Apple iPhone users to operate two accounts on a single device simultaneously, while also introducing new Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools for photo editing and drafting messages.

The 'two accounts, one phone' feature, which was previously available only to Android users, is now rolling out on iOS.

The company in a blog post said the update eliminates the need for users to carry two separate devices to manage personal and work conversations. Users will be able to identify the active account via a profile picture visible in the bottom tab of the app.

Riding the generative AI



wave, WhatsApp is also integrating Meta AI directly into chats. Users can now utilise Meta AI to touch up photos, remove distracting elements, swap backgrounds, or apply different styles before sending an image.

Additionally, an 'AI Writing Help' feature will now draft suggested responses based on the context of the conversation.

Addressing potential security concerns regarding the AI tool, WhatsApp emphasised that user chats will remain

"completely private". The company noted that the Meta AI features may not be available to all users immediately.

The update also simplifies cross-platform chat transfers. The platform now officially supports moving chat history, including photos and videos, from iOS to Android devices.

Other additions include predictive sticker suggestions, allowing users to swap an emoji for a suggested sticker as they type.

G7 meet: Rubio tries to sell US strategy to sceptical allies

MATTHEW LEEAP
■ Vaux-de-Cernay (France)

Group of Seven foreign ministers met in France on Friday to discuss the conflicts in West Asia, and between Russia and Ukraine, with deep divisions apparent over the US-Israel war with Iran following US President Donald Trump’s repeated complaints that US’ allies have ignored or rejected requests for help in confronting Iran’s retaliation, including the closure of the Strait of Hormuz to most of international shipping.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio joined his counterparts from G7 nations only 24 hours after Trump’s latest volley of insults lobbed at NATO, as instability in oil markets persisted with the Iran

war entering its fourth week along with uncertainty over the status of potential negotiations to end the crisis.

Most of US’ closest allies have greeted the Iran war with deep scepticism, sentiments that were on display as the G7 foreign ministers met at a historic 12th-century abbey in Vaux-de-Cernay, outside Paris, even as they urged a diplomatic solution to resolve the situation. As the diplomats gathered, France’s Minister of the Armed Forces Catherine Vautrin said the war in the Middle East “is not ours”, adding that France’s position is strictly defensive.

“The aim is truly this diplomatic approach, which is the only one that can guarantee a return to peace,” she said on



Europe 1 and CNews. “Many countries are concerned, and it is absolutely essential that we find a solution.

British Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper, meanwhile, said Britain also favoured a diplomatic path, acknowledging differences with the US. “We have taken the approach of supporting defensive action, but also we’ve taken a different approach on the offensive action that has taken place as part of this conflict,” she said.

Rubio has already faced difficulties in trying to sell the US strategy for the Iran conflict, but Trump’s vitriolic comments about NATO countries not stepping up to help the US and Israel during a Cabinet meeting on Thursday will likely make it an even tougher task.

Of the G7 nations — besides the US — Britain, Canada, France, Germany and Italy are members of the trans-Atlantic military alliance, Japan is the only one that is not. “We are very disappointed with NATO because NATO has done absolutely nothing,” Trump said, a sentiment echoed later by his top diplomat.

“Frankly, I think countries around the world, even those that are out there complaining about this a little bit, should actually be grateful that the United States has a president that’s willing to confront a threat like this,” Rubio said Thursday.

Rubio, who chatted briefly with Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha, also still has work to do to smooth things over with allies like those in Europe that have

faced criticism or outright threats from Trump and others in his Republican administration. Europe is still smarting over Trump’s earlier demands to take over Greenland from NATO-ally Denmark and are concerned over US support to Ukraine in its war with Russia. The conflict in the Middle East has added another point of tension.

Asked by reporters about the reception he was expecting before boarding his flight to France, Rubio said he was looking forward to gathering with his G7 counterparts, asserting “we’re going to have great meetings”.

“I’m not there to make them happy,” he said. “I get along with all of them on a personal level, and we work with those governments very carefully, but the people I’m

interested in making happy are the people of the United States. That’s who I work for. I don’t work for France or Germany or Japan.”

He later posted on X that he would be meeting “world leaders about the security concerns we share around the world and opportunities to address the situation in the Middle East and the Russia-Ukraine war”.

Trump’s complains over lack of support from allies

Trump has complained that he has not been able to rally support over the war on Iran, and that NATO and most other allies have rejected his calls to help secure the Strait of Hormuz, where Iran’s chokehold has disrupted oil shipments and pushed up energy prices. (AP)

OFFICE OF THE RECOVERY OFFICER- II DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL- II, DELHI
04TH FLOOR, JEEVAN TARA BUILDING PARLIAMENT STREET, NEW DELHI- 110001

Under the provisions of Second Schedule of Income Tax Act, 1961

E- AUCTION SALE NOTICE

Dated : 10.03.2026

RC No.172/2018

THE HONGKONG & SHANGHAI BANK CORPORATION LTD.
VERSUS
MR. SUKHBIR SINGH
"ORDER"

As per my order dated 10.03.2026 the under mentioned property will be sold by public e-auction sale on 29.04.2026 in the said Recovery Certificate:-

The auction sale will be "online e-Auctioning" through website
https://bankauctions.com

Date and Time of Auction: 29.04.2026 between 11.00 am and 12.00 noon
(With extensions of 5 minutes duration after 12 noon, if required)

Description of Property		
Description of Property	Reserve Price (In Rs.)	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (In Rs.)
C-1/D, Ground Floor, Front Half Portion Measuring 220 sq. yards, Green Park Extension, New Delhi- 110016	1,87,00,000/-	1,87,00,000/-

TERMS AND CONDITIONS

1. The auction sale will be "online through e-auction" through website portal: https://bankauctions.com

2. The EMD shall be paid either through Demand Draft/Pay Order in favour of the "Recovery Officer-II, DRT-II, Delhi-A/c R.C. No. 172/2018" or through NEFT/RTGS to the following account - HSBC Bank, Beneficiary Name: E-Auction EMD Suspense, Account No. 01090968042, IFSC, Code: HSBC0400002. The said Demand Draft/Pay Order or original proof of payment through NEFT/RTGS qua EMD, alongwith self-attested copy of identity (voter I-card/driving license/passport), which should contain the address for future communication, and self-attested copy of PAN card, and in the case of company, copy of resolution passed by the board members of the company and any other document confirming representation/ attorney of the company also, must reach the Office of the Recovery Officer- II, DRT-II, Delhi latest by 27.04.2026 before 4.00 PM. In the case of individual, a declaration if the bid is on his/her own behalf or on behalf of his/her principals be also submitted. In the latter case, the bidder shall be required to deposit his/her authority and in case of default, his/her bid shall be rejected. The EMD or original proof of the EMD received thereafter shall not be considered. In addition, the bid form annexed duly filled should also reach as per the aforesaid timing.

3. The envelope containing EMD or original proof of payment of EMD through NEFT/RTGS, along with details of the sender, i.e. address, e-mail ID and mobile number, etc, should be super-scribed "RC NO. 172/2018".

4. The property is being sold on "as is where is basis" & "as is what is basis".

5. The bidders are advised to go through the portal https://bankauctions.com for detailed terms and condition's for e-auction sale before submitting their bids and taking part in the e-auction sale proceedings and/or contact Sh. Rohit Dutt Tyagi, Mobile No. 9811911073, Email ID: - rohit.tyagi@hsbc.co.in.

6. Prospective bidders are required to register themselves with the portal and obtain login ID and Password well in advance; after deposit of EMD, which is mandatory for bidding in the above e-auction, from M/s C-1 India Pvt. Ltd Udyog Vihar, Phase-2, Gulf Petrochem Building, Plot No. 301, Gurgaon-122015, Haryana, Sh. Mithalesh Kumar, Assistant Manager, Mobile No. 7080804466 E-mail ID:- mithalesh.kumar@c1india.com & delhi@c1india.com, support@bankauctions.com.

7. The interested bidders may avail online training on e-auction, after deposit of EMD, from M/s C-1 India Pvt. Ltd., Udyog Vihar, Phase-2, Gulf Petrochem Building, Plot No. ' 301, Gurgaon-122015, Haryana, Sh. Mithalesh Kumar, Assistant Manager, Mobile No. 7080804466 E-mail ID:- mithalesh.kumar@c1india.com & delhi@c1india.com, support@bankauctions.com.

8. The prospective buyer may inspect the site on 07.04.2026 and 08.04.2026 from 10.30 AM to 04.00 PM.

9. Only those bidders holding valid user ID & Password and confirmed payment of EMD through demand draft/pay order or NEFT/RTGS shall be eligible to participate in online e-auction.

10. The interested bidders, who have submitted their bids not below the reserve price by 27.04.2026 before 4.00 PM in the office of the Recovery Officer-II, DRT-II, Delhi, shall be eligible to participate in the e-auction to be held from 11.00 AM to 12.00 Noon on 29.04.2026. In case bid is placed in the last 5 minutes of the closing time of the auction, the closing time will automatically get extended for 5 minutes.

11. The bidders shall improve their offer in multiples of Rs.1,00,000/- (Rupees One Lac Only).

12. The unsuccessful bidder shall take the EMD directly from the Office of Recovery Officer-II, DRT-II, Delhi/CH, i.e., INDIAN OVERSEAS BANK, immediately on closure of the e-auction sale proceedings..

13. The Successful / highest bidder shall have to prepare Demand Draft/Pay Order for 25% of the bid/sale amount, after adjusting the EMD, favoring Recovery Officer-I, DRT-II, Delhi, A/c R.C. No. 172/2018 by next bank working day i.e. by 04.00 PM with this Tribunal.

14. The successful/highest bidder shall deposit, through Demand Draft/Pay Order favoring Recovery Officer-I, DRT-II, Delhi, A/c R.C. No. 172/2018, the balance 75% of the sale proceeds before the Recovery Officer-I, DRT-II, Delhi on or before 15th day from the date of auction of the property, exclusive of such day, or if the 15th day be Sunday or other holiday, then on the first office day after the 15th day along with the postage fee @ 2% upto Rs.1,000 and @ 1% on the excess of such gross amount over Rs. 1000/- in favour of Registrar, DRT-II Delhi. (In case of deposit of balance amount of 75% through post the same should reach the Recovery Officer as above). In case of default of payment within the prescribed period, the property shall be re-sold, after the issue of fresh proclamation of sale. The deposit, after defraying the expenses of the sale, may, if the undersigned thinks fit, be forfeited to the Government and the defaulting purchaser shall forfeit all claims to the property or to any part of the sum for which it may subsequently be sold.

15. CHFI/CH Bank is directed to serve the Sale proclamation on CDs through Dasti, speed post, courier and by affixation at the conspicuous part of the property and by beat of drum in its vicinity and a copy of the same be placed on the notice board of the Tribunal.

16. Sale proclamation be also published in the Newspapers in English as well as in vernacular language, having adequately wide circulation in the area.

17. CHFI/CH Bank is directed to confirm the publication of advertisement in the Newspapers and original proofs of the publication be filed before next date of hearing.

18. The undersigned reserves the right to accept any or reject all bids, if not found acceptable or to postpone the auction at any time without assigning any reason whatsoever and his decision in this regard shall be final.

SCHEDULE OF PROPERTY

Description of the property to be sold	Revenue assessed upon the property or any part thereof	Details of any encumbrance to which property is liable	Claims, if any, which have been put forward to the property, and any other known particulars bearing on itsnature and value.
C-1/D, Ground Floor, Front Half Portion Measuring 220 sq. yards, Green Park Extension, New Delhi- 110016	Not known	Not known	Not known

Matter be listed on 16.04.2026 for filing affidavit of service of E-auction sale notice with proofs of service (including track results qua speed post and courier) and dasti, original proofs of publication in newspapers and wider publicity including website for the purpose of e-auction.

(Vaatsalya Kumar)
Recovery Officer-II
DRT-II, Delhi

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Geneva

A boat packed with migrants capsized off the coast of Djibouti on the way to Yemen this week, with at least nine people killed and another 45 missing, the UN migration agency said on Friday.

The tragedy was the latest in a series of shipwrecks between the Horn of Africa and the Arabian Peninsula that have over past few years killed several thousand African migrants fleeing conflict and poverty in hopes of reaching Gulf Arab countries.

The boat had left from the Djibouti port town of Obok with more than 300 people

onboard and was trying to cross the Bab el-Mandeb Strait when it went down on Tuesday, the International Organisation for Migration (IOM) said.

The Bab el-Mandeb Strait and the Strait of Hormuz are on opposite sides of the Arabian Peninsula. Search continues for possible survivors, said Tanja Pacifico, IOM’s chief of mission in Djibouti.

“The sea is very rough, and there were also strong winds,” Pacifico told a regular UN press briefing in Geneva. “This route is known to be a very deadly one.”

She said testimonies from the survivors described “an extremely heavy load for the boat”.

The shipwreck was the first this year in the area, Pacifico said. Last year, more than 900 migrants died or went missing on the route, the highest toll on record on the strait, the

IOM said. The passage typically lures tens of thousands of migrants from Africa “in search of safety and economic opportunities”, the agency said.

A search continues for

possible survivors, said Tanja Pacifico, IOM’s chief of mission in Djibouti.

“The sea is very rough, and there were also strong winds,” Pacifico told a regular UN press briefing in Geneva by video. “This route is known to be a very deadly one.”

In response to growing needs and funding short-falls, IOM calls for increased international support to strengthen search and rescue operations and expand safe migration pathways. IOM further urges donors and partners to scale up their financial support to Djibouti to sustain life-saving assistance and prevent further loss of life.

Iran war means more children to suffer in Somalia: UNICEF

The sound of a crying child is a sign of hope in a crowded displacement camp in southern Somalia — the most malnourished children are too weak to even cry.

For the mothers in the Ladan camp in the town of Dollow, survival is the only thing on their minds — not the Iran war or how UNICEF gets the supplies to keep the place

running. The displaced here have fled the drought that has ravaged swaths of this Horn of Africa nation after four failed rainy seasons. Their crops and livestock devastated, they show up at the camp, often with nothing but their children.

Aid workers at Ladan say the raging war in the Middle East - more than 3,000 kilometres (1,800 miles) away - has made their work harder, disrupting supplies.

Raising the alarm

UNICEF says it has \$15.7 million worth of lifesaving supplies — including therapeutic food, vaccines, and mosquito nets - in transit or being prepared for delivery to Somalia. (PTI)

Trump’s signature on dollar bills to mark 250th year of United States independence

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump’s signature is set to feature on US paper currency soon, a first for a sitting president since the introduction of dollar bills in 1861.

The decision, taken by the US Treasury, coincides with the 250th anniversary celebrations of American Independence this year.

“In celebration of America’s 250th anniversary, President Donald J Trump’s signature alongside (Treasury) Secretary Scott Bessent’s will soon appear on US currency, marking a

first in history, and symbolises @POTUS’ leadership and dedication to our great nation will carry a lasting impact,” US Treasurer Brandon Beach said in a post on X.

Earlier this month, a federal arts commission

approved the final design for a 24-karat gold commemorative coin bearing Trump’s image to help celebrate the 250th anniversary of American Independence.

The 24-karat gold coin, portraying Trump leaning on the Resolute desk with

clenched fists, will be only the second time a living president has featured on a coin.

“Under President Trump’s leadership, we are on a path toward unprecedented economic growth, lasting dollar dominance, and fiscal strength and stability,” Bessent said in a statement.

“There is no more powerful way to recognise the historic achievements of our great country and President Donald J Trump than US dollar bills bearing his name, and it is only appropriate that this historic currency be issued at the semiquincentennial,” he said. (AP)

Ukraine, Saudi Arabia agreed to key defence ties, says Zelenskyy

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy during his visit to Saudi Arabia on Friday said the two countries have agreed to “an important arrangement” on defence cooperation.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky (L) and Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman meeting in Jeddah

Zelenskyy, in a social media post Friday, said the document “lays the foundation for future contracts, technological cooperation, and investment”, providing no further details.

Drone combat experts from Ukraine, with over four years of experience in fending off Iran-manufac-

tured drones used during the Russian offensive, are helping five Gulf countries to counter Tehran’s attacks, according to Zelenskyy.

The Ukraine president said he would meet later in the day with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman.

Senate approves funding for TSA and most of Homeland Security

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

The Senate early on Friday morning approved Homeland Security funds to pay Transportation Security Administration agents and most other agencies, but not the immigration enforcement operations at the heart of the budget impasse that has jammed airports, disrupted travel and imposed financial hardship on workers.

The deal, which the Senate approved unanimously without a roll call, next goes to the House, which is expected to consider it on Friday.

“We can get at least a lot of the Government opened up again and then we’ll go from there,” said Senate Majority Leader John Thune, R-SD “Obviously, we’ll still have some work ahead of us.”

With pressure mounting to resolve the 42-day stalemate over funding for the Department of Homeland Security, the endgame emerged in the final

hours before Transportation Security Administration (TSA) workers miss another paycheck Friday.

President Donald Trump said he would sign an order to immediately pay the TSA agents, saying he wanted to quickly stop the “Chaos at the Airports.” The deal did not include any of the restraints Democrats have demanded as they sought to rein in Trump’s mass deportation agenda.

Senate Democratic Leader Chuck Schumer said the outcome could have

been reached weeks ago, and vowed that his party would continue fighting to ensure Trump’s “rogue” immigration operation “does not get more funding without serious reform.”

What’s in and out of the funding package

Senators worked through the night on the deal that would fund much of the rest of the department, including the Federal Emergency Management Agency, the Coast Guard and TSA, but without funding for Immigration and Customs Enforcement. Customs was funded, but Border Protection was not.

The package puts no new limits on immigration enforcement, which has remained largely uninterrupted by the shutdown.

The GOP’s big tax cuts bill that Trump signed into law last year funnelled billions in extra funds to DHS, including \$75 billion for ICE operations, ensuring the immigration officers are still being paid despite the lapse.

Ex-Sri Lanka minister fined LKR 75 million for purchasing substandard medicines

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

The Supreme Court on Friday fined a former health minister Sri Lanka rupees 75 million for violating fundamental rights by importing medicines under an Indian credit line in 2022 through a company not registered for the purpose.

A three member bench of the island nation’s top court gave the ruling in response to a fundamental rights petitions filed by Transparency International and two other parties in what is being seen as Sri Lanka’s biggest public health scam case.

While Keheliya Rambukwella, the former health minister, was asked to pay Sri Lanka rupees (LKR) 75 million, the court also asked a group of senior health officials to pay LKR 50 million each to the state for importing medicines through the company which was not registered for health supplies under the Indian credit line to help the island nation tide over the forex and economic crisis in 2022.

China greets Nepal's new PM Balen, signals policy reset

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, HISAR	SPECIAL REPAIR OF ELECTRICAL SERVICES IN OLD CIVIL HOSPITAL DISTT FATEHABAD, (PDG STREET LIGHT WORK ONLY), + 1 WORKS	25.03.2026 03.04.2026	35.11 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eesd-hisar@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, YAMUNA NAGAR	SPECIAL REPAIR OF DEPUTY DIRECTOR AND SDO AGRICULTURE OFFICE INCLUDING RESIDENTIAL ACCOMMODATION AT JASAOHRI IN DISTRICT YAMUNA NAGAR + 1 WORKS	26.03.2026 02.04.2026	19.99 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01732237834 pwd-eesd- yamunanagar@hry.nic.in
3	PWD B&R, KARNAL	STRENGTHENING WITH 50MM DBM PLUS 40MM BC AND 80MM INTERLOCKING PAVER BLOCK ON KARNAL KATTHAL ROAD (ROAD ID 7264) (SH-08) IN KM 17.100 TO 42.000 IN NILKHERI CONSTITUENCY, IN KARNAL DISTRICT (WORK PROGRAMME 2025-26)	25.03.2026 15.04.2026	3109.01 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9876009311 pwd-eesd-karnal@hry.nic.in
4	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	KACHHWA COMP. OF PENDING WORK OF COMMUNITY HALL AT RAIFARM, VILL.: KACHHWA, BLOCK: KARNAL, SCHEME VANGY	26.03.2026 04.04.2026	2.47 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896202019 prexeeng.kr@hry.nic.in
5	PANCHAYATI RAJ, KARNAL	DETAILED ESTIMATE OF CONST. OF COMMUNITY CENTRE AT VILLAGE- JAISINGHPURA BLOCK-ASSANDH DIST. KARNAL SCHEME-HGVY	26.03.2026 04.04.2026	67.14 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896202019 prexeeng.kr@hry.nic.in
6	CIVIL SURGEON, KATTHAL	PURCHASE OF ORTHO IMPLANTS FOR DISTRICT KATTHAL	28.03.2026 14.04.2026	EMD 50000	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	7988672699 drugstore4d@gmail.com
7	PANCHAYATI RAJ, RAJOUND	COMPLETION OF VISHVAKARMA COMMUNITY CENTRE (JAKHOULI KAMAN)	26.03.2026 31.03.2026	7.68 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8630071961 sdoprajound@gmail.com
8	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, MANDI DABWALI	DADU:- ACCEMUT FOR CONSTRUCTION OF 1 NO. S/S TANK, BOUNDARY WALL, REPAIR OF CIVIL STRUCTURES, SOLAR PANEL, CONSTRUCTION OF BOOSTING STATION, UGR, PC, B/WALL, PUMPING MACHINERY, DISTRIBUTION SYSTEM AND RESTORATION OF HOUSE CONNECTIONS AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENTS THERETO. AEO CH. HEAD :- DADU:- ESTIMATE FOR AUGMENTATION AND RENOVATION OF WATER SUPPLY SCHEME AND CONSTRUCTION OF ADDITIONAL BOOSTING STATION, STRENGTHENING OF DISTRIBUTION SYSTEM AT VILLAGE DADU DISTT. SIRSA. + 1 WORKS	25.03.2026 15.04.2026	334.42 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8730000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com
9	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, SIRSA	KUMTHAL:- LAYING OF 150 MM I/D D.I RISING MAIN, CONSTRUCTION OF BOUNDARY WALL / IRON GATE AND CONSTRUCTION OF 1 NO. TUBEWELL CHAMBER OF SIZE 10' X12' AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO	25.03.2026 02.04.2026	12.48 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467070175 eepsirsa@gmail.com
10	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, SIRSA	SIRSA TOWN :- DESILTING OF SEWER LINE OF SIZE 250MM I/D BY BUCKET TYPE SEWER CLEANING MACHINE, DESILTING AND CLEANING OF S.W. PIPE LINE 200MM I/D. BY ROPE SACK IN VARIOUS STREETS OF SIRSA TOWN AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO.	25.03.2026 02.04.2026	30.33 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467070175 eepsirsa@gmail.com
11	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, SIRSA	SIRSA TOWN:-DESILTING OF 400MM,500MM AND 600MM I/D RCC SEWER LINE BY SUPER SUCKER MACHINE IN PREET NAGAR, PREM NAGAR CHATTARGARH PATTI, CIVIL HOSPITAL ROAD C-BLOCK, MAIN GALI KURTI NAGAR AND OLD HOUSING BOARD AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO IN SIRSA TOWN DISTT. SIRSA.	25.03.2026 02.04.2026	47.64 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467070175 eepsirsa@gmail.com
12	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, SIRSA	ELLENABAD TOWN:-SUPPLY FIXING AND INSTALLATION OF DI SPECIAL, SLUICE VALVE, NRV, ARMOURD CABLE , CABLE TRAY AT RAW WATER PUMPING STATION IN BUDHIMERI FOR CANAL BASED WATER WORKS ELLENABAD AND ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENTS THERE TO. CH.HEAD:- AUG. WATER SUPPLY SCHEME ELLENABAD TOWN. CONSTRUCTION OF S/S TANKS, REPAIR OF EXISTING WATER WORKS STRUCTURES AND LAYING OF NEW WATER CARRIER (800MM I/D D.I. RISING MAIN) FROM SOUTHERN GHAGGAR CANAL TO EXISTING WATER WORKS.	25.03.2026 02.04.2026	23.37 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9467070175 eepsirsa@gmail.com
13	FOREST DEPARTMENT, HISAR	CONTRACT FOR GATE ENTRY FEES AT BHIWANI ZOO	19.03.2026 30.03.2026	25 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662259233 dwlohisar@gmail.com
14	FOREST DEPARTMENT, HISAR	SUPPLY OF CHICKEN MEAT FOR MINT ZOO BHIWANI AND 8 OTHER ITEMS INCLUDING DEER PARK HISAR	25.03.2026 30.03.2026	112.92 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662259233 dwlohisar@gmail.com
15	FOREST DEPARTMENT, HISAR	TENDER NOTICE FOR CONSTRUCTION OF DFO OFFICE BUILDING IN HISAR FOREST DIVISION, HISAR	25.03.2026 10.04.2026	80.46 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416029555 dfohisar.td@gmail.com
16	ZILA PARISHAD, FATEHABAD	ANNUAL REPAIR OF VARIOUS ROADS FALLING IN THE NOTIFIED AREAS OF ZILA PARISHAD FATEHABAD (YEAR 2026-2027) GROUP -A AND GROUP -B) + 8 WORKS	25.03.2026 01.04.2026	279.55 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416071464 zpfth@hry.nic.in
17	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, GOHANA	ESTIMATE FOR RECONSTRUCTION OF STRUCTURES OF BHALAUT SUB BRANCH FROM RD 45000 TO 83000.	11.03.2026 31.03.2026	1497.84 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9996532900 xenghn@rediffmail.com
18	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, PANCHKULA	SUPPLY ERECTION AND COMMISSIONING OF 04 NO. 10 CV. TS PUMPS ALONGWITH 50 HP MOTOR AND STARTER PANEL ETC FOR WS MECH. DIVISION FARIDABAD	27.03.2026 10.04.2026	93.60 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0172-2582542 xenproc@gmail.com
19	BPS GOVT. MEDICAL COLLEGE FOR WOMEN KHANPUR KALAN SONPAT	TENDER FOR MAKING DIESEL STORAGE LICENCE FOR BPSGMC FOR WOMEN KHANPUR KALAN SONPAT	27.03.2026 02.04.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9996752925 purchasebranch2026@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 44265-1-27-2

PROSPECT

Goa secures ICPB to boost MICE Tourism

The Department of Tourism, Goa has secured a Lifetime Membership with the India Convention Promotion Bureau (ICPB), marking a major boost for the State's Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions (MICE) sector. The official certificate was presented to the Department of Tourism, Goa by Arun Srivastava, Joint Director General, Ministry of Tourism, Government of India; Neeraj Dhawan, Treasurer, ICPB; and Dr Poonam Rajput, Executive Director, ICPB during a formal ceremony held at Assembleia, Taj Cidade de Goa Horizon. Minister for Tourism, Rohan A Khaunte, stated, "This lifetime membership with ICPB reinforces our commitment to positioning Goa as a leading destination for business and corporate events. We are focused on creating a robust ecosystem that blends world-class infrastructure with Goa's unique experiential appeal, enabling us to attract high-value global events while driving sustainable tourism growth for the State. "This strategic partnership aims to elevate Goa beyond its beaches and establish it as a premier year-round MICE destination.

Indian engineers secure Japan roles at ₹42 lakh average pay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Even as global geopolitical uncertainties continue to impact hiring sentiment across markets, Indian engineering talent remains in demand, with AI-led platform Cognavi placing 13 students in Japan at an average package of ₹42.15 lakh per annum. Out of 127 applicants, 13 candidates secured offers ranging between ₹42.15 lakh and ₹56.27 lakh, underlining strong international appetite for specialised engineering skills from India despite ongoing global disruptions.

The highest offer in the cohort touched ₹56.27 lakh (9.6 million yen), while the average stood at 7.1 million yen. The students were recruited from institutions including IIT Madras, IIT Mandi and the SRM Institute of Science and Technology.

The roles span core engineering and technology domains such as data engineering, system engineering and product development, with all candidates placed in Japan's manufacturing and tech sector.

A total of 127 students applied for the programme. Using an AI-

based skill mapping and assessment process, 20 candidates were short-listed, of which 13 were selected.

"The global engineering talent shortage is a matching problem, not a supply problem. India produces the supply — world-class engineers — but the connection to global demand is broken. We fixed that with AI. One student just got ₹56 lakh. That's not the peak. That's the proof of concept," said Varun Modgill, Managing Director & CTO, Cognavi India Pvt Ltd.

The company said its proprietary AI matching model evaluates candidates based on technical capabilities rather than academic scores, aligning them directly with global job requirements.

Industry experts say such AI-driven hiring models are gaining traction among multinational firms looking to tap India's engineering talent pool for specialised roles, particularly in non-IT sectors, even as global uncertainties persist.

Cognavi currently partners with over 300 engineering colleges in India and is expanding its focus on cross-border recruitment in core engineering disciplines.

Jadhav addresses Illness to Wellness summit

GYANVI SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare Prataprao Jadhav on Friday said the Government of India under leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi is committed to strengthening the integrated healthcare ecosystem.

"Today, healthcare is not limited to hospitals; it must begin at home for individuals to focus on their overall well-being," Jadhav said while addressing virtually the 4th Annual Illness to Wellness Summit in the national Capital.

The MoS (Independent Charge) for Aayush Ministry appreciated the efforts of the Illness to Wellness Foundation, FICCI, and The Pioneer for organising the summit.

Delivering the keynote address, former Health Secretary Rajesh Bhushan stressed that healthcare must go beyond treatment and include prevention, promotion and rehabilitation. He



highlighted the importance of community-level health awareness, especially in a country as diverse as India while pointing to the role of digital initiatives like the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) and ABHA in improving access, efficiency and continuity of care.

The summit, themed "Advancing Holistic Health through Innovation, Technology, and Tradition," focused on the need to shift from a reactive healthcare system to a more preventive

and personalised approach. Anil Rajput, Chairperson of the Advisory Council; Illness to Wellness Foundation, said that true progress lies in helping people adopt healthier lifestyles in their daily routines at home and at work.

Highlighting the role of traditional knowledge, Dr Manoj Nesari explained the concepts of aarogya and swasth, noting that health is a balanced state of physical, mental, and environmental well-being. He stressed the



(L-R) (Padma Bhushan) Dr T S Kler, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation and Chairman & HOD - BLK-Max Heart & Vascular Institute & Chairman Pan Max - Electrophysiology; Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Rajesh Bhushan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India & Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Dr Manoj Nesari, Senior Chief Medical Officer (SAG), CGHS, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Former Advisor, Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India and Dr Ravi Gaur, Co-Chair, FICCI Digital Health Task Force & Healthcare Awards and Founder - DRG Path Lab at the inaugural session of 4th Annual Summit on Illness to Wellness held in New Delhi

importance of nutrition, seasonal diets, surroundings and sustainable living practices.

Cardiologist Dr T S Kler raised concerns about the growing impact of lifestyle diseases and called for an integrated healthcare model that combines modern med-

icine with traditional systems like Ayurveda, along with greater public awareness.

In an engaging moment during the event, Dr. Ishwar V. Basavaraddi; Ministry of Ayush, Govt of India led participants through a brief session of breathing exercis-

WTC, AIAI welcome reduction of excise duty on petroleum products

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Mumbai

Welcoming the Government of India's decision to reduce excise duty by ₹10 per litre on both petrol and diesel with immediate effect, Dr Vijay Kalantri, Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai and President, All India Association of Industries



Dr Vijay Kalantri, Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai and President, All India Association of Industries

when global fuel prices have increased significantly by 30-50% across South and South-East Asia, around 30% in North America, and nearly 20% in Europe, India has maintained price stability. This decision underscores the Government's commitment to prioritising economic stability and consumer welfare," said Dr Kalantri.

"The excise reduction will offset pressures on Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), enabling them to continue supplying fuel without disruption while keeping retail prices stable. Fuel is a critical input across sectors, and stabilising its cost will have a cascading positive impact on transportation, logistics, and inflation. This will provide

relief to industry, MSMEs, and the common man alike," added Dr Kalantri.

Dr Kalantri, emphasised, "the Government's continued focus on ensuring uninterrupted availability of petroleum products, including LPG for both household and commercial usage.

Such proactive and balanced policy measures will help sustain economic momentum, contain inflationary pressures, and strengthen overall resilience in a period of global uncertainty," WTC Mumbai and AIAI believe that this decisive step will reinforce confidence across sectors and support India's growth trajectory by balancing fiscal responsibility with economic stability.

VIT scores big in QS World University Rankings by Subject 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

VIT has achieved a significant milestone in the recently published QS World University Rankings by Subject 2026, with record number of subjects breaking into the top 200 ranking in the World. With 17 subjects ranked globally, VIT is rapidly closing the gap with global education leaders through major improvements in Engineering, Technology, Sciences, Management, Agriculture & Design.

Engineering & Technology remains the forte of VIT and is ranked 119 on the World, moving up 23 places from last year where it was ranked 142. In Engineering & Technology, VIT has moved to the 6th rank in India. In Mathematics, it has secured the 5th rank. In the subjects of Computer Science & Information Systems, Electrical & Electronics, and Data Science & Artificial Intelligence, Mechanical, Aeronautical & Manufacturing VIT has achieved the 6th, 7th and 8th ranks respectively in India.

For the first time, two subjects - Computer Science Engineering (86) and Electrical & Electronics Engineering (87) have broken in to the top 100 rankings in the World.

Other programmes that feature in the top 200 Data Science & Artificial Intelligence (101-200), Mechanical Engineering (148), Mathematics (104) and Material Science (137), Art & Design (201-300) & Civil Engineering (201-275) are the new entrants this year. Other branches that are ranked include Chemical Engineering (201-250), Chemistry (251-300), Physics (251-300), Statistics & Operational Research (251-275),



Biological Sciences (351-350), Agriculture (401-475) and Business & Management (451-500). Dr G Viswanathan, Chancellor - VIT said "The improvement in rankings reflects our unwavering pursuit of excellence across teaching, research, and global engagement. It is a proud moment for our entire community-our faculty, staff, students and alumni -whose collective efforts have made this progress possible.

The improved ranking highlight VIT's continued investment in cutting-edge research, industry collaborations, and a future-focused curriculum designed to prepare students for a rapidly evolving

Assam rifles busts interstate tout network, four held in Silchar



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Acting on specific intelligence inputs, Assam Rifles in coordination with Cachar Police dismantled an active network operating in Silchar, Assam on 25 March 26. The module was involved in organised illegal ingress of foreign nationals from Bangladesh and Myanmar through Tripura and Mizoram, as well as egress of illegal foreign nationals from India, including individuals involved in criminal cases, deportation proceedings and visa violations.

During the operation, four individuals were

apprehended, including a Nigerian national identified as Emeka (44 years), along with three Indian nationals, K Malsawmdawngi (Aizawl), Tinku Hussain Barbhuiya (Silchar), and Ramina Begum Barbhuiya (Silchar).

Investigation revealed the network's role in systematically facilitating illegal cross-border movement, posing a serious threat to national security and immigration control mechanisms.

Assam Rifles remains committed to ensuring security of the region and create deterrence for the inimical elements.

es and light stretching for about five minutes. The activity accentuated how simple mindfulness practices can help reduce stress and improve focus in everyday life.

The discussions also touched on mental health, particularly among students and working professionals and the need for supportive environments in schools and workplaces. Experts emphasised early intervention, open conversations, and the inclusion of wellness practices such as yoga and meditation.

The event closed with a strong emphasis on collaboration and awareness, with speakers agreeing that lasting change in healthcare will depend on everyday choices, community participation, and a balanced integration of modern medicine with traditional practices. The panel discussions reinforced that building a healthier India requires not just better systems, but a shift in mindset towards prevention and overall well-being.

ICICI Prudential Life Smallcap 250 Index Fund to tap India's growth stocks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

ICICI Prudential Life Insurance has launched the ICICI Prudential Life Smallcap 250 Index Fund under its Unit Linked Insurance Plans (ULIPs). The fund enables customers to participate in a broad basket of emerging listed companies and build wealth over the long term through a disciplined, index-based approach.

The fund tracks the Nifty Smallcap 250 Index, which comprises 250 companies ranked 251st to 500th in the Nifty 500 universe. However, regulations may prevent the company from investing in all index constituents in line with their weights from time to time, potentially resulting in tracking error.

This fund provides exposure to an array of smaller listed businesses at the early stages of their growth journey, with strong potential to scale over time. Commenting on the launch, Manish Kumar, Chief Investment Officer at ICICI Prudential Life Insurance Company Limited, said: "The Smallcap 250 Index Fund offers customers a simple, transparent way to tap into the growth potential of emerging companies and build long-term wealth. It suits investors seeking structured exposure to such firms across diverse market sectors.

"The rule-based approach ensures diversification across a wide set of businesses while staying disciplined and benchmark-aligned. Notably, the fund spans 250 emerging companies in sectors including financial services, healthcare, and capital goods, among others—allowing investors to gain exposure to multiple economic growth stories through a single product."

Snakebite victim rescued by Indian Army in Imphal East



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Imphal

In a swift and life-saving response, troops of the Indian Army extended immediate medical assistance to a seven-year-old child who suffered a snakebite.

At approximately 5 pm, a distressed local family reached the Company Operating Base (COB) at Hanuman Top, in Imphal East District seeking urgent help. Acting promptly, troops initiated first aid under the guidance of the Regimental Medical

Officer (RMO). The wound was carefully treated, and the affected limb was immobilised to prevent the spread of venom.

Following initial stabilisation, the child was swiftly evacuated to Regional Institute of Medical Sciences (RIMS) for advanced medical care.

The timely intervention by the Indian Army played a crucial role in ensuring the safety and well-being of the young patient, reflecting its unwavering commitment to serving the local community.

कुमाऊँ मण्डल विकास निगम लिमिटेड

(उत्तराखण्ड सरकार का प्रतिष्ठान)

ओक पार्क हाउस, मल्लीताल, नैनीताल-263001

सत्राक : 4402/10-निर्माण/2025-26

दिनांक : 27.03.2026

पुनः आमंत्रित ई-निविदा सूचना

"Development of Rural Tourism Cluster Experience at Gunji, Pithoragarh" तथा "Tea Garden Experience" project at Champawat Under Swadesh Darshan 2.0 scheme के निर्माण कार्य हेतु उत्तराखण्ड ई-निविदा पोर्टल <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> के माध्यम से पुनः ई निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण दिनांक 28.03.2026 से ई-निविदा पोर्टल एवं निगम वेबसाइट www.kmvn.in में सार्य 5.00 बजे के पश्चात देखी जा सकती है। उक्त निविदा में किसी भी प्रकार का संशोधन होने की दशा में संशोधन का प्रकाशन केवल ई-निविदा पोर्टल एवं निगम वेबसाइट के माध्यम से ही जायेगा।

प्रबन्ध निदेशक

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Galgotias University has steadily evolved over the years as a growing contributor to technology-focused education in India, and its recent recognition in the Quacquarelli Symonds (QS) World University Rankings 2026 by subject (Computer

Science and Information Systems) reflects this ongoing journey. The ranking is not just a milestone, but a result of decades of consistent effort toward building a strong academic and research ecosystem.

In the 2026 rankings, Galgotias University has been placed in the 601-650 band globally for Computer

Science and Information Systems. Within India, it is ranked 11th among private universities and 30th among Government and Private universities in India in this subject area.

These outcomes indicate gradual progress and a strengthening presence in the national and global academic landscape.

This recognition has been shaped by a sustained focus on academic quality, industry-aligned curriculum design, and a Student Centered Active Learning Ecosystem. Over the years, the university has worked to expand its capabilities in emerging areas such as artificial intelligence, data science, cybersecurity, and software engineering, aligning its programs with evol-

ving industry and societal needs.

The achievement also reflects the collective efforts of faculty, students, and institutional partners and industry collaborations in nurturing an environment that values innovation, collaboration, and continuous improvement. With the global demand for technology talent continuing to grow, Galgotias University aims to further build on this foundation and contribute meaningfully to the development of a future-ready workforce and India's knowledge economy.

This ranking by subject makes the Galgotias University's Computer Science and Information Systems the no 2nd ranked amongst private universities in Uttar Pradesh which is not

only an achievement for Galgotias University but also a matter of pride for the state of Uttar Pradesh, which is becoming a Global knowledge Destination. Uttar Pradesh is not only attracting world class universities but is also set to open one of Asia's largest airports in Jewar (close to Galgotias University) set to be inaugurated soon. The Noida International Airport will be a big factor in boosting the industry ecosystem, and will create several jobs in the area.

Mr Suneel Galgotia said, "Being recognized in the QS World University Rankings by Subject 2026 for Computer Science and Information Systems is a meaningful moment for Galgotias University. More than the

recognition, it reflects the journey and the efforts that have shaped it over the years. This is not the outcome of a single milestone, but the result of a sustained commitment to building a strong quality academic ecosystem" Dr Dhruv Galgotia said, "This recognition is a reflection of the collective commitment of our students, faculty, and researchers. It has been built over years through consistent effort, quiet perseverance, and a shared belief in doing meaningful work. While we take pride in this moment, we remain grounded in the understanding that this is only a step in a much larger journey. There is still much to accomplish, and Galgotias University will continue striving to improve, and contribute with purpose."

BRIEFLY

Mexico prepares for Portugal in World Cup warmup



Mexico's Javier Aguirre prefers not to dwell on absences and instead focus on players he has available for two warmup matches ahead of the World Cup. Mexico is missing 12 regular call-ups including captain Edson Alvarez and five other starters as the team prepares to face Portugal on Saturday and Belgium three days later. The match against Portugal marks the reopening of the iconic Azteca Stadium, which has been closed since May 2024 for renovations to host the third World Cup in its history. The game against Belgium will be played at Soldier Field in Chicago. The absences include six players from the team that won the regional Nations League and the Gold Cup last year. "Half of the team that won two titles, with whom you forged a family bond and a commitment, and who lifted a trophy today, are not with you," Aguirre said at a press conference Thursday. "It's by no means an excuse because other Mexicans are emerging in the same positions and they will try."

Reyna happy lack of club playing time not held against him



Gio Reyna is happy his lack of Bundesliga playing time isn't being held against him by Mauricio Pochettino as the US coach prepares for the last two friendlies before picking his World Cup roster. Reyna is among the 27 players in camp for matches against Belgium on Saturday and Portugal on Tuesday. The 23-year-old midfielder, a son of former US captain Claudio Reyna, has had just 28 minutes on the field in the past three months for Borussia Monchengladbach. "It's always easier when you're playing week in and week out. My case is not like that," Reyna said during an online news conference Thursday. "Fortunate and of course always honored and happy to be back in with the coach's trust. If the opportunity comes up, I still feel very prepared to make an impact this camp on the field." After Pochettino took over the U.S. in late 2024, he stressed the importance of gaining regular club playing time. "We need them to be involved in the competition in their clubs," he said that November. Reyna transferred to Gladbach last summer after making just 14 league starts in his last four seasons at Borussia Dortmund plus two during a loan to English side Nottingham Forest. He had made just one start and five substitute appearances in the Bundesliga this season when Reyna reported for a pair of November U.S. friendlies. Reyna scored in his first international start in 16 months to surpass his father in career international goals with nine and then set up Folarin Balogun's tiebreaking goal for a 2-1 victory over Paraguay.

Iran bans its teams from travelling to hostile countries

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tehran

Iran has banned its sports teams from travelling to countries it considers "hostile," Iranian state TV reported ahead of Tractor FC's scheduled soccer game in Saudi Arabia. The ban announced by Iran's Ministry of Sports in Tehran didn't mention the World Cup which starts June 11 in the United States, Canada and Mexico. The ministry's statement singled out the Tractor game against Shabab Al Ahli of Dubai that was set to be played in Saudi Arabia. It's a playoff game in the Asian Champions League Elite. "The presence of national and club teams in countries

that are considered hostile and are unable to ensure the security of Iranian athletes and team members is prohibited until further notice," it said. The Iran war has impacted the region, with nearly every country in the Middle East sustaining damage from missile hits, drone strikes or shrapnel. Tractor's playoff game in Saudi Arabia was the result of the Asian Football Confederation's draw on Wednesday to determine the quarterfinal pairings, a day after announcing that the western zone playoffs that were postponed because of the war in the Middle East have been rescheduled for April 13-14 in Jeddah. The Saudi city is also slated to host the tournament quar-



terfinals, semifinals and final from April 16-25, with organizers setting the dates and hoping for peace in the region. The Iranian ministry

added that the soccer federation and clubs "will be responsible for notifying the Asian Football Confederation of this matter in order to relocate the games."

Iran's stance on the World Cup: The Iranian ambassador in Mexico City has said the country was negotiating with

FIFA to move Iran's three group-stage matches from the United States to Mexico after US President Donald Trump discouraged the team from attending the 48-nation tournament, citing safety concerns. Last week, however, FIFA President Gianni Infantino further dampened Iran's attempts to move its World Cup matches, saying global soccer's governing body wants the tournament "to go ahead as scheduled." Iranian government and soccer officials have said they do not want to boycott the World Cup but that it is not possible for the national team to come to the U.S. because of military attacks on the country by Israel and the US since February 28.

Szmodics stretchered off after heavy collision in World Cup playoff game

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Prague

Ireland midfielder Sammie Szmodics was stretchered off after being left unconscious following a heavy collision with an opponent in a World Cup qualification playoff game against the Czech Republic. Szmodics collided with Czech player Stepan Chaloupek as they both moved toward a high ball. Szmodics collapsed to the ground immediately and seemed to display involuntary arm movement. Medical staff treated Szmodics on the ground for



several minutes before he was moved onto a stretcher with support for his head and neck. Fans sang and applauded as Szmodics was carried off.

"He was knocked out cold," Ireland coach Heimir Hallgrimsson said. "At least he's conscious now. He will stay here tonight."

Mbappe shakes off knee injury, sparks France's 2-1 WC tuneup win

JIMMY GOLENAP
■ Foxborough (USA)

The traffic on the way to France's World Cup tuneup against Brazil was a problem. Kylian Mbappe's knee was not. The former Paris Saint-Germain and current Real Madrid star showed no ill effects from his knee injury on Thursday when he broke free for a goal to give France an early lead on its way to a 2-1 victory in a friendly between two of the world's top teams. Mbappe missed almost a month with a left knee sprain for Real Madrid before coming on as a substitute in the last two matches. France coach Didier Deschamps started Mbappe but had him on a limit of about an hour; he came off for a substitute in the

65th minute. "He has a lot of desire, a lot of soreness in his legs," Deschamps said. "Beyond that — the quality to make a difference he's always had." With a crowd of 66,215 heavily favouring Brazil, Mbappe and Hugo Ekitike gave France a 2-0 lead on the same pitch where they will play their final group stage game of this summer's World Cup, against Norway and Erling Haaland. Bremer cut the deficit to 2-1 in the 78th minute. The friendly went off without any major hiccups despite the simmering feud between the town of Foxborough and World Cup organisers over almost \$8 million in security costs. The sides reached an agreement two weeks ago in which the organising committee



promised to make the payment in advance and the town approved the necessary entertainment licence. That was expected to be the last remaining obstacle to the world's biggest sporting event arriving in this 20,000-person suburb tucked between Boston and

Providence, Rhode Island, that swells to three times its size for New England Patriots games. To accommodate FIFA requirements, a grass field has replaced the artificial turf that had been used for the NFL's Patriots and the New England Revolution of Major League Soccer. "Good

stadium. Good pitch. It was all OK to play good football," Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti said. "The atmosphere in the stadium was good — a lot of Brazilian supporters. Everything was fine, apart from the result." Deschamps said the biggest problem was the travel from Boston, about 25 miles away but part of it on a four-lane road with stoplights and tens of thousands of fans trying to get to the game. "I am convinced that everything will be fine," Deschamps said. "The most difficult thing are the trips that take a lot of time. ... One hour and 15 minutes before a game is not easy." The crowd was the second-largest to watch a soccer match at Gillette Stadium, behind only a 2007 friendly

between Brazil and Mexico. It was speckled with fans in Brazilian yellow kits, with just a few French flags waving to celebrate Mbappe's goal. (The media dining room was more neutral, with madeleines, macarons and eclairs alongside Brazilian brigadeiro, pudim and mousse deo maracuja.) Also in the house were coach Joe Mazzulla and players from the NBA's Boston Celtics, with forward Jayson Tatum taking part in the pregame coin toss alongside Massachusetts Gov. Maura Healey. The 2018 World Cup champion and 2022 Golden Boot winner, Mbappe sprained his left knee in December but played through January before sitting out almost a month. (AP)

Ukrainian skeleton racer Vladyslav Heraskevych speaks at UN

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ United Nations

Heraskevych was shunned by the Olympics, then invited to the United Nations. He never expected that would happen. The Ukrainian skeleton athlete was not allowed to compete at the Milan Cortina Games because of his plan to wear a helmet paying tribute to some of those killed following Russia's invasion of his country. He spoke on a panel at the UN on Thursday detailing why he still believes he made the right decision. "I think it's important that we use this stage and talk about important things," Heraskevych said at the opening ceremony of Change the World Model United Nations, an educational sim-

ulation for thousands of students. "Sometimes it feels like, in all these hours of training, we really forgot about the overall mission of sports. It is not only about the medals, but it's also about values that we represent." Heraskevych was invited to share his story as part of a panel that also included Shiva Amini, a former women's soccer player for Iran who now lives in exile in New York. Amini was granted asylum in Switzerland in 2017 after the Iranian government threatened sanctions after she was photographed playing soccer with men while not wearing the mandatory hijab, or headscarf. "We can save lives with sport," Heraskevych said from the stage. "Sport gave people some hope." The



International Bobsled and Skeleton Federation said his insistence on wearing the helmet was "inconsistent with the Olympic Charter and Guidelines on Athlete Expression" and therefore he wouldn't be allowed to compete at the Games. Heraskevych wore the

helmet in training, but the International Olympic Committee asked him to wear a different helmet in races. It offered concessions, such as wearing a black armband in remembrance of those killed in the war or letting him display the helmet once he was off the ice. The

names of the Ukrainian athletes that were part of Heraskevych's "memory helmet" were read aloud during the session Thursday, drawing an ovation. Heraskevych's season ended when he wasn't allowed to compete in the Olympics, but his sliding career is not over. He intends to compete in at least some World Cup races this coming season, including one at the Cortina d'Ampezzo track that he was kept from racing on last month. He also has plans to stick around for the 2030 Olympics. The invite to the U.N. came as a surprise. "It wasn't part of my bucket list," Heraskevych said, smiling. Heraskevych has been in constant motion since the Olympics. He and his father are leading a foundation for

people and groups in Ukraine; one of their top priorities is providing generators, given that much of the country is dealing with blackouts and an at-best shaky power grid. He is trying to find more ways to honor the two dozen athletes and coaches who were immortalized on the helmet that he wasn't allowed to wear in Olympic races, and he's even trying to use his "real job" training as a physicist to find ways for his country to deal with the countless issues created by the war. He also wants to try to expose more people to Ukrainian culture. He wore a vyshyvanka, a traditional embroidered shirt, on stage Thursday, and has plans to show off some of his country's best cuisine around the world as well.

Italy beats Northern Ireland 2-0 in World Cup playoff semifinal



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Italy finally won a match in the World Cup playoffs. Now the four-time champion needs to win one more to avoid failing to qualify for a third straight time. The Azzurri beat Northern Ireland 2-0 in the European semifinals on Thursday. Sandro Tonali broke the deadlock with a half-volley early in the second half for Italy at home in Bergamo and then set up another goal for Moise Kean. "After taking the lead, we cleared our minds," Italy coach Gennaro Gattuso said. "We put in a good performance. This should be a confidence boost for Tuesday. Ah, we have to win. We have no other choice." Also advancing to the playoff finals scheduled for Tuesday were Bosnia and Herzegovina, Sweden, Poland, Turkey, Kosovo, Denmark and the Czech Republic. Italy next visits Bosnia and Herzegovina needing another victory to

reach the upcoming tournament in North America and avoid going at least 16 years without even playing a match at soccer's biggest event. Bosnia beat Wales, and the Czech Republic beat Ireland in penalty shootouts. The other finals matchups are: Sweden vs. Poland; Turkey vs. Kosovo; and Denmark vs. the Czech Republic. Italy was eliminated by Sweden over two winless legs in the playoffs for the 2018 World Cup then was stunned by North Macedonia in the semifinal round in 2022. Italy's World Cup struggles go back all the way to 2010 and 2014, having failed to advance from its group on both occasions. The Azzurri's last World Cup knockout match was when they won the title in 2006 by beating France in a penalty shootout. Italy produced seven shots on goal while Northern Ireland had none. For the second goal, Tonali's cross-field pass set up Kean, who made an expert control and finish.

Lydia Ko posts career-low 60 and only leads by 1 shot in LPGA's Phoenix stop

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Phoenix (USA)

Lydia Ko opened with four straight birdies and never stopping rolling Thursday until she closed out the best round of her LPGA Tour career with two more birdies for a 12-under 60 on a day of extreme low scoring in the Ford Championship. Defending champion Hyo Joo Kim had a 61, making it the first time since the 2003 Kellogg-Keebler Classic two players were double digits under par in the opening round. "I don't think I've ever actually started a round with four birdies, so it was nice to take advantage of the good start and continue that on my



back nine," Ko said. "I think like as every golfer, when things go well you also think about the things that could go terribly wrong. I feel like I stayed patient and was rolling it really well." A moderate start to her

13th season came to life on the Cattail course at Whirlwind Golf Club when the 28-year-old Ko got into a rhythm after a rare putter change and started piling up the birdies. She said the idea of 59 — Annika Sorenstam has

the only sub-60 round in LPGA history, 25 years ago on a different course in Phoenix — entered her thinking when she birdied her 14th and 15th holes of the round after starting on No. 10. But she didn't hit a 7-foot birdie putt firmly enough on the par-5 seventh. Ko finished with two more birdies for her career low round. "That would have been nice to hole that one," Ko said. "But who knows? Maybe if I holed that one I might not have holed the other two. You can't think about what if? Birdied some other ones that I didn't expect, so kind of just ends out in that sense." It was the ninth round of 60 or lower on the LPGA, the

most recent by Lucy Li at Pinnacle Country Club in Arkansas in 2024. Kim also started on No. 10 and shot 28 on the front nine, finishing birdie-eagle-birdie, including a hole-out from the fairway on the par-4 eighth hole. Nelly Korda, who opened the year with a 54-hole win in Florida and was runner-up last week in California, holed out from the 18th fairway for eagle in the middle of her round and shot 63, one of her career best. She was three shots behind. They all played in the morning and no one caught them in the afternoon, when temperatures were pushing 100 degrees (38 Celsius). Frida Kinhult of Sweden had a 64, the low

score of the afternoon. Jeeno Thitikul, the No. 1 player in women's golf, opened with a 69. The big surprise for Ko was not so much her score but the equipment she uses. The Kiwi rarely tinkers with her putter but decided to switch to a different model earlier this week. "It's been a while since I have tried a different model," Ko said of her Scotty Cameron 12 she used at Whirlwind. "It just rolled good." Went in the bag on Tuesday. This has only been one round but it's a good start. You know, really couldn't have been any better." Ko was among six players from the morning wave who shot 65 or better.

Japanese GP will be the last for 5 weeks

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Suzuka (Japan)

The Japanese Grand Prix (GP) is only the third race of the new Formula 1 season, but it will be the last one for five weeks with events in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia called off because of the war in Iran. The next F1 race is not until May 3 in Miami. Here's what we've learned so far from races in Australia and China with the Japanese GP set for Sunday: Mercedes and Ferrari have adapted best to Formula 1's most radical change in power and chassis in more than a decade. George Russell and Kimi Antonelli have won each of the first two races, and

Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton and Charles Leclerc have flip-flopped finishing third and fourth. Mercedes and Ferrari are the favourites on Suzuka's figure-eight circuit, located in central Japan and among F1's most storied venues. Suzuka is a vastly different circuit from Australia — a street course in Melbourne — and Shanghai, which resembles many of the newer Formula 1 venues. Suzuka is old-school — narrow, twisting with only one major straight-away for passing. Hamilton has won the Japanese GP five times, four times at Suzuka as he surges back near the top of the standings after two races. **McLaren's woes:** McLaren has



struggled after winning last season's drivers' championship with Lando Norris, and adding the constructors' title for good measure. But McLaren failed to even start the race two weeks ago in China with engine and elec-

trical faults. Asked on Thursday if the problem had been resolved, Norris replied, "I think it took a little bit of time to figure things out, but yes. Of course it hurt us as a team, certainly didn't make us look good to have two cars not starting a race." Norris talked up the team which includes Oscar Piastri. It had the best car on the grid in the last two seasons, having won the constructors' title each time. "Now is just as good a time as ever to prove exactly what we can do as a team — against Ferrari, against Mercedes, who are performing very well at the minute," Norris said.

Bolivia rallies past Suriname to reach World Cup playoff final against Iraq

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Monterrey (Mexico)

Moises Paniagua and Miguel Terceros scored goals within a seven-minute span in the second half, and Bolivia rallied to beat Suriname 2-1 on Thursday to qualify for the final of the World Cup qualifying playoff against Iraq. Liam Van Gelderen put Suriname ahead in the 48th minute but Paniagua tied the score at the 72nd and Terceros had the winning goal in the 79th minute for the Bolivians, who are aiming for their second World Cup appearance. "I want to highlight the players' character in never



giving up; it's a team that never considers anything lost and that today knew how to pull through," said Bolivia's coach Oscar Villegas. The Bolivians have only previously played in the 1994 World Cup in the United States. Suriname was looking to qualify for the first time. Bolivia, which finished in seventh place in the CONMEBOL qualifiers, will play Iraq next Tuesday in Monterrey. The winner will qualify for Group I with France, Norway and Senegal.

Focusing on versatility, says Sai Sudharsan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Sai Sudharsan is prioritising versatility over high strike-rates heading into the IPL, as the Gujarat Titans opener returns from a rib-cage injury, having worked on his game to upgrade skills after a rough red-ball stint with the Indian Test team. The 24-year-old, who won the 'Orange Cap' with 759 runs at a strike-rate of around 145 last IPL season, didn't have a great time with the Indian Test team, aggregating 302 runs from six Test at a below-par average of 27.45. While he got a couple of half-centuries in 11 Test innings, by and large his performance was underwhelming. "I think I was grateful enough for the experience. First thing, I am not looking at it as a low or I am not looking at it as a fail because it has shown me what I have to improve," Sudharsan told PTI in an interview ahead of the 19th edition of the Indian Premier League. Playing for

India has been an eye opener of sorts for the batter. "It has shown me what I have to work on and grind when I go forward in Test cricket. So, I am not thinking of it as a failure. I am thinking it has given me an opportunity to work on more things and it is helping me to evolve. "And obviously, it has made me believe in myself more," the genial southpaw said. Sudharsan endured a torrid time towards the end of the last season as he didn't have big scores against South Africa and then sustained a rib cage injury while playing in the Vijay Hazare Trophy. He got a two-month break, and he turned adversity into an opportunity as he got time to work on his skills along with his childhood coach Jayakumar. "Emotionally, I am not looking at it as a very low space or very difficult times because I've gotten an opportunity to work on my body and work on my batting," Sudharsan gave his perspective.

IPL 2026: RCB look to regroup, CSK, KKR, MI hunt lost glory

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Besieged defending champions seeking to regroup after an unprecedented tragedy, decorated sides chasing lost glory, two stalwarts fighting for relevance and a clutch of hopefuls eager to impress, the 2026 IPL, starting Saturday, is poised to offer intriguing moments over the next two months. Title holders Royal Challengers Bengaluru, who host Sunrisers Hyderabad at the Chinnaswamy Stadium in the tournament opener, would have liked to enter the league's 19th edition with a lot more swag and pomp. But an austere atmosphere surrounds the match, as the memory of 11 fans who

lost their lives in the June 4 stampede outside the stadium during the team's title celebration dominates the lead-up to the match. The Karnataka State Cricket Association and RCB management have also taken steps to keep the unfortunate souls' memory alive. The KSCA announced leaving 11 permanent empty seats in the stadium, which itself had to go through a few uncertain months before the receiving necessary permissions from state government authorities to host the IPL matches. RCB players would wear jerseys printed No. 11 on their back during the practice session on the first match-day. While these are hugely appreciable measures, cricket on the ground often



transcends such emotions and empathetic symbols. It does not require any trained eyes to understand that both RCB and Sunrisers are thin on bowling resources after missing key players. RCB will be without the metronomic Josh Hazlewood and left-arm seamer Yash Dayal. Both played significant roles in their triumphant campaign in 2025, but will be absent this year owing to various reasons. Hazlewood is completing his rehabilitation process in Australia and might join the squad at a later stage. Dayal, who is facing sexual abuse allegations, will sit

Compound archers dominate with mixed team gold, clean sweep in men's individual

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bangkok

Indian compound archers delivered a dominant performance, clinching the mixed team gold and women's team silver, while also sweeping the men's individual podium at the Asia Cup-World Ranking Tournament Stage 1 on Friday. With the addition of the individual medals, India's overall tally swelled to two gold, two silver and four bronze medals, matching their eight-medal haul from the previous edition. The Indian contingent also remained in contention in two more finals later in



the day — women's recurve individual (Ridhi Phor) and men's recurve team as they are all set to surpass the tally of the 2025 Stage 1 event held here. The highlight of the day was a clean sweep in the men's compound individual section, where Uday Kamboj

rience to drill in three perfect arrows in the final end to down local favourite Peerawat Rattanapongkiat 145-144 in a tense bronze playoff. The 31-year-old former World Championships silver medalist had a two-point deficit after three ends. Chauhan overturned the deficit in the fourth end where he dropped just one point while Peerawat slipped to 27 points, shooting in the '8-ring'. Locked 115-all heading into the final end, Chauhan struck three perfect 10s to seal the match by a solitary point to earn India's fourth bronze medal.

Kabaddi camp for Asian Games to be held in Bellary



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bellary (Karnataka)

Several prominent Kabaddi players from the men's and women's sections, including Naveen Kumar, Pawan Sehrawat, Arjun Deshwal and Sonali Vishnu Shingate, will take part in a high-performance strength and conditioning camp for probable athletes ahead of the Asian Games in Japan later this year. The camp, scheduled from March 27 to April 2, aims to strengthen India's kabaddi ecosystem, with a focused approach to athlete development, fitness optimisation, and long-term performance excellence. They are the defending champions in both men's and women's kabaddi at the Asian Games. "Naveen Kumar, Arjun Deshwal, Pawan Sehrawat, Aslam Inamdar, Sunil Kumar, Ashu Malik, and Bharat Hooda are part of the camp (in the men's section).

Impact Sub a good innovation: RCB head coach Flower

G UNNIKRIISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

The Impact Sub rule might have vertically divided the opinion of players and pundits but Royal Challengers Bengaluru head coach Andy Flower on Friday termed it a "good innovation" as it offers tactical flexibility to teams in the IPL. Leading voices such as India's Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill and former captain Rohit Sharma thought the Impact Sub rule takes the skill out of the game. "I think it has been a good innovation, it's interesting to be part of it. You're making decisions on the impact player, and I think it's interesting for the audience to debate what's right and



what's wrong, so tactically it's quite an interesting addition to the game," Flower said on the eve of IPL's 2026 season-opener against Sunrisers Hyderabad. At the same time, Flower also said the Impact Player rule makes the decision making a bit tricky for the coaching staff. "I must say

that one of the things I love about cricket is that when you select an 11, one of the challenges you have is balancing your 11 - the length of the batting order, balancing, perhaps, some guys that can't feel that well and it's one of the things that makes selection a little bit tricky. "The impact player rule

hides that selection problem a little, so I think one of the great things about cricket is some of the debates around selection and when you select single-skilled players, you weaken another area of your game, the impact player can hide that, so there are pros and cons I think to it," he added. From an RCB perspective, deciding on the 11 can be a bit of a hustle because of the non-availability of lead pacer Josh Hazlewood. Hazlewood, who was RCB's top wicket-taker in IPL 2025, landed in Bengaluru on Thursday night but Flower said the management is keeping a close watch on the Australian's fitness. "Hazlewood did arrive yesterday, he's looking fit. I did comment to him that he looks even younger than I remember. So, he's enjoyed some good down time but he's worked hard to get himself back up to full fitness, we've been liaising closely with Cricket Australia on his fitness. So, it's great to have him in our dressing room and in the meetings. "But he won't be ready for tomorrow, he's just got off the plane, but we'll be monitoring his fitness very closely and looking forward to him making his entrance into the IPL," he said. Flower, however, hoped that the backup options will cover-up for Hazlewood's absence in the interim. "Yash (Dayal) is not with us this unfortunately. (PTI)

On May 31st, we will be playing at Chinnaswamy and lifting trophy: Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Having fallen short in the 2025 IPL final, Shashank Singh is confident Punjab Kings will go all the way and lift the coveted trophy on May 31 at the Chinnaswamy stadium in Bengaluru this season. Punjab Kings had scripted a stirring run to reach the final after a decade-long wait, only to fall agonisingly short, going down by six runs to Royal Challengers Bengaluru in the title clash. "I know that on May 31st, we will be playing at the Chinnaswamy and lifting the cup. It's not just a feeling, I know this. This will happen," Shashank said on Friday. "It's the self belief and team belief. Everyone is on the same page. There is confidence in everyone."



PBKs enjoyed a stellar campaign last season, topping the league stage with nine wins from 14 matches before beating Mumbai Indians in Qualifier 2 to book a place in the final. Asked how they plan to repeat last year's performance all over again, Shashank said, "We will take it match by match because ultimate aim is to get a trophy. "If we keep thinking we reached the final last year, there will be a lot of pressure on us. So our immediate aim is to prepare for our first game against GT, then against CSK and KKR," Shashank said on 'JioStar Press Room'. The Shreyas Iyer-led, Ricky Ponting-coached team has retained 21 players from its

2025 squad, keeping the core set of players intact. "To play the final and win is the ultimate goal. But we have to focus on every match, rectify our mistakes that will be easier. We are very motivated and excited that we are the same group. We are better prepared than last year." Having adapted to a lower middle-order role at PBKS, the 34-year-old said embracing the responsibility has been key to his growth. "It's important to love the role. Earlier I also used to think I am a top-order batter and I have been thrown down the order. But then I fell in love with the role. "The most important thing to prosper in this role is to get the backing (of the team management and dressing room) because you need freedom to play high risk cricket." Talking about his preparation, he said, personal goals will be secondary this season. "It is more a mental game than skill game during the IPL. The past year didn't go well for me as I had a spate of injuries and I couldn't play competitive cricket much.

Hardik, Navneet win Hockey India Player of the Year awards

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Star midfielder Hardik Singh and striker Navneet Kaur on Friday won the Hockey India Player of the Year awards in the men's and women's categories respectively. The players were honoured during a glittering ceremony in the capital that celebrated the finest performers over the past one year. Former India captain and a member of the 1980 Moscow

Olympics gold medal-winning team, Zafar Iqbal, was bestowed with the Major Dhyan Chand Lifetime Achievement Award. Hardik and Navneet were honoured with the coveted Balbir Singh Sr Award for Player of the Year 2025 that includes a cash reward of ₹20 lakh each. Iqbal, who also won two silver medals at the Asian Games in 1978 and 1982 along with a bronze medal at the 1982 Champions Trophy, was



honoured with a cash reward of ₹25 lakh for his contribution to Indian hockey. The Balbir Singh Award for Goalkeeper of the Year went to the women team's Bichu Devi Kharibam, while the Pargat Singh Award for Defender of the Year was bagged by Sanjay, both the accolades carrying a cash reward of ₹5 lakh each. Hockey India Ajit Pal Singh Award for Midfielder of the Year was won by Sanjay, while the Dhanraj Pillay Award for Forward of the Year was col-

lected by Sukhjeet Singh. Both the players got richer by ₹5 lakh each. Hockey India Asunta Lakra Award for Upcoming Player of the Year (Women, U-21) was bagged by Sakshi Rana, while young goalkeeper Prince Deep Singh, who was an integral part of last year's Junior World Cup bronze medal-winning side, won the Jugraj Singh Award for Upcoming Player of the Year in U-21 men's category. Both took home ₹10 lakh each. Earlier in

the day, Raghu Prasad RV was honoured for being named the FIH Umpire of the Year for 2025, while Ishika was recognised for scoring a goal on her debut against Uruguay during the FIH World Cup 2026 Qualifiers in Hyderabad. Deepika was recognised for winning the Poligras Magic Skill Award, while Abhishek was honoured for being named Player of the Tournament at the Asia Cup Rajgir, Bihar 2025.